The Launch Pad - Three Years

The guide's books for Origin, The Forge, and The Helm (written so a learner can read every page)

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The Origin Year - Lesson Plan Book

A guide's book for Year One of the Launch Pad, written so a learner can read every page.

Opening note

This is the guide's book for the first year of the Launch Pad, the year called Origin. It holds the whole plan: the shape of the year, the seven sessions, the week-by-week flow, the things a guide might say, and the ways we keep everyone safe. It is written for the guide to teach from. It is also written so that any learner can pick it up and read the whole thing.

That last part is a rule, not an accident. Here is the rule, and it holds on every page:

Everything in this book is safe and honest for a learner to read. Nothing in it manages or manipulates anyone. Lines in "quotes" are things a guide might say aloud. Everything else is for the guide to understand and hold.

There is no hidden chapter. There is no page that says "here is how to get the reluctant kid to do the thing." A guide's notes here are transparent and kind. If a learner reads a note about themselves, they should feel respected, not handled. That is the whole point of the year, so it is the whole point of the book too.

One author's note on language: this book was written by Erin Stanley, who opened the studio. "The guide" means whoever is leading the studio, and this book says "they" throughout, because that will not always be the same person. "You" sometimes means the guide and sometimes means the learner - the context always makes it clear which.

Part 1 - For everyone: what this year is

The year's question

Origin asks one question, all year: **Who am I?**

That is it. Not "who should you be," not "who do we need you to become." Just the honest, enormous question of who you already are and who you are turning into. Everything this year is a way of walking around that question and looking at it from a new side.

Origin is the first of three years. The three years each carry their own question:

- **Origin - Who am I?** (Know your story.)
- **The Forge - What is worth solving?** (Find your work.)
- **The Helm - What do I do when there is no easy answer?** (Make the hard call, and love the life around it.)

Origin comes first in the telling because a story is the ground the other two years stand on. It is not a prerequisite. The three years turn as a cycle rather than a ladder: whichever year is running when you arrive is the one you start in, and you are not behind. A learner who starts at The Forge asks what is worth solving with the story they already have, and comes to Origin later with more of it. Nobody here is catching up to anybody.

The journey (the year's arc, plain)

The year is built like a story with a beginning, a middle, and an end.

You start by dreaming with no ceiling. You look at where you come from and the people who made you. You practice the muscle of choosing, and then the muscle of running your own days. Then, in the long middle of the year, you write your whole life down, all of it, unedited. After that you become the author of it, shaping it into something you can hold. And at the very end, you make a piece that says "this is me," and you show it to your people.

Named plainly, the seven sessions are:

1. **The Map of Me** - dream 100 dreams and start naming what you want.
2. **The Lineage** - gather the stories of where you come from.
3. **The Power of Choice** - practice choosing on purpose.
4. **Running My Own Ship** - build a routine that fits you.

5. **The Full Draft** - write your whole life, unshaped.
6. **Chapter One** - become the author and shape it.
7. **This Is Me / The Unveiling** - make a self-portrait and show it.

The year rhymes from end to end: you dream it, you draft it, you shape it, you declare it.

The words this book uses

This studio has its own small vocabulary. None of it is a secret, so here it all is, before you meet any of it.

- **A quest.** One piece of work with a beginning and an end: a prompt, an interview, a making, a share. It is the unit you can say no to.
- **A session.** One of the year's seven stretches, each with its own question. Three to six weeks long, with a break after it.
- **The settle.** The three slow breaths that open every guide day.
- **The way down.** Standing up and shaking it out after hard work, so your body can put the stress down.
- **The exit ramp.** The named place you can step out to, without asking, and come back from with nothing said.
- **The closing minute.** The three private questions at the end of an opening. Never written for the studio, never read by anyone.
- **The Work of the Day.** The one piece of the session's work the whole tribe does together that morning, named out loud at the start so you know what the day is for. One per guide day.
- **Your tribe.** The people in this studio with you.
- **The walk-in.** The soft first twenty-five minutes of a guide day, when the door is open and nothing is required. The guide will come to one or two people for a quiet talk inside it. Nothing said in one is written down.
- **The interval.** A your-own day with nothing asked back: one question to carry, nothing to hand in. It is named out loud so you know the quiet is on purpose.
- **The close-return.** The words the room says out loud after a heavy day, so your body hears that the heavy part is over. Always the same words; they are on the settle page.
- **Fallow.** Deliberately empty. Fallow is a farming word: a fallow field is one you leave unplanted on purpose, because that is what makes it rich again. Fridays are fallow, and so is one whole week in the autumn. Never earned, never filled.
- **A harvest.** The last stretch of a session, where you gather what the weeks grew and name what you got. An empty harvest is a real harvest.
- **Witnessed.** Someone was there and saw it. Not watched, not assessed. Being witnessed is a gift and never a demand.

- **A re-thread.** Picking the year back up after a break. The first guide day back starts with it: where were you, where are you now, what came back changed. You are never restarting cold.
- **The pace question.** The guide asking whether the plan still matches the speed your real life is running at.
- **The re-ask.** The guide asking, out loud, *is this still yours?* It means: do you still choose to be here, doing this.
- **Open Waters.** The loose three weeks after the Unveiling: expeditions, your own projects, credit close-out, and real rest.

One word needs a line of its own, because it does two jobs. A **harvest** is the gathering at a session's end, and it is yours. The Vineyard is the one thing in this year that is never harvested, and that is exactly what makes it the Vineyard.

What you make and carry

The Captain's Log. This year you begin one artifact you will carry through all three years: your Captain's Log. It is a record of your own life and your own thinking. You name it yourself. You write in it however you write. It belongs to you, completely. A guide never reads it to grade you or check up on you. The moment a private log becomes something someone else reads to judge you, it stops being yours, and this one stays yours. You will carry it out the door when you leave, and no copy is kept.

The Vineyard. On the very first day, alongside the Log, you name one more thing: a part of your week that is just yours to love. A thing you tend because you love it, and that no one will ever ask you what it was *for*.

What it can be. Almost anything. The list below is deliberately a mess, because there is no right kind of thing:

- an instrument you are slowly getting better at, or one you are not getting better at
- a trail you walk, or a bus route you like riding
- bread. Or a knife you keep sharp, or an engine, or a sewing machine
- a game, including one on a screen
- a friendship you put real time into
- a language nobody in your family speaks
- drawing the same thing over and over
- birds
- a project with no end date and no plan
- lying on the floor and listening to one album all the way through

Some of those sound impressive and some sound like nothing. **That is the point.** This is not a list to choose from, and there is no version of this that counts for more. If your honest answer is the album on the floor, that is a Vineyard, and nobody here will rank it against somebody's violin.

Why this is in a school book at all. The rest of this year asks hard things of you. You will write your whole life down, look at your worst day, and show yourself to a room full of your people. That is one half of what this place is for. The other half is sitting in the third year's question, The Helm: *make the hard call, and love the life around it*. The Vineyard is where that second half lives, starting now rather than in three years. It is not a reward for the hard work, and it is not a break from it. It is the other half of the work, and it is given its own ground precisely so that nothing can quietly turn it into the first half.

It is never made useful. It is never harvested. It is never turned into an assignment. Nobody grades it, reports on it, counts it, or asks you to reflect on it. If a guide ever adds a "Vineyard reflection prompt," the whole thing is dead, so no one will. The moment it becomes useful it stops being a Vineyard.

When, and this is the one part that is required. Making time for something you love is a requirement of this programme. Not a particular thing, not a certain number of hours, and not anything you hand in. The requirement is that the time is in your week and that something you love is in the time.

That is deliberate, and it is not softness. A life with no un-useful joy in it is not what this place is trying to build you toward, and **finding the time is a skill, exactly like learning to hold your own hours.** Nobody drifts into it. People who have it protect it on purpose, and that is learnable, so we teach it.

In practice: Friday is already yours and is the obvious home. You name a Vineyard-thing in the first week. When you build your routine in Session 4, your Vineyard is in it, and a routine without it is not a finished routine. If your Vineyard-thing needs something that lives here, a workbench or a kiln or a piano or a quiet room, say so in the first week and the door is open to you on Fridays.

And the edge of it, which matters as much as the requirement. Nobody ever checks what you did with the time. Nobody signs in. Nobody is counted. Nobody asks how it went, and that includes the guide. The only question anyone will ever ask is *is the time there* - never what you made, never whether you got better at it, never whether you enjoyed it. It is the same deal as the Table: presence is the whole requirement, never consumption. The moment anyone asks the second kind of question the Vineyard is dead, and the rule against asking it is written as hard as the rules about safety.

The last of the promises says you may refuse the structure itself, and this is part of the structure. So you can refuse this too. What you cannot do is get the programme to stop offering it, or stop protecting the time, or stop asking whether the time is there. **The requirement binds us to keep making room for it. It does not bind you to fill the room.**

The Vineyard is the quiet twin of the Captain's Log. The Log is the self examined. The Vineyard is the self delighted. You carry both from the first morning, and both grow across all three years.

The promises (the six refusals)

Underneath everything, there is a floor of promises. Nothing in the Launch Pad is allowed to break these. In plain words:

1. **No grades or scores anyone but you can see.** Your progress is yours.
2. **No ranking and no leaderboards.** You are never stacked against the person next to you. There is no screen anywhere in the Compass that puts learners side by side. A parent linked to your account can see which of your own goals you have finished, and that is the whole of what anyone else sees. If that ever stops being exactly true, you will be told before it changes, not after.
3. **No one deposits the answers into you.** You make meaning here; the guide holds questions and walks with you, and does not hand you a finished you.
4. **No imposed deadlines.** You set your own pace. "I didn't get to it" is honored, not punished.
5. **Your worth is not your output.** A quest you abandoned and learned from counts as much as one you finished. Doing more does not make you worth more.
6. **No surveillance.** The data of your life belongs to you, not to the school.

And one more, which sits on top of the six:

You may refuse the structure itself. If you decline a whole quest, you are fully honored. You are not quietly marked down as a failure or an opt-out. Your no is real.

Where your no reaches, and where it stops

Here is the edge of that last promise.

Your no covers your own work. A quest, a prompt, an interview, a share, a whole session, this entire structure. It lands the moment you say it, it costs you nothing, and nobody can overrule it.

It does not cover how you treat the people in the room with you. That is not a deadline and it is not output. It is the floor that makes everything else here safe for six other people, and it is the one place in this programme where something can actually be taken from you. The studio's agreements run that floor, and they have their own ladder. You will meet it in your first week, and you will help write the agreements it rests on. Here is the whole of it, said now rather than when you are standing in it:

- **A Pause.** Step out, settle, come back when you are ready. A council member meets you. The count runs across the day, and a third in one day is a Stop.
- **A Stop.** Home for the day, with a note that goes home and that you fill out with your guide. Stops carry across days.
- **A Strike**, at three Stops. One guide day at home, never your Friday. Your character contract goes home to work on with your family, and when you come back you, your family, Jenna and your guide talk it through. Your Stops reset. A second Strike is at least two guide days, and you come back when you and your family both say the commitment is real.
- **Step Away**, at three Strikes. Not back for the rest of the year, with a real conversation long before anyone is near it, and a way to re-apply the next year.

That is the top of the ladder and the bottom of it. Nothing about it is a surprise, and nothing about it is hidden in a document you are not allowed to read.

So, in one line: **the agreements are about how we treat each other. The promises are about whether you do the work.**

Declining a quest is never a Pause. A Pause is never a judgement on your work, your pace, or whether you are keeping up. If anyone ever runs those two together, they have got it wrong, and you can say so out loud and point at this page.

And if you do not sign. You are in the room anyway, and that was never the price of being here. The agreements still run for you. They are not holding you to your word, because you did not give it. They are holding the room safe for the people in it with you. You can tell us the agreements are not yours. You cannot be outside the floor, because **the floor is not about you.**

How we work: the week

The studio day runs through the morning, 9:00 to 1:00. Across the week, two mornings are guide days and two are your own.

- **Guide days (Tuesday and Thursday).** The guide runs the studio with you. The order of the morning is below, and it is the same every time.

- **Your-own days (Monday and Wednesday).** You run your own morning: your reading, your core academics (the high-school credit work you have claimed, at your own pace), your personal project, and the session's writing. Nobody is steering but you. The guide is in the building, at Vibrant Life Tots with the younger children from 9:15 to 11:30, and then the guide comes to you around noon for a real check-in. Same site, different room. If you need them before noon, you go and get them. You are genuinely running your own hours and you are never actually alone in the building. Both of those are true at once.
- **The fallow day (Friday).** Protected. Never earned, never filled, never converted back into work. It is for rest, play, friendship, and making things for no reason. This is not a reward for finishing. It is practice for a whole life. And it is binding: it does not get eaten to cover a busy week.

A guided morning, start to finish

Guide days run 9:00 to 1:00. The order is the same every single time, so you never walk in wondering what today is.

Time	What happens
9:00 - 9:25	**The walk-in.** Door open, nothing required. Put your things down, make tea, talk or don't. The guide is here and will come find one or two people for a quiet one-to-one.
9:25 - 9:35	**The settle, then the circle.** Three breaths, the same words every time. Then one round of "how are you, really?" You may pass.
9:35 - 10:50	**The Work of the Day.** The session's main work. This is the part that changes week to week. The rest of this table does not.
10:50 - 11:00	**The way down.** Stand, shake it out, step outside, water. Then we eat.
11:00 - 11:40	**The Table.** We eat together. You bring your own lunch.
11:40 - 12:40	**Hands and each other.** Making, cooking, building, fixing, an errand into the world, a project with somebody else. Different from the morning's work on purpose: the body works and the talking gets easy.
12:40 - 1:00	**The close.** One light thing, then your closing minute, then you go.

The times are honest rather than strict. Most days drift ten minutes. The order never drifts.

The Table

Every guide day has a shared meal in the middle of it. Here is exactly how it goes.

You bring your own lunch. On ordinary days the studio does not provide the food.

It is still a shared table rather than a lunch break. We stop, sit down together, and the guide sits and eats with you. The forty minutes is for being a group of people who eat together, not for getting through food on the way to the next thing.

You sit wherever you want. Seats are not assigned, and nobody's seat is kept from last week.

You do not have to eat. Presence is the whole requirement here, never consumption. If you are fasting, or observing, or not hungry, or food is a hard thing for you right now, you sit with us and that is full participation. Nobody watches anybody's plate, and you never owe anyone an explanation for what is or is not on yours.

If you arrive late, come in and sit down. Nothing restarts, and nobody asks where you were in front of the room.

On the two days a year when there *is* shared food, the family-story potluck in the autumn and the feast in May, tell the guide what you cannot eat, once, whenever you know it. Planning around it is the guide's job rather than yours to work around. On those two days the studio provides the base of the meal, and bringing a dish is never required. If you want what the studio brings to stand as yours, say so to the guide once, privately, and it will. Nobody at the table will know the difference, and nobody will ask.

The circle: "how are you, really?"

Right after the settle, every guide day, we go around once. The question is "how are you, really?" and it means the real answer rather than the automatic one.

Here is how it goes. The guide asks, and answers first, honestly and briefly. Then it goes around in order, so nobody is picked on and nobody has to volunteer. One or two sentences each is plenty. "Tired." "Good, actually." "I don't want to say today." Those are complete answers.

You can always pass. Say "pass" and it moves on, with no follow-up and no note taken. Passing is not a smaller answer. A person who passes has been round the circle the same as everyone else.

Nobody fixes what you say here unless you ask. Advice that arrives unasked is not help, so the circle starts from being heard.

But you can ask, and you can ask the room. “Does anyone know what to do about this?” is a completely normal thing to say in a circle, and so is “I just wanted to say it, I don’t want to talk about it.” Both are answers to the same question, and the question is yours: **do you want this held, or do you want it worked?** Say which and the room will follow you. Six people who know you is not a smaller resource than one guide, and some things a sixteen-year-old knows better than any adult in the building.

If you would rather not ask in front of everyone, that is equally fine. Say so, or say nothing and catch the guide afterwards.

It takes a few minutes. It is not a check-up, and nothing said in it is written down.

Who else is in the room

There are a handful of you and one of me. On guide days my baby is in the studio with us, usually in a carrier on my front. That is the honest shape of this year: you get a guide who is also a parent, in a room where a baby naps and eats and sometimes cries. Some mornings I will be holding a child while we talk.

Two things follow from that, and you should know both before you say yes. First, there will be minutes when my hands are full and the room carries itself for a bit. Second, if you ever need all of me - a hard day, or a conversation that cannot be interrupted - there is a named person who takes the baby. Then I am entirely yours. That handoff is arranged before the year opens. It is not improvised on the day.

Arriving late, stepping out, coming back

Arriving late. Walk in. There is no procedure and nothing restarts. If the circle is going, join where it has got to, or pass. If the settle is going, sit down and pick it up on the next breath. Nobody will ask you in front of the room where you were. If something made you late and you want the guide to know, catch them at the Table.

Coming back after stepping out. The soft parts of the day are named so you know where the easiest way back in is: the walk-in, the Table, and the hands block after it. You can come back at any moment, including the middle of a hard one. The soft seams are just the ones where nothing has to be said at all. Nobody says anything to you when you come back. Not even “glad you’re back.” You pick up a plate or pick up a tool and you are in.

The Log, captured however you hold it

You keep the Captain's Log in whatever form is true to you. Written in a notebook. Spoken aloud and recorded. Drawn. Dictated. Typed. Told to a scribe who writes it down for you. No form is the lesser Log. The point is that you are keeping your own record, not that it looks a certain way.

Where it lives. Your Log can go home with you, or stay here somewhere only you open, or both, and you can change your mind any time. If you want it to stay here, say so and nobody asks why. It is not kept in the Compass or on any school computer, and no copy is made, because the moment there is a copy somebody else is holding your life.

When you write in it. There is no Log time and nobody will ever call one. Here is where the room has room for it, and all of these are open rather than expected:

- **The walk-in**, the first twenty-five minutes of a guide day. Nothing is required then, so if you came in with something on your mind, that is the place to put it down before the day starts asking things of you. Some people need to write before they can talk, and the walk-in sits before the circle on purpose.
- **Right after your closing minute**, at the end of a guide day. This is the natural one. The closing minute hands you exactly the kind of thing the Log is for, and you are already quiet and already finished. Some people say the three answers under their breath and then write them down; some write something else entirely; some write nothing.
- **Your own mornings**, Monday and Wednesday. Your block, your call, no check-in about it.
- **Friday**, if you want it. Friday is also a fine day to deliberately not write. A record you have to feed every day stops being a record and becomes a chore, and **there are supposed to be days you skip.** Weeks, even. A Log with gaps in it is not a failed Log; it is what an honest one looks like.

One rule about this, and it is for the guide as much as you: **nobody writes on a bell.** We will never all sit down and write at the same time, because the moment that happens, everyone can see who is writing and who is not, and the only thing that makes this yours is that nobody is watching. Your Log is private in what it says and private in whether you touched it today.

How "no" works here

You may decline anything. **Your no takes effect the moment you say it, and it is not conditional on explaining yourself.** This is called **decline-with-reasoning**.

You can say no to any quest, any prompt, any interview, any share, and the no lands straight away. Nothing is held up while you find words.

The reasoning is still owed. Two things about that, and they matter equally. **It is owed to your tribe, not to the guide** - you are in a room with other people whose work and plans move around yours, so they get to know where you stand. It is not a toll you pay an adult for permission. And **it is not owed in the moment.** "I don't know yet, and I'll come back to you" is a real answer. Take a day. Take the week. Work it out in your Log first and come back when you have it. A reason you had to produce on the spot is not thinking, it is pressure.

The guide may ask you an honest, curious question about it, the way a friend might. But the guide **has a voice, never a veto.** The guide cannot overrule your reason, and cannot require you to have one ready. The question is a mirror, not a test you can fail.

There is one place where even the curious question is set aside: anything to do with official papers and government forms. There, an honest reason for declining might reveal something private about your legal situation that a guide has no business knowing. So on that one surface, your no needs no reason at all.

The settle

Every guide day opens with a short, body-first way in, and there is a matching way down when something gets heavy. This is fixed, and it is yours to keep for life.

- **The way in (the Settle).** Three slow breaths with the out-breath longer than the in-breath (roughly four counts in, six counts out), feet flat, one hand where you feel your breath. The guide paces it out loud, the same way every time. The out-breath is what tells your body it is safe to settle. No app, no playlist, no special frequency. Just a human voice, used the same way on purpose.
- **The way down.** After hard work stirs the body up, you stand, shake it out, take a short walk, move the activation *through* the body before sitting back down. If standing or walking is not yours, any movement that is - shaking out your hands, rolling your shoulders, rocking - does the same work. A body cannot work off a stress spike sitting still. This is thirty seconds to a few minutes, and it comes before the shared meal, because a body still buzzing cannot take a meal as welcome.

- **The way out (the exit ramp).** There is a named place you can step out to, set up in the first week. You do not have to ask. And there is a designed way back in during a soft part of the day, with no scene, no acknowledgment demanded. Stepping out and coming back costs you nothing. This is the room holding a door open for you, never the room watching you for a fall.
- **The way back (the close-return).** After a day that went somewhere heavy, the room says out loud that the heavy part is over, so your body hears it and not just your head. These words do not change either:

  > *"That was then. This is now. Look around and name one thing you can see. You're in this room, and the hard part is behind you."*

  It sounds almost too simple to do anything. It works because a body that has been inside a hard memory for an hour does not automatically notice that the hour ended, and being told, in words, is how it notices. Solo version, for the rest of your life: *that was then, this is now, and I'm here.*

The closing minute

At the close of an opening - a dream named, a memory touched, a hard thing looked at - you take a quiet minute and cross back through three fixed questions. They are always the same, in the same order:

1. **What did I meet?**
2. **What do I carry back?**
3. **What's different in me now - even a little?**

That is the whole practice. It is spoken or held in your head, never written down for the studio, never read by anyone. It is yours.

Reach for the real answer. Taking the first thing that comes to mind and moving on makes this worth almost nothing. Staying in the question for a whole minute and letting something come up makes it worth a great deal, and **something almost always comes up, if you stay open long enough to hear it.** That takes a kind of nerve. It is the same nerve the rest of this year asks for, and it is the part of this practice that actually changes people. Going toward the hard thing on purpose is the whole skill.

“I don’t know yet” is a real answer - not because the question has no answer, but because sometimes the true one has not surfaced, and naming that beats manufacturing something to have said. “Nothing’s different, and I’m steadier for having looked” is also true and complete, because steadier is a change.

Nobody reads this, nobody asks about it, and no one can tell from the outside whether you reached or shrugged. **This is the one practice here that runs entirely on your own honour.**

The reason this exists: the year opens a lot of doors inside you. This is how you learn to close them yourself, so that when you are grown and something cracks you open, you already know the way home. The measure of it working is not a good answer. It is that you still use it years from now.

The one adult outside the room

There is one adult, outside the studio, you can always talk to. You will know who they are and how to reach them in the first week, before you ever need them.

A line about breaks. When the studio is on a break - the short ones between sessions, Thanksgiving, the two weeks at winter, and the summer - the guide is not reachable. A break is rest and reset for them too, and the book protects that the same way it protects your Friday. Two things stay open the whole time:

- **The one adult outside the room**, reachable across every break, the same as always.
- **988**, free, open all day and all night, call or text, from anywhere.

Nobody here will ever be upset that you used either one.

And this is the shape of privacy here, told to you on the first day rather than in the moment it starts to matter. Almost everything stays here. Your Captain’s Log, nobody reads. Your closing minute is never written down by anyone.

Here is what doesn’t. If the guide believes you are in danger, that someone is hurting or neglecting you, or that something is going on that is bigger than a studio morning can hold, they will bring in real help. That includes:

- talk of suicide or self-harm
- abuse or neglect
- something going wrong with eating
- a crisis with drugs or alcohol
- a panic or a flashback they cannot reach you through
- a threat to someone else
- something that keeps going and is getting in the way of your life

Those are two different things and they have different consequences, so both get named. **Abuse or neglect is a report**, and in Idaho the guide is required by law to make it. **Everything else on that list is a hand-off**, which means they stop the session work and help you get to someone trained, you will be told who, and you get a say in which one and when.

In most of those cases they will also call your parent or guardian, and they will tell you they are making the call. The one exception is if your parent or guardian is the person hurting you. Then the call goes to the state rather than to them.

That is the whole list. It is not one secret trapdoor, and the guide will never go looking for a reason to use it. **What they know is only what you chose to tell them.** None of this is breaking trust. It is what care actually looks like.

What gets written down about you

Short answer: very little, and you can read all of it.

- **Your Captain's Log and your Vineyard.** Yours. Nobody reads them. No copy is kept.
- **Your closing minute.** Never written down at all, by anyone.
- **Your witnessed work** - your dreams list, your Chapter One, your portfolio, your This Is Me piece. The guide sees what you bring into the room, and so do the people you choose to show. That is what bringing it means.
- **The guide's own notes.** A short practical record: attendance, your pace and your credit plan, and a factual note if there is ever a safety event, meaning what happened, what they did, and who they called. A safety note never contains what you wrote or said about your own life.
- **Your Growth Record, in the Compass.** The one record here that is built to leave with you. It works differently from everything else on this list, so it has its own section below.
- **The agreements record, if you ever reach a Stop.** Our studio agreements run on a ladder: a Pause, then a Stop, then a Strike. The Stop and the Strike are the two rungs that make paper. A Stop note says what happened and goes home the same day, you fill it out with your guide, and the line about coming back is yours in your own words. A Strike letter lists the dates of the three Stops. Your character contract is yours, in your handwriting, and a copy stays with Jenna while you are working it. All of it records a choice and never a judgement about who you are, the count clears at the start of each year, and none of it goes on a transcript or travels with your Growth Record.
- **What is never kept.** Scores. Rankings. Assessments of your character written by anyone but you. Any note about you that you have not read. Any file that follows you past this year.

You can ask to read anything written about you, at any time, and the guide will show you. If you think a note is wrong, say so, and it gets corrected. That includes a Pause, a Stop or a Strike: if you think a call was wrong, say so, and it can come off - off the note and off the count. You do not have to be calm about it. A learner who is angry at an unfair call is giving us information, not failing a condition.

That is the whole of it. “No surveillance” is a promise about this list, and the list is short on purpose.

The Growth Record, and whether any of this counts on paper

You are sixteen to eighteen, so a fair question about any year of your life is whether it counts on paper.

The Compass holds a record called your **Growth Record**, and the whole design of it is that you own it and the studio does not. The app is a lens, not a vault: you hold the keys from the first day, and a guide is a guest whose access ends when the relationship does. A school cannot lose, withhold or hold hostage a record it never held in the first place.

It has two faces, and you control which one anybody sees.

- **The Journey view** is the whole trail, in order, with the slow parts and the stalls in it. It stays private. It is yours.
- **The Portrait view** is the one you would hand a college, an employer or a programme. It is framed as what you can actually do, and **you choose what goes into it, piece by piece.** Nobody assembles your Portrait for you, and nobody sends it anywhere without you.

One rule holds across both, and it is built into the thing rather than promised about it: growth here is only ever shown as **movement compared to your own earlier self.** Never a grade. Never a score. Never set beside another learner.

And the honest limit, which you should hear from us rather than discover. The part that lets the record physically leave - a real export, readable by a human, held in your hands - **is not finished yet.** It is being built. Until it exists, nobody walks the Launch at the end of the three years, because a ceremony that hands you something that is not there is not a ceremony. That is a rule the programme put on itself before any learner was in the room.

Two more things. High-school credit is tracked separately, and it is the one record other people read as a routine matter, which is the honest exception to the first promise. And a transcript from a studio like this one is not yet a thing every college recognises; the bridge to dual enrollment is real work and we will do it alongside you rather than pretending it is already finished.

Part 2 - For the guide: teaching this year

The shape of the year, and naming the destination on day one

Origin runs the full Vibrant Life year, mid-August to late May, and it runs on the school's calendar rather than a tidy one of its own. Seven sessions with a break between each: thirty-one weeks of session work, plus the three-week Open Waters tail, for thirty-four program weeks in all. The sessions are **not** equal lengths. They are set by where the breaks fall.

Origin 2027-2028. A program week is Monday to Thursday. For the Launch Pad that means two guided mornings (Tuesday and Thursday), two the learners run themselves (Monday and Wednesday), and Friday fallow.

Session	Dates	Weeks
S1 The Map of Me	Aug 16 - Sep 9	4
session break	Sep 13 - 16	
S2 The Lineage	Sep 20 - Oct 21	5
session break	Oct 25 - 28	
S3 The Power of Choice	Nov 1 - Nov 18	3
Thanksgiving	Nov 22 - 26	
S4 Running My Own Ship	Nov 29 - Dec 16	3
Winter break	Dec 20 - 31	
S5 The Full Draft	Jan 3 - Feb 10	6
session break	Feb 14 - 17	
S6 Chapter One	Feb 21 - Mar 30	6
session break	Apr 3 - 6	
S7 This Is Me / The Unveiling	Apr 10 - May 4	4
Open Waters (flex tail)	May 8 - May 25	3

Four Mondays inside sessions are holidays: Labor Day in S1, the second Monday of October in S2, MLK Day in S5, and Presidents Day on S6's first day. A Monday here is a self-run morning rather than a guided one. The October holiday is Columbus Day on the federal calendar and Indigenous Peoples' Day by this programme's values; S2's watch-fors hold the naming. Two guide days in S3 are holidays too, Election Day and Veterans Day; whether the studio observes them is decided

before S3 opens. Each session's spine line in Part 3 carries its own. Nothing spans the winter breaks: S3 ends into Thanksgiving and S4 ends into the winter break, which is a real teaching and staffing fact you plan around rather than through.

Every session ends into a break, so every session carries the same two seams. On the last guided day, the carry-out: the pace question, the harvest, and the closing minute at session scale. On the first guided day back, the re-thread. The re-ask is rarer and is asked three times, where there is still time to act on the answer: at the winter break, after the Full Draft, and on the year-close day. The agreements are open for reopening at every session's close too - say so on the last guided day, every time, so the handle is real and not only promised in week one.

The break dates above are projected from the school's 2026-2027 calendar, which ran 17 August to 27 May with the same shape. Jenna sets the real ones; confirm before anything is printed for a family.

On day one, name the destination out loud. Say it plainly in the first week:

> *"In May, you'll show your people who you are - as much of it as you choose. We call it the Unveiling. Everything between now and then is getting ready to mean it."*

The mountain should be visible from the trailhead. A learner walks a long arc better when they can see where it is going.

The safety floor

You are running an examined-life year with teenagers, so the floor under it has to be real, seeded early, and grown as the year deepens. Four pieces:

The settle, the way-down, and the exit ramp. Described in full in Part 1 (the learner reads the same words you do). Teach them in the first week, with the framing that they are the learner's for life. **Fix your own wording for the settle in the first week, write it down, and then do not improve it.** If it starts feeling stale to you, that staleness is the thing working: it is stale to you because it has become automatic for them, which is the entire goal. Keep them fixed - same cadence, same anchor, same spoken cue, every guide day. The sameness is the medicine; a settle improvised freshly each day never becomes the reflex a body can drop into without thinking. Anchor the way-down especially at Session 5, where writing a whole life will activate bodies.

The closing minute. Also in Part 1. Teach it light and concrete in Origin. Model it out loud a few times, genuinely, then get out of the way and let it become the learner's private reflex. Name the close; never demand the content. "Take your closing minute" is the whole prompt.

How to push the reach when you cannot see the answer. This is the one practice you are asked to raise the bar on and are structurally unable to audit, so the pushing has to happen before the minute rather than after it. Two things do all the work.

Model a hard one out loud, early, and let it be slow. Not a tidy one. Do your own closing minute in front of them in the first weeks, including the part where you sit for twenty seconds and have nothing, and then say the thing you actually found. A learner who has watched an adult stay in a question past the comfortable point knows what reaching looks like. One where the adult always had a neat answer ready learns that the practice is a performance with a right length.

Put the standard in the invitation, never in the follow-up. "Take your closing minute" stays the whole prompt on the day. The place to say *go for the real one, something almost always comes up if you stay open long enough* is when you teach the practice, and at a session's close when you are talking about the practice rather than collecting its answers. Say it to the room, about the practice, never to a person about their minute.

And hold the line that makes the bar possible: **you still never ask what came up.** A raised bar with an audit attached is not a higher standard, it is a graded reflection, and the learner will start producing answers for you. The honour system is not the weak version of this. It is the only version that survives them leaving.

The circle, and holding "ask the room." Described in full in Part 1. One round, in order, pass always allowed, and you answer first so the register is set by you rather than by whoever is bravest. The part that needs your hands is the asking. A learner can ask the room for help with what they just said, and the room is often better at it than you are, so the work is not to answer first. It is to make sure the asking stays the learner's.

Three moves, and they are the whole job:

- **Default to held.** If nobody asked, nobody advises. When a learner says something hard and the room starts solving, stop it once, warmly, and out loud: "Hold on. Did you want ideas, or did you just want to say it?" Then do whatever they answer. Asking that question in front of everyone teaches the room the rule faster than any explanation.
- **Hand the room the question, not the answer.** When a learner does ask, your first move is "who's got something for that?" rather than your own best thought. You speak last or not at all. A guide who answers first has quietly told six people their experience is the backup option.
- **Close it when it is done.** Advice has a natural length and teenagers will overshoot it out of goodwill. "That's a good place to leave it, thank you" is the whole intervention, and it protects the person who asked from a room that is enjoying helping.

And watch the one that will actually happen: the learner who asks for help every single morning. That is not a circle problem, it is a learner telling you something, and it belongs in a walk-in rather than in a rule that narrows the circle for everybody.

When to reach for outside help (the referral pathway). You are a life-coach and mentor, not a licensed clinician. Sessions surface identity, memory, grief, and hard days by design, so clinical material will come up. Your job is not to treat it. It is to recognize it, hold the moment safely, and route it to real help fast.

Route now. Do not "work it in a session." Route if you see or hear any of these:

- any mention of suicide, self-harm, or not wanting to be here
- abuse, neglect, or someone hurting them
- a crisis happening right now: panic, a flashback, feeling cut off from their own body, or distress you cannot reach
- signs of something going wrong with eating
- a crisis with drugs or alcohol
- a threat to someone else
- something past an ordinary hard day: it keeps going, and it is getting in the learner's way

When in doubt, route. Being sure is a clinician's job, not yours.

In the moment:

- Stay with the learner. Never leave them alone in a crisis.
- Move to the quiet space you set up before the year opened. A real room or corner, not a hallway.
- Be present, calm, and listening.
- Do not fix it, do not ask for details, do not counsel.
- Do not promise secrecy you cannot keep.

Then name your own honest limit out loud. One guide has only so much capacity to hold a breakdown and the whole room at the same time. That limit is real, not a failing. It is exactly why there is a named list of trusted adults who can step in when you cannot hold both.

The second pair of hands. That list has one more line on it that must never stay blank: the person who takes the baby. A name, a current number, and a confirmed answer to "can you be here inside twenty minutes on a Tuesday morning." Read the instruction above again. "Stay with the learner and never leave them alone" and "move to the quiet space" both assume two free hands, and on guide days the baby is worn. Both things are true, and they are only both true at once if somebody else can arrive. If nobody can, the crisis plan is not built yet, whatever else is on the roster.

Two duties you cannot coach around, in Idaho.

Someone is in immediate danger. Call or text **988** (free, 24/7; chat also works). If it is life-threatening, call **911**.

You suspect abuse, neglect, or abandonment of a child. In Idaho everyone is a mandatory reporter, and that includes you. Report it, ideally within 24 hours. You do not need proof.

- Statewide: **855-552-5437**
- Treasure Valley: **208-334-5437**
- Or **2-1-1**, or local law enforcement

If the parent or guardian is the source of the harm, that is a report, not a phone call home.

This duty does not give you a key to the Log. You do not read it, so it cannot be a source. What the duty reaches is what a learner tells you, shows you or hands you, and what you see and hear in the room. Say that distinction out loud on day one: the Log is never read, and what you are told, you may have to act on. Going looking is the one thing that is never true.

Build the referral roster real before opening - names and current numbers, not categories. The one line that must never stay blank is a named, warm-referral therapist: one or two local licensed clinicians the studio can send a learner to, arranged before the year opens. “Route to real help” is only real if there is a real person to route to. The pathway runs across breaks, not only on program days, and the learner is told so before each one.

Keep confidences safe. Almost everything a learner writes and says here is theirs. Say so, up front, on day one, woven into the promises you make each other on day one:

> *“Almost everything you write and say here is yours. Your Captain’s Log, nobody reads - including me, and I won’t go looking. What I can’t keep private is a short list, and I’d rather you hear it now than find out later: if you’re in danger, if someone’s hurting you, or if something’s going on that’s bigger than I can hold here. That’s when I bring in real help, and usually that means a call home too. I’ll tell you when I’m doing it. That’s not breaking trust - it’s what care actually looks like.”*

Those are the same promises that are on the learner’s privacy page in Part 1, in your own voice. Say them in these words, rather than improvising a warmer version. A learner who hears a different wording than the one they read goes looking for the seam.

A confidentiality limit named up front is a promise kept. Named in the moment, it feels like betrayal. Say it before it is ever needed.

Holding a “no”

Decline-with-reasoning lives or dies in the single moment a learner actually says no. If that moment collapses into invisible opt-out - silence, the activity just continues around them - the learner is protected by being erased from the room. So hold a no in three beats, and you can run them under load:

1. **Receive the no, whole.** “Okay. You’re not doing this one.” Honor it *before* any curiosity, so your curiosity never lands as a lever.
2. **Offer the door once, and don’t push it.** “That no stands, and it’s done. When you’ve worked out what’s behind it, the tribe will want to hear it. Not me - them. And not today.” Hold both halves or you have turned the practice into a toll: the reasoning is genuinely owed to the room, and it is genuinely not owed in the moment. If a learner never comes back to it, that is between them and the tribe, and it is not yours to collect.
3. **Keep them inside the encounter.** “Come sit with me - you don’t have to do the thing.” Removing the task is not the same as removing the person.

Your question stays a mirror. It is never a way to scare someone into yes.

Ask this: *“When do you think you’ll first run into this for real?”*

Do not ask this: *“What happens the first time you need this and no one is beside you?”*

The first one opens a door. The second one pictures the learner alone and unready, and a worried learner hears it as “you’ll be sorry.”

And whether a fear is the useful kind is the learner’s to name about themselves. It is never yours to assign. The instant you re-code a reasoned no as “avoidance” so you can override it, you have smuggled the veto back in as a diagnosis. You have a voice. You never have a veto.

Watch-fors, and protect yourself

You are the floor everyone else stands on. That is not a self-care footnote; it is safety instrumentation. Co-regulation is a physiological output - you spend your own steadiness to settle a flooded learner, all day. A depleted guide cannot run the watch-and-pivot the whole floor depends on. So:

- **Run your own settle, your own way-down at day’s end, and your own closing minute.** Your regulation is part of the design, not an extra.

- **Your fallow day is fallow too, and so are the breaks.** Protected, not on-call. Do not eat them to cover a hard week. The learner's page says plainly that you are not reachable over a break, so you never have to improvise that limit on the last guided day; what you say aloud before each break is who is: the one adult outside the room, and 988.
- **Debrief what you witness, more often than monthly.** Holding teenagers' worst days and self-portraits is a real load. After any safety event, debrief with a peer or supervisor and do not carry it alone. Document incidents factually and minimally (what happened, what you did, who you contacted), never the learner's private content.
- **A pre-committed pause trigger.** If the deep work has been set aside two guide days in a row (from exhaustion or from a hard week), pause to a lighter mode and re-plan rather than push through. Commit to this now, while rested. A depleted person does not pause on instinct; that is exactly when the instinct fails.
- **Permission, in writing.** A deep block you set aside, or a good-enough December day, is the design working, not you failing. This is the Origin year, not a mastery year. The permission the learners get, you take too.

Two general watch-fors across the year. Guard against any framing that turns a learner's life into a map of what is missing in them: the quiet region is an invitation, not a deficit. And feelings are your private hope for a learner, never the session's aim. You cannot schedule "being seen" for a Thursday. Each session has a kind of gladness we hope for. Word it as a possibility - some feel it, some feel nothing yet, both are true - never as the outcome you are delivering.

Part 3 - The sessions

Each session below has the same seven parts: what it's for, a short intro the learner reads, the flow week by week, things to say, the settle plus the closing minute, watch-fors, and what you'll need. Three sessions carry one more block in the same place, after the things to say: Session 1 (inside the dream session), Session 3 (the choice games) and Session 7 (the year-close). Each is one piece of a session too big for a week line. The day-shapes are the same all year (guide days Tuesday and Thursday; your-own days Monday and Wednesday with a midday check-in; Friday fallow), so the flow sections describe what changes, not the fixed grid.

The weeks inside a session follow one small grammar, and the word in brackets after each week says which beat it is: a session **opens**, **deepens**, **applies**, and **harvests**. A five-week session adds a **gather**, the week the work leaves the room and comes back. A three-week session doubles up. Session 2 gives its deepen week to the field and calls it what it is: fallow.

One word about words. Part 1 said the Log is kept however you hold it, and that holds all year. When the sessions below say write, draft, page, or read, they mean put it in your Log and go back to it, in whatever form yours takes. The book says write because it is the shortest word, not because it is the only way. And anything the room listens to has a transcript in the room; anything the room reads can be heard. Both are on the table for everyone before anyone needs them; nobody has to ask.

Session 1 - The Map of Me (four weeks, Aug 16 - Sep 9)

What it's for: to dream with no ceiling and start naming what you actually want.

For the learner: This is where you get to find out how much bigger your life might be than you have let yourself imagine - some people are startled by their own list, some are not yet, and both are true - and where you start naming it out loud. You are going to write a hundred dreams. Not the realistic ones - all of them. Then we look at what they say about you. This is the "first creation": you dream a thing before you build it, and everything the next years build, you dream here first.

The flow:

Weeks 1-4 · Aug 16 - Sep 9 · off: Mon Sep 6, Labor Day

- **Week 1 - the threshold week (open).** The whole first week is the crossing, and the order is the point. Agreements signed in the hour you met the room are compliance, not consent, so this week gives each rite its own air. **Tue: arrival, then the door.** The walk-

in, the opening circle with the first “how are you, really?”, a name round (pass is always allowed), the Table, the map of the year. Then **the exit ramp is built and walked, before any promise is asked for** - show them how to leave, let them use it once in practice. A no with nowhere to stand is a courtesy, not a right. Then the privacy words from Part 2, said as written and not warmed up - the room is honest about its limits before it asks for anything - and the name of the one adult outside the room, and how to reach them. **All of it carried on a shared task**, something to do side by side; seven strangers put in a circle to name themselves with no work under it feels like exposure, not welcome. **Wed is the interval**, which means a day where nothing is asked back. The promises have been offered - the six refusals and the one that sits on top of them - and nothing is owed in return yet. **Thu: the tribe’s own half.** Say the floor before they start writing: there are six things this tribe cannot agree to, and they are the six they were promised. An agreement that makes doing the work, finishing, keeping pace, hitting a date or sharing a piece enforceable is not theirs to write, because a ladder would then stand behind it. The learners co-write their own agreements (contributions can be written on a card, not only spoken), and the agreements are named as **reopenable** - say when, in words rather than in principle: at any session’s close, and on request at any walk-in. Agreements you can sign only once are a door with no inside handle. Say also what happens if a learner will not sign: they are in the room anyway. The agreements describe how we treat each other. They were never a condition of being let in. Then, last and separate, the carried objects: name your Captain’s Log, with every form it can take out on the table so picking one says nothing about you, and name your Vineyard-thing. The first Log entry is theirs to make whenever the walk-in or the close gives them room for it - nobody writes on a bell, and that is true from the first week. **At the very end of the week**, send home the 100 Dreams assignment.

- **Week 2 (deepen).** They arrive on the first guide day *with* their dreams - a full week of collecting, so the ones that arrive late are in the list. Run the dream session (below). The first solo day is narrated so the shape is visible. The second guide day goes deeper: what do your 100 dreams say about what you actually want? *Keep this week and the next side by side on shared, comparable material: first-week impressions - the funny one, the quiet one - are still loose here, and common work keeps them loose. Nobody is assigned a part and nobody is moved out of one; the material is kept shared so each person has room to be more than their first morning.*
- **Week 3 (apply).** Sort the dreams by time horizon (within 12 months / one to five years / five-plus years) and notice what the shape reveals. Then map them across the five regions of the Compass the learner already navigates - Self, Others, Making, World, Voice - using warm prompts so no part of life gets missed. The credit and path conversation begins this week, warmly, in walk-ins and check-ins - never as a day-two audit.
- **Week 4 (harvest). Tue: the courage pass** - “which of these scares you a little?” **Wed is the interval again, and it is named out loud as one**: the learners run it themselves, carrying one question and handing in nothing. Late in S1 they can hold their own silence,

which they could not on Day 1. **Thu: each learner picks three within-12-months dreams** as the session's orienting goals - a commitment decided after a night and a day of their own air, not in the hour the courage was spent. Three is the shape, not a gate - a learner who can name one, or none yet, has harvested truly. Ask the pace question as the day closes: is the plan matching the speed that is real for you right now? Run the closing minute at session scale, the first time at that size. Then the session closes and bridges to The Lineage, and the ten-day break lets the goals rest. (Labor Day removes this week's Monday, a self-run morning.)

Things to say:

> *"Your first quest, before Tuesday: write 100 dreams. No filter, no ceiling, nothing has to be realistic, don't edit a single one. You'll hit a wall around 40 where the easy ones run out - that's exactly where the real ones start, so keep going. Bring your list Tuesday and we'll dig into them together. A hundred is the target, not a gate - bring what you've got."*

> *"The Compass is how you read your sky; the Log is how you steer - same voyage. You'll navigate by the chart you're building right now."*

> *"If you hear a dream you want, add it to your own list. Borrowed dreams count."*

> *"A thin region isn't a lack - it's a door you haven't walked through yet. You don't have to. If you're curious, what's on the other side of it?"*

> *"Any of these can change, or be dropped, or outgrown at any point, with no failure attached. The dream you no longer want is data about who you're becoming, not a target you missed."*

Inside the dream session: Debrief the wall first ("who hit the wall at 40? what came up after?") so the wall is a shared story, not a private failure. For whoever did not reach forty, the wall was wherever their list stopped; the wall is the shared story, never the number. Then go around once, in order, the same way the morning circle goes: each is invited to share one dream, aloud or

by putting it on the tribe dreams wall, starting with a within-12-months one, and pass is a complete answer. The wall is a second way to share for anyone, not a side door: a dream pinned there has been shared the same as one said aloud, and the guide reads the wall aloud once so the whole room hears all of it. Watch the lists grow live as dreams prove contagious. As they share, you begin to hold each learner's dreams with them, which is what makes you a coach and not a teacher. Ask before you work one - "do you want to just say that one, or do you want us to think about how you'd live it?" - and follow the answer. The circle's held-or-worked rule runs here too, and this is the first week the room learns it on something light. A warm catch-up in the walk-in, never in front of the room, for anyone whose list stopped early. Nobody leaves ashamed of a count.

The settle and the closing minute: Open every guide day with the settle. Teach the closing minute at its youngest register this session, and use it at each day's close. On the day, "take your closing minute" is the whole prompt; the three questions are the learner's own, in the fixed words from Part 1. Spoken, never written for the studio.

Watch-fors: Do not let the region map read as a deficit ledger - the quiet regions are invitations, not gaps. Keep the credit and path conversation out of day one entirely; belonging roots first. The permission to dream is genuine, so protect it from any quiet "be realistic."

What you'll need: The take-home 100 Dreams card (the rule, the wall at 40, a spark bank of warm words, "borrowed dreams count," "what did you want when you were eight?", and "kept however you keep your Log"). Blank Captain's Logs in several forms. The five-region prompt map. A tribe dreams wall surface. The exit-ramp place, set up before Tuesday. One shared task to carry the week. Cards for agreement contributions. The map of the year to hand out. The two names, written: the one adult outside the room, and the person who takes the baby. After the first year, notice which words on the card nobody used, and change them: a skipped door is a dead label.

Session 2 - The Lineage (five weeks, Sep 20 - Oct 21)

What it's for: to gather the stories of where you come from, and to see that an ordinary life carries enormous meaning.

For the learner: You come from somewhere and someone. This session you learn how to gather a story - how to interview someone who made you and listen for the story under the facts - and you bring what you choose of it to a family-story potluck. "Where you come from" is answered whatever your roots are: interrupted, mixed, adopted, chosen, unknown, or forward-facing. Interrupted lineage is still lineage. However you arrive, you belong at this table.

This session goes near death. You interview someone older than you, usually much older, about a life further along than yours. The room also listens to a recording of real people telling their life stories, and one of them is dying. People get sick, people are gone, people are not speaking to each other, and all of that lives in family stories. Some of it will be yours. You will know in advance, every time, before anything heavy starts. There is a named place to step out to and you never owe a reason for going there. And if your own lineage holds something you do not want to go near, you can do this whole session without going near it.

The ask itself has a ceiling and a floor. **One interview, once** - that is the ceiling, and nobody is asked for a second. The person you ask is told, by you, what this is for and where their story will go, and they can take any of it back at any point, even after they have told you. After the interview there is one more thing, and it is not a second interview: you may take what you made of it back to them and go through it with them, so they can hear it and take anything out. That is for them, not for us, and you can skip it. And you may decline the ask entirely. Some people will have good reason: a family they are not in contact with, a story they already know they do not want opened, or simply no. Declining the interview is not declining the session. The session's question is where do you come from, and "I am not asking anyone" is one of its true answers.

The flow:

Weeks 5-9 · Sep 20 - Oct 21 · off: Mon Oct 11, Indigenous Peoples' Day / Columbus Day - see watch-fors

One ask. This is a cap, not a guideline. Each learner interviews one person, once. Five weeks, and most of them go to the **waiting**, not to more asking: a learner asks a grandmother on a Tuesday and the answer comes when it comes, after a phone call across time zones, after a cousin is consulted, after an old woman decides whether she wants to tell it. Fewer weeks would force the ask and the return into one breath. A second, deeper ask is the line where gathering becomes excavation, and we do not cross it.

The elder has a no, and they are told so. They are the one person in this arc who did not enrol here, who consented to a grandchild rather than a curriculum. Before the interview they are told plainly what it is for and where the story will go. Where the story will go means all of it: the potluck table, and anything the learner writes or makes this year that carries the elder's words. They may withdraw anything, at any point, **including after the telling**, and a withdrawal reaches that far too: what is taken back comes out of what was written and out of anything made from it. The learner carries that sentence to them; it is not ours to assume.

- **Week 5 (open, re-thread).** A short re-thread first: where were you, where are you now, what came back changed over the break. The three dreams chosen in week 4 have had a break to rest - some will have shifted, and that is data, not drift. Then open the session: family is who made you. Name the safety net and the other honest ways in *first*, warmly, so

everyone knows they belong before anything is asked - **and make that door visible to the whole room in week one, not produced later for whoever needs it.** A door that appears only when someone needs it announces them for needing it. For some learners the silence, the rupture or the migration *is* the lineage, and the structure says so before anyone asks. The family tree as stories, not a chart. Preview the recording of real people talking about their own dying - name that it touches death and loss, and give a real place to step out to. Then the craft: how to interview someone who made you, how to listen for the story under the facts ("what was that time like for you?" not "when were you born?"). Practice in pairs in the room first. Give them the words to carry to the person they ask, before they ask anything:

> *"Before you ask them anything, tell them what it's for and where it goes. Something like: 'I'm gathering a story about where I come from, for my studio. Some of it goes to a meal with my people there, and some of it might end up in what I write or make this year. Anything you tell me, you can take back - now, later, or after I've written it down.' Then they know their no is real before they've said a word."*

The ask goes out at the end of the week.

- **Week 6 (the fallow week - and it stays empty).** No new lineage content. **This is the year's one deliberately empty stretch inside the arc, and it is un-harvested: no Work of the Day, nothing reported, nothing to hand in.** The temptation to refill it the first time it looks idle is the exact thing it exists to resist. Low-stakes in-studio craft only, if anything at all. The guide's work this week is the walk-in, for whoever wants to say where the ask stands: sent, answered, still waiting, or not made. "Not made" closes the question, and nobody is asked it twice. Nobody is behind. **Waiting is the relationship, not a gap before it.**

- **Week 7 (gather).** They bring back what they gathered. Voluntary share of one surprising thing. Reflect the meaning under the facts - a recipe as a story, an ordinary day as a whole world. **Debrief the ask, never the elder.** What did you do, what would you try - never what they withheld. A characterisation of an absent family member, said aloud to six peers who will never meet them, is not the learner's to make, and the learner will sit across a table from this person again.

- **Week 8 (apply).** Prepare the short telling that goes with each dish (or with no dish at all). **Then offer the return, and it is not a second gathering.** The learner may take what they made of it back to the elder and go through it with them: *did I get this right, is there anything you want taken out?* That hands the elder power instead of asking for more. It is

offered and declinable, never a station anyone is marched through, and whatever they add unprompted is theirs to give. Set the potluck together. (The Oct 11 holiday removes this week's Monday; see the watch-fors.)

- **Week 9 (harvest).** The family-story potluck gets its own week and its own body, rather than riding the back of a working day. The table is the tribe, the guide, and whoever each learner chooses to invite - the person you interviewed is welcome at it, and is told so when you ask them. **Build the vessel to receive an empty hand:** "I asked, and the answer has not come yet" is a true telling about lineage. If the table cannot hold that, the rite shames the learner it was built for. Ask the pace question as the week closes - is the plan still matching the speed your real life is running at? - and on the last guided day run the closing minute at session scale, before the break. Bridge to The Power of Choice.

Things to say:

> *"Family is who made you - biological, chosen, or found. A grandparent, a mentor, a coach, a sibling, a neighbor. Whoever left a mark."*

> *"Your lineage is also who you choose, who you're building, who you're becoming. You can be the first of a line. That's a full front door, not a side exit."*

> *"A recipe you wish you had, recreated from memory, is as real an offering as one that's been handed down for generations."*

> *"You choose how much of your story travels to the table - all of it, a little, or none. You're never the exhibit."*

> *"This recording touches death and loss. Here's where you can step out to, and you don't owe anyone a reason."*

The settle and the closing minute: Carry the settle, and go further down the safety floor than usual - grief opens for some this session, so use a short way down in the middle of the work and the close-return on the deep days. Close with the three prompts. Important: real grief is **not** a

costume anyone takes off at the end. This is a “that was me, and I carry it, and I’m still here” close, never a “that wasn’t me” one. If an opening runs deeper than a close can hold, hand off warmly to the referral pathway.

Watch-fors: The mortality preview is the sharpest safety point - preview it, name the content, give a real exit, honor opt-out with no explanation. The family interview can surface rupture (estrangement, loss, unknown parents); keep the other honest ways in visible, not buried. Name specific peoples (Eritrean, Nepali, Basque, Diné), never a regional lump. And the learner’s own word for their people is the word; the guide never asks for a finer-grained one. At the potluck, protect the material-poverty path: the studio-provided base dish can quietly *be* a learner’s contribution, pre-arranged so a learner who brings nothing is indistinguishable from one who brought a dish. Presence, not provision. A learner from a marginalized or painful lineage sets their own terms and is never turned into a lesson for the room. **The Monday Oct 11 holiday falls inside this session.** Decide its observance given the studio’s values, and decide what the studio calls it: the federal calendar names it Columbus Day, and this programme’s values point to Indigenous Peoples’ Day. It lands on a self-run Monday, so the decision is about the name and the framing rather than the schedule. In a session about lineage, the name is not a small question. If the studio names it Indigenous Peoples’ Day, name the specific peoples whose homelands the studio stands on, in the names those nations use for themselves, confirmed from their own published materials - never “the local tribes.” The rule about specific peoples applies to the book.

What you’ll need: The recording about dying, previewed, with its transcript and a real exit space. Interview-skill practice prompts. The elder’s sentence, written so the learner can carry it word for word: what this is for, where the story will go, and that they may take anything back, at any point, including afterwards. The other honest ways in, named as equal from day one. The referral pathway, live - this is the first session that hands off to it. Potluck logistics with the inclusion floor (base meal provided, no cover charge, allergen and cultural and religious safe, presence not consumption). The exit ramp, named for the potluck room and shown before guests arrive - the same no-reason rule holds at a feast.

Session 3 - The Power of Choice (three weeks, Nov 1 - Nov 18, ends into Thanksgiving)

What it’s for: to make choosing a muscle you can feel in your body.

For the learner: You cannot always choose what happens to you. But the space between what happens and what you do next - that space is where your whole freedom lives. Every guide morning this session opens with a fork: one small real decision, about three minutes, no winner, nothing scored, nothing written down. The same shape every time, on purpose, because that is

how a thing stops being an exercise and starts being something your body knows how to do. Then you notice the choices you have been making by not choosing. Responsibility, freedom, and choice are one knot, not three topics. And decline-with-reasoning - the way “no” works here - is this exact power, practiced on us: your no stands the moment you say it, and the reasoning you bring to your tribe afterwards is this same muscle, used on purpose.

A session about choice can do damage if it is taken too far, so: **not everything is a choice.** Some things happen to you. Some things were done to you that you did not choose, and nothing in this session says otherwise. Nobody here is going to tell you that you chose your circumstances, and nobody is going to tell you that you chose anything that was done to you. The choosing we practice is what you do next. That is a different thing, and it is the only thing we are claiming.

And one more honest thing, about right now rather than about the past. **Some of you have more room to choose than others do.** Who decides where you live, whether you work, whether a Saturday is yours - that is not the same for everyone in this room, and it is not a measure of anything about you. So: the smallest real choice counts here. A choice made inside a tight constraint is the same muscle as a choice made with the whole field open, and sometimes it is the harder rep. Nobody is asked to bring a big one.

And a warning. Getting better at choosing on purpose sometimes makes things louder at home before it makes them easier. That is not you doing it wrong. We break for Thanksgiving right after this session. The guide is not reachable over the break - that is their rest too - but the one adult outside the room is, the same as always, and so is 988. If something at home gets hard because of work you did here, that is exactly the kind of thing to call about.

The flow:

Weeks 10-12 · Nov 1 - Nov 18 · six guide days in total: Tue Nov 2, Thu Nov 4, Tue Nov 9, Thu Nov 11, Tue Nov 16, Thu Nov 18 · two of them are federal holidays - Election Day, Tue Nov 2, the session’s first guided morning, and Veterans Day, Thu Nov 11 - and observance is decided before the session opens, not during it · ends into Thanksgiving

Settle the guide-day count before you plan the weeks. This is a three-week session whose opening ritual is daily, and the number of guided mornings it actually has is either six, five, or four depending on the holiday call. At five, which is the shape the companion grid is written to, the week that loses a day is week 11. Make the call, then read the grid.

- **Week 10 (open, re-thread).** On the first guided day, the re-thread first, short - where were you, where are you now, what came back changed - and the potluck telling is the natural thing to pick back up; it has had a week to settle. Then the fork, the way it will open every guided morning from here. Then the knot: responsibility, freedom, and choice as one thing. Name the honest frame up front, including the part about room (see watch-fors). On

the second guided day, the first story at a safe distance - in a story, a film, a moment in history - “where did one choice change everything?” Small weight first; the heavy ones are later or not at all. Then, only for those who wish, in their own life.

- **Week 11 (deepen).** The fork to open. Then, kept light and personal: a choice opens some doors and quietly closes others; there is no free move. Then the turn toward agency - defaults and drift, the choices you make by not choosing. Notice your own patterns without judgment, and **go first yourself**: name one of your own defaults out loud, a real one, before anyone is asked for theirs. **If Veterans Day is observed, this week has one guided morning**, and the doors-and-defaults work runs on it alone. Pick the half you keep rather than compressing both; defaults is the half that feeds week 12. This is also the week with the longest stretch between asks, so the walk-in question matters most here.
- **Week 12 (apply, then harvest).** Each learner names a real choice in front of them, **or one they are still circling**, and practices choosing it deliberately - weighing it, owning it, feeling agency in the body. Circling is a real answer at fifteen and at eighteen; a learner pushed to land a choice on a Tuesday has been handed a deadline, not a freedom. Then the harvest: name, if you wish, a choice you now own, or say that none is owned yet - seeing where you have not been choosing is itself a harvest - and the shift from “things just happen to me” to “things happen, and then I choose.” Ask the pace question here too: three weeks is short, and the plan should still match the speed that is real for you. Bridge to Running My Own Ship. **On the last guided day, Thu Nov 18, before the ten-day gap:** run the closing minute at session scale. For the learner whose choice-work opened friction at home, Thanksgiving is where the work meets the people it is about. Send them into it held, not loose. Before they go, say all three out loud: how to reach the one adult outside the room over the break; that 988 is always open, any hour; and that you are not reachable. Their page already says the third one. Hearing it from you the day before makes it a plan rather than a surprise.

Things to say:

> *“You can’t always choose what happens, and sometimes what happens leaves no room to choose at all. What you do next, once there is room again - that part is yours. That’s the whole of it, and it’s enough.”*

> *“Some of your defaults were handed to you. Noticing one isn’t blaming yourself for it - it’s just turning the light on.”*

> *“Not ‘what should I do?’ handed to me. ‘Here’s how I’m deciding.’ That’s yours.”*

> *“Some of you have more room than others do right now. The smallest real choice counts, and a choice made inside a tight constraint is the same muscle. Nobody has to bring a big one.”*

The forks (the daily opener, and the five rules that make it one): The opener is **one fixed form, run the same way every guided morning**, not a rotating set. The fixed form is the Fork: pose one small real choice, they choose, then trace together what the choice opened and what it quietly closed. The sameness is the point. A different exercise each morning builds tolerance for novelty; the same one, five mornings running, builds the thing this session is named for. The other forms in the bank are a second, optional slot on some days, never a substitute for the opener.

Five rules hold for every fork, and they are what keep a daily ritual from becoming a daily test:

1. **A ceiling.** About three minutes. No winner, no score, nothing kept, never twice in one morning. If it is running hot, it ends early.
2. **No consequence the guide hands out.** The consequence traced is the one the chooser names. A fork whose outcome the adult dispenses teaches the opposite of the session.
3. **A way to be in it without speaking, built in rather than permitted beside it.** Every fork has a pointed, written, or placed way to answer. A fork that needs a quick voice or a quick read is a fork somebody sits out of, and in a daily ritual that somebody gets seen sitting out five times.
4. **No tradeoff that assumes resources.** “Would you rather” with options that cost money, travel, or a free Saturday is a fork the learner with the least room cannot honestly play. Keep the stakes inside what every learner in the room actually holds.
5. **Nobody is asked to improvise in front of the room.** A learner who freezes in a scene has just been shown, publicly, that they cannot choose, in the session about choosing. Freeze is not a choice. Any form with a performance edge is offered to volunteers or not at all.

The bank, the weight-graded story ladder, and the day-by-day grid live in the companion: `launch-pad-session-3-forks-and-stories-v0.1.md`.

The settle and the closing minute: Settle to open, then the fork. Close with the three prompts. **On any morning the fork runs hot, take the way down after it** rather than only after the deep block - this session’s activation is fast and upward rather than heavy, and an activated room

cannot hear the knot. The gladness we hope for here is play; for many people agency feels good in the body, and for some it feels like risk before it feels like freedom. Both are true, and the second one is why the ceiling and the non-speaking door exist.

Watch-fors: This is the load-bearing safety point: a session about agency can wound if it implies *everything* is a choice. It is not. Some things happen to a person; some people have had choice taken from them. Never "you chose your circumstances," never "you chose your harm." Always distinguish choices you made from things that happened to you. **And the present-tense version of the same care: the learners do not have equal room.** A session about choosing, run without that said out loud, quietly teaches the learner with the least that agency belongs to other people. It is on their page now; say it in the room too. **Go first on defaults.** For a sixteen-year-old, the default in the room is set by the nearest adult's face, so name one of your own defaults, badly, before you ask. The walk-in is where you hear whether home got louder. Ask it there, one learner at a time, never in the circle, and ask it on every guided morning of week 11 and week 12. Keep consequence-thinking light - deep second- and third-order work belongs to a later year; here it stays personal and immediate. **Two holidays fall on guide days inside this three-week session: Election Day, Tue Nov 2, and Veterans Day, Thu Nov 11.** Decide observance of both before the session opens, not during it. The session has six guide days in total, so observing both leaves four, which is a change to the plan rather than a detail. Election Day can be framed as a civics moment if it is kept.

What you'll need: The companion: the fork bank with its ceilings, the three-rung story ladder, and the guide-day grid. One named story chosen per guided morning, never two, and never the heaviest rung first. A pointed or written way to answer every fork. Opt-out held open all session; the referral pathway ready. The holiday call made and the grid read against it.

Session 4 - Running My Own Ship (three weeks, Nov 29 - Dec 16, ends into the winter break)

What it's for: to build a routine that actually fits you - the thing that makes freedom possible instead of just noise.

For the learner: Freedom you can't hold is just noise. A routine that fits you is how you actually run your own ship. This is Session 3's power of choice, lived as a rhythm - one that fits *you*, not one imposed on you. Routine is not the opposite of freedom. It is what makes freedom possible. This session you build a routine that survives a bad day, you practice real communication, and you look back at who you are becoming.

One thing your routine has to have in it: **your Vineyard.** A week with no time in it for something you love is not a finished routine, and we will send you back to it the same way we would if you had forgotten to sleep. That is the one place this programme is strict about joy. Strict means we keep asking whether the time is there. It never means we check what you did with it, and if you refuse this part too, you will still hear the question - that is the one thing you cannot get us to stop. What goes in the time stays nobody's business but yours.

The flow:

Weeks 13-15 · Nov 29 - Dec 16 · ends into the winter break

December runs lighter by design - short dark days, the guide's own hardest stretch. This session is December, entirely. Postpone depth freely and protect your own fallow.

- **Week 13 (open, re-thread). Open the first guided day (Tue Nov 30) with the re-thread, before anything else:** where were you, where are you now, what came back changed. Then the reframe: routine makes freedom possible. Begin designing your own routine (not a template imposed on you). Then time management as craft - time-blocking, energy management (when are *you* sharp?), and the Weekly Plan as the real tool. Design a routine that survives a bad day, not just a good one.
- **Week 14 (deepen, then apply).** Communication foundations - real listening, "I" statements, asking a question worth answering (this feeds the interviewing through-skill and, later, mentor outreach). Then a real communication: draft and send a genuine email to an adult, prepare a needed conversation, or present a plan to the room. Refine your routine from two weeks of running it - what bent, what held.
- **Week 15 (apply, then harvest). This week holds the true midpoint of the year, and the midpoint is the winter break itself** - the fold between here and January, crossed with the learner's body out of the room. So the crossing comes in two halves. **This half, on Thu Dec 16:** the look-back across Sessions 1 to 4 (who are you becoming?), the pace question, the re-ask (*is this still yours?*), and the re-entry note to your future self so the throughline survives two weeks away. Ask the re-ask to the room; take the answers one at a time, in the walk-in or at the Table, never round the circle. A yes said in front of six people is not the answer you asked for. A no, or an I don't know, is held the way Part 2 holds any no: received whole first, the door offered once, the learner kept inside the room while the plan changes around them. Then the harvest: name the routine that now fits you, or name honestly that it does not fit yet - a routine still bending is a real harvest in December - and share (voluntary) one thing the look-back showed you. They carry the re-ask through two weeks of ordinary life and come back with evidence rather than a feeling the circle produced. This is the longest stretch of the year with no one in the room. Say all three out loud: how to reach the one adult across the two weeks; that 988 is always open, any hour;

and that you are not reachable until January. The referral pathway stays live the whole time, not only on program days. Then run the closing minute at session scale - this half of the crossing closes here. Bridge to The Full Draft.

Things to say:

> *"Routine isn't the opposite of freedom. It's what makes freedom possible. We're building one that fits you, not one that's imposed on you."*

> *"What have these first weeks shown you about yourself? Who are you becoming?"*

> *"What pace is real for you right now, and does the plan match it? That includes the credit plan."*

> *"And the one I ask only a few times a year, so hear it as a real question: is this still yours? Being here, doing this. 'No' and 'I don't know' are both real answers, and you have two weeks to sit with it."*

> *"A routine that fits you protects the fallow. The un-filled cup is part of the rhythm, not a gap to optimize away."*

The settle and the closing minute: Settle to open; three prompts to close. The gladness we hope for is quiet - a clear desk, real momentum, the satisfaction of a rhythm that fits.

Watch-fors: This is the natural readiness moment - read each learner's readiness for more of their own hours with them, one learner at a time, never by date, and let them name how much scaffold they want. Some move toward more autonomy; some keep the full scaffold, and that never reads as remedial. The midpoint look-back is growth-framed, not a shortfall audit - "who you're becoming," not "what you didn't finish." Guard hard against it becoming a private ledger of falling short. The credit and path conversation is a pacing conversation, witnessed, never graded; a learner who needs a multi-year path names it now, adjusting the plan to the learner. Keep communication practice real (a genuine email, a genuine conversation), not role-play only.

What you'll need: The Weekly Plan tool. A real email or conversation for each learner to actually do. The Credit/Path Map for the pacing check. The re-entry note format. The long haul is next, so a routine that holds is exactly what a learner needs to carry the Full Draft through six unbroken weeks of January and February.

Session 5 - The Full Draft (six weeks, Jan 3 - Feb 10)

What it's for: to claim your whole life on the page - all of it - before you choose what to keep.

For the learner: You cannot shape a story you have not yet dared to tell in full. So first you write all of it - messy, complete, unedited, nothing too small. This is your whole life on the page. Some people feel real relief and catharsis in claiming it; some feel tired, flat, or unfinished. Both are true. No one is asked to perform the feeling. Being witnessed is a gift here, never something you owe the room. What you write is private by default - it lives in your Captain's Log, which no one reads - and you choose what, if anything, you say aloud.

Here are the five things you will be asked to write. All of them, now, so none of them is a surprise on the day.

1. A moment after which you were not the same.
2. A place, a smell, a song, a meal, a room. Memory lives in the body before it lives in words.
3. The people who made you. Not just family. Anyone who left a mark.
4. Your worst day and your best day, and what each one taught you.
5. One ordinary day at an age you pick, start to finish.

Number four is the heavy one. It comes in the fifth week of this session rather than the first, and a week before it you will be asked, one to one and never in front of the room, whether you want the gentler version instead. The gentler version is a real option and not a lesser one. A hard thing can be named without being told in detail, and "here is what it taught me" is a complete answer. Nobody has to relive anything to belong here.

The flow (the five prompts, spread across six weeks):

Weeks 16-21 · Jan 3 - Feb 10 · off: Mon Jan 17, MLK Day · no break inside this session

This session opens three days after a two-week holiday and then runs six unbroken weeks of interior work. No break falls inside it, so what a break would quietly do for a body, the design has to do on purpose.

- **Week 16 (open, re-thread) - no prompt.** The second half of the midpoint crossing, and it is the whole day, not a warm-up. The big re-thread: where were you, where are you, what came back changed. Then why the whole life first, and the relief some people find in getting it all down. **Name the safety floor aloud** - the exit ramp, the gentler-prompt swap, the referral pathway with a real room and a real person in it. No prompt this week.
- **Week 17 (deepen).** Prompt 1 - Turning points ("name a moment after which you were not the same"), on the second guided day. A recording of real people telling their life stories. Ask the pace question at the close, two clear weeks before the hard prompt so there is still time to act on the answer.
- **Week 18 (deepen).** Prompt 2 - Sensory doorways (a place, a smell, a song, a meal, a room; memory lives in the body before it lives in words). Memoir excerpts as models. *(MLK Monday removes a self-run day and its midday check-in.)*
- **Week 19 (deepen).** Prompt 3 - The people ("who made you? not just family - anyone who left a mark"). What someone told you in the autumn is theirs, and the autumn's rules still hold over it. What they were to you is yours, and nobody can take that back - including a person who took their own story back. **On the Thursday, an explicit readiness read for what is coming, taken in the walk-in, one learner at a time, never round the circle**, and the softer prompt offered in advance rather than in the moment. Offering it on the day it lands is too late for the learner who needs it.
- **Week 20 (apply: the hard prompt).** Prompt 4 - The hard and the best (the worst day, the best day, what each taught). Run it on the Tuesday, so the held day is the Thursday and no one carries the worst day alone into a weekend. This is the sharpest care point - run all four things in the settle and the closing minute below, and the gentler version was offered last Thursday. Follow it with a lighter, held day: coming-of-age songs as mirrors ("which line is about you?"), then back to their own words.
- **Week 21 (the lighter week, then harvest). Designed lighter on purpose, not by accident** - the week after the hard prompt carries no new hard ground. Prompt 5 - A slice of life ("write one ordinary day at age ____, start to finish" - a whole world in an ordinary day). The ordinary day is the decompression, not one more descent. Then push the draft toward whole, and the harvest: the full draft as it stands - complete, or not yet, or with prompts swapped or left out - being witnessed, sharing only what you choose. An unfinished draft is a real harvest. The pace question and the re-ask both come at the close, answered the same way as in December - after the whole life is on the page is the strongest re-ask of the year. **Run the closing minute at session scale before the break**, and the referral

pathway stays live *through* Feb 11-20, not only on program days; the learner is told so. A learner finishes their whole life on the page and then no one sees them for ten days. Bridge to Chapter One.

Things to say:

> *"Write all of it - messy, complete, nothing too small. You can't shape a story you haven't yet dared to tell in full. If relief comes, it comes from getting it down, not from making it good."*

> *"Your draft lives in your Log, so it takes whatever form your Log takes. A told draft, a drawn one, a typed one - all of it is the full draft."*

> *"You choose what goes in the draft and what stays private. A hard thing can be named without being detailed - 'what it taught me' is enough. No one has to relive anything to belong here."*

> *"A gentler prompt is always available. You can swap any prompt for a softer one, anytime, no reason owed."*

> *"Wherever you went just now, that's exactly what the closing minute is for. Take it, the whole minute, and go for the real answer. Nothing you find in it is for me."*

> *"The break starts Friday and runs ten days. I won't be reachable - that's my rest too - but the person you can go to is, the whole time, not only on studio days, and 988 never closes. You just put your whole life on a page; here is how to reach them."*

The settle and the closing minute: This is the anchor session for both. On every writing day, four things, every time:

- **The settle** to open.

- **A short way down between hard passages.** Thirty seconds: feet on the floor, look around the room, one breath.
- **The close-return** at the end. Say it out loud so the body hears it: “That was then. This is now. Look around and name one thing you can see. You’re in this room, and the hard part is behind you.”
- **An exit ramp that is always open**, used without asking. A body that stays inside a worst-day memory for an unbroken hour floods. The closing minute lands hardest here and rides *into* the private Log. This is a “that was me, and I carry it, and I’m still here” close, and real grief is never something a learner is asked to put down at the door. When a close meets something bigger than a close can hold, hand off warmly to the referral pathway. Open no faster than you teach a person to close; this session is where that rule is most literally true.

Watch-fors: This is the heaviest session, and it has a **binding gate.** The pathway was built before the year opened (Part 2) and Session 2 already leaned on it; this is where you check it again and certify it in writing before anyone writes a worst day. Do not run this session with a real learner until both of these are true:

1. **The referral pathway built before the year opened is still real today.** The quiet space is still a real room. The named clinician still has a current number and will still take the call. Your own honest limit is said out loud again. The clinical hand-off is in place. And the second pair of hands for the baby is re-confirmed for a January morning, not a September one.
2. **A consented safety walk is done, and it walked this session’s floor.** Someone who has held this kind of work with teenagers - a licensed clinician or an experienced guide - has walked this session’s plan with you, in person, before any learner meets it: the settle, the way down, the close-return, the exit ramp and the hand-off, not only Session 1’s morning.

Who certifies this gate: you do, in writing, dated, on the plan - naming the quiet space, naming the clinician, and naming the date of the walk and who walked it. A solo studio has no second signature available, so say plainly that the guide self-certifies and make the certification a written thing rather than a feeling. A gate nobody signs is a gate nobody holds. A trauma-informed floor with an unbuilt trap door is not yet trauma-informed. Coach, not therapist: you hold the container and witness; you do not treat. Every session opens with a re-thread; Session 4’s is short and this one is a whole day. The two-week winter gap is the highest risk to a learner’s throughline, which is why week 16 carries no prompt. Being witnessed is a gift, never a demand.

What you’ll need: The five scaffolding prompts. The recordings and readings (the Session 2 recording of real people telling their life stories, previewed again if it is played again; memoir excerpts; coming-of-age songs; each with a transcript or an audio form). Gentler swap-prompts on hand. The built referral pathway and the designated quiet space. Your gate certification, written and dated, before week 16.

Session 6 - Chapter One (six weeks, Feb 21 - Mar 30)

What it's for: to become the author of your own story, and to learn that shaping it small is not making your life small - it is declaring there are chapters to come.

For the learner: A chapter is not a smaller version of your life. It is a shaped thing with one thread running all the way through, and you learn to find the thread. To you, right now, this *is* your whole life - so we don't argue with that, we flip it. Calling it "Chapter One" is an act of hope: it declares there are chapters coming. It doesn't make your life small. It makes your future big. And here is the discipline that keeps this from feeling like loss: we never cut to hide. We cut to focus. Everything you leave out of Chapter One is kept, in the full draft, in your Log. It is still true. It just isn't load-bearing for *this* chapter's shape.

The flow (five steps of shaping, across six weeks):

Weeks 22-27 · Feb 21 - Mar 30 · off: Mon Feb 21, Presidents Day (the session's first day)

- **Week 22 (open, re-thread).** A short re-thread first, then: become the author; a chapter is a shaped thing with a throughline; introduce the "Chapter One = hope" reframe. Go back through the full draft. That is a re-opening, so this day runs Session 5's four things - settle, the way down, the close-return, the exit ramp - and any passage may be skipped in the going-back without a word.
- **Week 23 (deepen: the truth-discipline).** Cut to focus, never to hide; everything cut is kept in the Log, still true. Practice the discipline on a shared example at a safe distance before turning it on their own life. If an elder's words from the Lineage are in your chapter, their no still reaches here: anything they asked to take back comes out of what travels, even now, and stays only in your Log if you want it kept.
- **Week 24 (deepen: the throughline).** Shaping step 1: find the thread ("what is this chapter *about*?" - one sentence). You hold the question; the learner finds the line. A throughline that is theirs tends to land as relief rather than a cage. If it lands as a cage, hold the question longer, not the line.
- **Week 25 (deepen: the load-bearing moments).** *Ask the pace question at the close, two weeks before the session ends while there is still time to act on it.* Shaping step 2: choose the three to five moments that hold the chapter up - the ones that set up who you are becoming. *Keep, because* - never *cut, because*. Everything else moves, honored, into the Log; nothing is lost.
- **Week 26 (apply: write it).** Shaping step 3: make Chapter One - tight, shaped, true. Revision as care; share a passage with the room if you want to.

- **Week 27 (harvest: the second distillation, and the turn outward).** Shaping steps 4 and 5: distill the same life into a second shape, the short story-of-self and the one-page resume. Same material, two forms - a story (meaning) and a page (practical), for two different rooms. A Chapter One not yet finished, or a thread not yet found, is a real harvest - the shaping goes on. **Assemble the portfolio here** - it belongs in the join between the two sessions, not to a day of its own. **Choose the medium for your This Is Me piece now, before the break, if it's ready**, so the choice has two weeks to sit; the scarce thing in the last session is not making time but dwell time. An unchosen medium crosses the break too, and nothing in Session 7 waits on it. Name the four ways of being seen alongside it, equal, so no one meets them for the first time in April. **And the turn outward starts here, not in Session 7.** Twelve weeks have gone inward; the coming-back-out needs more than the final stretch to carry it, so this harvest turns the work toward being seen. Ask the pace question as the session closes: four weeks remain, so the plan can still bend to the speed that is real for you. Run the closing minute at session scale before the break. Bridge to the Unveiling.

Things to say:

> *"Calling this 'Chapter One' isn't shrinking your life. It's declaring there are chapters coming. It doesn't make your life small - it makes your future big."*

> *"We never cut to hide. We cut to focus. What you leave out isn't erased - it's kept in your Log, still true. It just isn't load-bearing for this chapter."*

> *"Keep this, because* ***. Not cut this, because*** *. Choose your keepers by what they set up in who you're becoming."*

> *"Your resume is a tool that belongs to you. One true page inside your portfolio, for the rooms you choose to walk into. It isn't you, reduced to a page."*

The settle and the closing minute: Settle to open; the three prompts to close - the shaping *is* a re-crossing of the whole draft. Memory is still in play here (it draws on the Session 5 draft), so keep opt-out and the coach-not-therapist boundary live.

Watch-fors: Offer the hero's-journey arc as *one* map, not the frame. The learner whose life is a garden, a spiral, or a set of rooms authors their own shape with equal honor. The learner is the author of their story, never a character in ours. The truth-discipline is the safety - cutting one's own life can feel like erasure, and the kept-in-the-Log reframe is what makes it authorship. Hold the "Chapter One = hope" reframe whenever the shrinking starts to feel like loss. Sharing a passage is an offer, never a round. If it starts going in order, stop it once, warmly: this is an offer, not a round, and a passage kept to yourself is still Chapter One.

What you'll need: The full drafts from Session 5. A shared safe-distance example to practice the cut-to-focus discipline. The one-page resume format, framed as a tool the learner owns. Portfolio materials.

Session 7 - This Is Me / The Unveiling (four weeks, Apr 10 - May 4)

What it's for: to declare who you are - dreamed in Session 1, drafted in Session 5, shaped in Session 6, now shown to your people.

For the learner: This is the year's harvest. You make a self-portrait - a "This Is Me" piece - in whatever medium is true to you: art, film, music, writing, spoken word, a practice, a set of values. It does not have to be a story. You present it with your portfolio, your resume page, and your Chapter One. Some people feel deeply seen; some feel exposed or flat. Both are honored, and no one performs the feeling. The audience is warm - your people, not a panel. It is a feast, not a judged presentation.

You choose how you are seen, and you know all the choices now rather than in April. Four ways, equal, not one main road and three exits:

- show your piece at the feast, with families there;
- show it to the tribe only;
- show it to one person you choose;
- make it in a form the guide, or a person you choose, presents for you while you sit with your people, or while you do not.

Nobody will ever have to ask for one of these; all four are offered to everyone, the same way. And "I have nothing to declare this year" is a real and honored harvest too. A flat year, a tired year, or an unfinished piece has not failed anything.

One more rule we hold for you. Afterwards people will want to talk to you about your piece, and **you do not have to answer any question about it, from anyone, including an adult who means well.** "I'd rather not say" is a complete answer that night, and the guide will back you on it in the room.

The flow:

Weeks 28-31 · Apr 10 - May 4 · the session break falls before this session (Apr 3-6), not inside it

- **Week 28 (open, re-thread).** A re-thread after the break, then open with a witness beat *first*: before you turn to your own portrait, witness someone else's story. Reflect a peer's Chapter One back to them **if that peer offers it to you**, or sit with one of the year's recordings of a real person telling their own life and reflect that teller's thread back - to the guide, or to the room if you choose. Nobody interviews anyone this session; the one interview of the year was in the autumn, and it stays one. Nobody's Chapter One is handed to a classmate by the guide. Pair this only where both learners have said yes, and the learner who is not in a pair that week witnesses a recorded life instead, which is equal rather than second. Done that way, being seen becomes reciprocal rather than performative. Then: what the Unveiling is, and the year it completes, and the four ways of being seen, named again as equal, so the choice is open the whole session. For most, the medium was chosen at the close of Session 6, so the making can begin on the first day; for anyone still choosing, the first week is the choosing, and that is not behind. It need not be a narrative.
- **Week 29 (deepen).** Make the piece (the guide is coach, not critic - the piece is theirs). Sharing works-in-progress is ambient, whenever someone wants it, not a scheduled beat. Refining is part of making, not a separate pass. *(The portfolio was assembled in Session 6. Any remaining logistics live on the self-run days.)*
- **Week 30 (apply).** Finish the piece. Confirm each learner's unveiling shape now, in the walk-in - the four were on the table from the first day, and this is the week the choice is made real, not first offered. Then the works-in-progress share **becomes** the dry run in the shape they chose: to the tribe, in the safety of the tribe, for those who chose it; with the one chosen person, or with the guide, for those who did not. Each is the same dry run, the rehearsal rather than a thing that precedes one. Prepare the exhibition together; hold any nerves warmly.
- **Week 31 (harvest).** Final touches and final rehearsal early in the week, then the Unveiling feast midweek, an afternoon or evening with a real audience (families, the tribe), each learner unveiling as much as they choose. **The year-close gets the last guided day, Thu May 4, to itself, not the feast's last hour** - the co-authoring review, the Log handoff ("it's yours; it goes where you say; no copy kept"), and the closing minute at year scale. This is also the last honest place to ask *is this still yours?*, answered the same way as in December. Then Open Waters.

Things to say:

> *"Before you turn to your own portrait, witness someone else's. If a friend offers you their Chapter One, reflect it back to them. A room where everyone has done some of the seeing is a safer room to be seen in."*

> *"Your piece can be anything true to you - an image, a film, a song, a set of values, a practice. It doesn't have to be a story."*

> *"The tribe is your people. A mentor, a friend's family who takes you in for the night - a chosen witness is honored exactly as much as anyone. You will not fall through this."*

> *"This is the end of the first year of three. It's allowed to be a little tender. The story continues - next year, we ask what's worth solving."*

The year-close: On the last guided day, after the feast has had its own night, three acts. First, a co-authoring close: the learner reviews the year's design *with* you, the design named not hidden - "here's how this year was built, and why; tell me what to change for your next year." The learner's call on their own year, never a feedback form, and declinable like every other quest; a learner who doesn't want to redesign the year has still closed it. Alongside it, put the whole short record of them on the table, unasked: attendance, pace, credit plan, any safety note. They could read it any day; this is the day you offer it. Second, the Captain's Log ownership handoff: the Log is theirs; it goes where they say - home, or back to the one place here only they open for next year - and no copy is kept. That is the same whatever form the Log took: if any of it lives on a studio device or in a scribe's hand, it goes to the learner and nothing stays behind. Third, the closing minute at year scale, below. The year ends on the learner owning their own record, not the studio archiving it.

The settle and the closing minute: The Unveiling turns a learner outward. Showing yourself to a room is its own kind of opening, so it needs its own private close. On the year-close day, after the feast, run the closing minute at the scale of the whole year, in its fixed words:

> *"Before the next year opens, take your closing minute at the whole year's scale. What did you meet this year? What do you carry back? What's different in you now - even a little? 'I don't know yet' is a real answer."*

That is what brings a learner back from being on stage to being themselves. Then a real fallow stretch before the next year opens. Never start a new opening on a body still buzzing from the feast.

Watch-fors: Being seen is invitational, and being seen can be exposing, especially for the anxious or isolated learner. Offer the other three shapes as real roads, not as "share less": unveil to the tribe only, or in a form you present for them, or to one chosen person - each equal, not a lesser path. The learner with no family in the room is the one most exposed by "show your people," so name and hold them: the tribe *is* their people, and a chosen witness is honored equally, never as consolation. Do not let "families come" become a floor that learner falls through on the year's most tender day. Hold the year's close gently; this is a year-close, not a goodbye - the full Launch is a later year. Coach-not-therapist still applies; the piece can surface a lot.

What you'll need: Materials for many mediums. The witness-beat setup (peer reflection by consent, or the year's recordings of real people telling their lives). The feast planned like a real event with the inclusion floor (base provided, presence not consumption, allergen-safe). The exit ramp, named for the feast room and shown before families arrive - the same no-reason rule holds at a feast. The co-authoring review structure. The Log handoff.

Part 4 - Closing the year

The Unveiling harvest

The Unveiling is the year's culminating feast, and it deserves real weight and real warmth. It sits outside the daily morning grid - likely an afternoon or evening with families. Plan it like any studio feast, with the full inclusion floor: the base is always provided, no one watches a plate, everyone is allergen-safe, and presence matters more than what anyone brought. Each learner shows their "This Is Me" piece, their portfolio, and their Chapter One, as much as they choose to share. The whole point is being seen by your people in a room that is glad you exist.

Remember the honored empty outcome, here as everywhere: a learner who feels flat, or exposed, or unfinished has not failed the harvest. "I have nothing to declare this year" is a real and honored harvest. The fallow field is part of the crop.

The year-scale closing minute

The year opens with a felt beginning and closes with a public harvest - and a public harvest is itself an opening outward. So the year needs its private close, or the learner is left facing out with no way back in. It runs on the year-close day, the last guided day of Session 7, after the feast has had its own night. It is a naming, not a new ceremony: the practice they have run all year, put in their own hand at the year's scale. The words are in Session 7 and they do not change.

Then a real fallow stretch before the next year begins. Never walk a new year's opening on a body still activated from the last one. The learner who is staying needs this between-years close as much as a graduating learner needs the Launch - it is the arc-scale version of the practice they have run all year, put in their own hand.

The tail of the year: Open Waters

The flex tail runs May 8 to May 25, the three weeks after Session 7 closes on May 4. It is light structure, not a void: real-world expeditions, personal-project deep dives, high-school-credit close-out for anyone finishing the year's plan, and genuine fallow - rest is a legitimate use of it. Name it to families as intentional: flex plus fallow, not "we'll figure it out." And the bridge into the next year is one sentence: *"You know your story now. Next year: what is worth solving?"*

“We evoke - we never extract.” - and that includes the guide, and everyone in the room.

The Forge Year - Lesson Plan Book

A guide's book for Year Two of the Launch Pad, written so a learner can read every page.

A note before you begin

This book is the plan for The Forge - the second of the three Launch Pad years. It is written for the guide who runs the year, and it is written so that any learner can pick it up and read the whole thing. There is nothing hidden in here.

Here is the rule, and it holds on every page: everything in this book is safe and honest for a learner to read. Nothing in it manages or manipulates anyone. Lines in "quotes" are things a guide might say aloud. Everything else is for the guide to understand and hold - the reasons behind the moves, the care points, the things to watch for. A learner who reads a guide's note will find an adult thinking carefully and kindly about how to be useful, never an adult figuring out how to steer them.

If you are a learner reading this: welcome. This is your year, and you are allowed to see how it was built. At the end of the year you will be invited to help rebuild it for the next group, and you can say no to that too.

One author's note on language: this book was written by Erin Stanley, who opened the studio and guided its first year. "The guide" means whoever is leading the studio, and this book says "they" throughout, because that will not always be the same person. Where the book says the guide is raising a small child, that is the shape of the year it was written for, named so the shape is owned; a later guide names their own shape in the same place. "You" sometimes means the guide and sometimes means the learner - the context always makes it clear which.

Part 1 - For everyone: what this year is

The year's question

The Forge asks one thing, all year: **What is worth solving?**

The first year, Origin, was about dreaming your life and figuring out who you are. This year is about building: turning your gaze outward, from yourself to the world and the problems in it. You will find a real problem that matters to you, trace it down to its root, and act on it alongside the people who actually have it.

The anchor line for the year is simple: **things are only impossible until they're not.**

The three years each carry their own question:

- **Origin - Who am I?** (Know your story.)
- **The Forge - What is worth solving?** (Find your work.)
- **The Helm - What do I do when there is no easy answer?** (Make the hard call, and love the life around it.)

The three years turn as a cycle rather than a ladder. Whichever year is running when you arrive is the one you start in, and you are not behind. A learner who starts here asks what is worth solving with the story they already have, and comes to Origin later with more of it. Nobody here is catching up to anybody. There is a short note for learners starting here at the end of this Part.

The journey (the year's arc, plain)

Here is the shape of the whole year, in order:

1. **Name a real problem.** Learn the difference between a problem you can act on and a thing you just have to accept. Name your problem so precisely that it stops being a fog and becomes a thing you can actually work on.
2. **Trace it to its root.** The obvious villain is almost never the real cause. You will learn to keep asking "why" until you hit the system underneath, and to ask who is still answerable inside that system, including, sometimes, you.
3. **Find your arena.** Not every problem is yours to move. You will find the slice of it where your own action actually changes something, and try to move one small thing.

4. **Lift your eyes to the world.** You will go out and meet real problems where they live, and choose the one that gets to you. Not the one you think you should care about. The one that actually moves you.
5. **Play the long game.** Big problems are systems, not single heroic acts. You will break the impossible into a next doable step, find the real lever, and gather people.
6. **Put your hands to work.** You will act, for real, with real people, designing the work *with* them, never *for* them.
7. **Tell a room what's worth solving.** You will make the case: here is a problem worth solving, here is why it got to me, here is what I did, here is what I ask of you.

The three years together move like this: first you look at yourself, then you look at the world, and in the final year you learn to make the hard call when there is no easy answer. This is the middle year. The turn outward.

The words this book uses

This studio has its own small vocabulary. None of it is a secret, so here it all is, before you meet any of it.

- **A quest.** One piece of work with a beginning and an end: a prompt, an interview, a making, a share. It is the unit you can say no to.
- **A session.** One of the year's seven stretches, each with its own question. Three to six weeks long, with a break after it.
- **Core.** Short for your core academics: the high-school credit work you have claimed, at your own pace, on your own days.
- **The settle.** The three slow breaths that open every guide day.
- **The way down.** Standing up and shaking it out after hard work, so your body can put the stress down.
- **The exit ramp.** The named place you can step out to, without asking, and come back from with nothing said.
- **The close-return.** The words the room says out loud after a heavy day, so your body hears that the heavy part is over. Always the same words; they are on the settle page.
- **The closing minute.** The three private questions at the end of an opening. Never written for the studio, never read by anyone.
- **The Captain's Log.** Your own record of your own life. Yours.
- **The Vineyard.** The thing you love that nobody ever makes useful.
- **The Work of the Day.** The one piece of the session's work the whole tribe does together that morning, named out loud at the start so you know what the day is for.
- **Your tribe.** The people in this studio with you.

- **The walk-in.** Two things share this word. The walk-in is the soft first stretch of a guide day, when the door is open and nothing is required. It is also what we call the quiet one-to-one conversations that happen inside that window, where the guide comes to one or two people rather than calling anyone over. “I’ll catch you in the walk-in” means a conversation, not a meeting, and nothing in it is written down.
- **Fallow.** Deliberately empty. Fallow is a farming word: a fallow field is one you leave unplanted on purpose, because that is what makes it rich again. Fridays are fallow, and so is one whole week in the autumn. Never earned, never filled.
- **A harvest.** The last stretch of a session, where you gather what the weeks grew and name what you got. It is yours to gather, and an empty harvest is a real harvest.
- **Witnessed.** Someone was there and saw it. Not watched, not assessed. Being witnessed is a gift and never a demand.
- **A re-thread.** Picking the year back up after a break. The first guide day back starts with it: where were you, where are you now, what came back changed. You are never restarting cold.
- **The pace question.** The guide asking whether the plan still matches the speed your real life is running at.
- **The re-ask.** The guide asking, out loud, *is this still yours?* It is not a mood check and it is not rhetorical. “No” and “I don’t know” are both real answers, and it gets asked at points in the year where there is still time to act on the answer.
- **The Impossible Question.** The question with no clean answer that opens every guide day, after the settle and the circle, argued for fun. “Could we end loneliness?” Nobody is meant to answer it. It is practice at standing inside something too big to close.
- **Your dragon.** The one problem you carry all year, named precisely enough to work on. “Everything sucks” is not a dragon. “Nobody my age in this town has anywhere to be on a Friday night” is.
- **A fact of life.** A hard thing you cannot act on and have to accept. Fighting one wears you out and tells you it was your fault.
- **How-Might-We.** A complaint turned into a question with a door in it. “History is pointless” becomes “how might we make it matter?”
- **The Iceberg.** The problem you can see on top, and the bigger thing underneath that it sits on.
- **The 5 Whys.** Ask “why?” of a problem, then “why?” of the answer, about five times, until you reach the bottom. Run it more than once; most problems have more than one root.
- **The Three Circles.** Three rings for sorting your worries: what you can control, what you can influence, what you can only be concerned about.
- **Your arena.** The slice of your problem where your own action moves something. A small arena is not a small person.
- **A starter quest.** One small real problem inside your arena that you can finish, so you have moved something before the big one.

- **The Commons Problem.** One problem the whole tribe argues into choosing together and carries as a "we." It gets its own talk at the end of the year, given by everyone at once; we call that talk the chorus.
- **The relay.** You are one hand in a relay that began before you and goes on after you. Carry it your distance and pass it well. Nobody is asked to solve it alone.
- **A lever, and the ladder of levers.** A lever is where a small push moves a lot. The ladder: change a number, change a rule or who enforces it, change the goal, change the story everyone believes. The obvious levers are usually the weakest.
- **The shadow of the problem.** The uncomfortable truth inside a problem that nobody wants to say, which is usually why it stays unsolved. We look at the shadow of the problem, never the shadow of you.
- **The Call to Action.** The talk you may give at year's end: here is a problem worth solving, why it got to me, what I did, what I ask of you. It is the harvest, and it is a feast, not a judged presentation.
- **A Call to Repair.** The other shape the talk takes when the honest finding is that something went wrong: here is what I owe, who leads this, how you join them. A whole talk, not a lesser one.
- **Open Waters.** The loose three weeks after the Call to Action: expeditions, your own projects, credit close-out, and real rest.
- **The short Origin.** If you are joining this year, the small version of the first year's three things, built in your own work time across the first four weeks. Nobody grades it and nobody can see who is doing it.

What you make and carry

The Captain's Log. You have one artifact that travels with you across all three years: your Captain's Log. It is a record of your own life and your own thinking. You name it yourself. You write in it however you write. It belongs to you, completely. A guide never reads it to grade you or check up on you. The moment a private log becomes something someone else reads to judge you, it stops being yours, and this one stays yours. You will carry it out the door when you leave, and no copy is kept, because the moment there is a copy somebody else is holding your life.

If you are joining this year, your Log starts now, on your first day, the same first page everyone else started with. Every Log starts empty. Yours starts now.

The Vineyard. Alongside the Log runs a second thread called the Vineyard. It was named on your first day here, whichever year that was, on the same morning the Captain's Log was named. The two are twins. The Log is the self examined; the Vineyard is the self delighted. The Vineyard is whatever you tend purely because you love it, for no useful reason at all: a garden, a song you are learning, a craft, a friendship, a wandering, a game, an album on the floor. Nobody harvests it.

Nobody asks you to write a reflection on it. Nobody makes it count for anything. The instant someone tries to make the Vineyard *useful*, it dies, which is why the rule protecting it is written as hard as the rules about safety. It is here because the whole point of these three years is to make the hard call **and still love your life**, and that half of the thing cannot wait for the last year. If you are joining this year, you name your own Vineyard-thing in the first week, too.

When, and this is the one part that is required. Making time for something you love is a requirement of this programme. Not a particular thing, not a certain number of hours, and not anything you hand in. The requirement is that the time is in your week and that something you love is in the time. Friday is already yours and is the obvious home. Nobody ever checks what you did with the time. The only question anyone will ever ask is *is the time there*. The requirement binds us to keep making room for it. It does not bind you to fill the room.

The promises (the six refusals)

Underneath everything, there is a floor of promises. Nothing in the Launch Pad is allowed to break these. In plain words:

1. **No grades or scores anyone but you can see.** Your progress is yours. High-school credit is the one honest exception, and it is explained at the end of this Part.
2. **No ranking and no leaderboards.** You are never stacked against the person next to you. A parent linked to your account can see which of your own goals you have finished, and that is the whole of what anyone else sees. If that ever stops being exactly true, you will be told before it changes, not after.
3. **No one deposits the answers into you.** You make meaning here; the guide holds questions and walks with you, and does not hand you a finished answer.
4. **No imposed deadlines.** You set your own pace. “I didn’t get to it” is honored, not punished.
5. **Your worth is not your output.** A quest you abandoned and learned from counts as much as one you finished. Doing more does not make you worth more.
6. **No surveillance.** The data of your life belongs to you, not to the school. This promise is about a short list of what gets written down about you, and the list is at the end of this Part so you can check it.

And one more, which sits on top of the six:

You may refuse the structure itself. If you decline a whole quest, you are fully honored. You are not quietly marked down as a failure or an opt-out. Your no is real.

Where your no reaches, and where it stops

Here is the edge of that last promise, said now rather than discovered later.

Your no covers your own work. A quest, a prompt, an expedition, a share, a whole session, this entire structure. It lands the moment you say it, it costs you nothing, and nobody can overrule it.

It does not cover how you treat the people in the room with you. That is not a deadline and it is not output. It is the floor that makes everything else here safe for the other people in the room, and it is the one place in this programme where something can actually be taken from you. The studio's agreements run that floor, and they have their own ladder: a Pause, then a Stop, then a Strike. You will meet it in your first week, and you will help write the agreements it rests on. The count clears at the start of every year, so nothing from last year walks in with you.

So, in one line: **the agreements are about how we treat each other. The promises are about whether you do the work.**

Declining a quest is never a Pause. A Pause is never a judgement on your work, your pace, or whether you are keeping up. If anyone ever runs those two together, they have got it wrong, and you can say so out loud and point at this page.

And if you do not sign. You are in the room anyway, and that was never the price of being here. The agreements still run for you, and here is the honest reason rather than a convenient one: they are not holding you to your word, because you did not give it. They are holding the room safe for the people in it with you. You can tell us the agreements are not yours. You cannot be outside the floor, because **the floor is not about you.**

How we work: the week

The studio day runs through the morning, 9:00 to 1:00. Across the week, two mornings are guide days and two are your own.

- **Guide days (Tuesday and Thursday).** The guide runs the studio with you. The order of the morning is below, and it is the same every time. What differs this year is the middle: Tuesday's work is lighter, and Thursday holds the week's one deep block. That is on purpose. The guide is running the studio solo in a week that is otherwise parenting a toddler, with childcare for the two guide mornings and no more, and chose the shape that holds rather than the shape that looks fuller, and says so out loud. Choosing the sustainable shape and naming it is itself part of what this place teaches.

- **Your-own days (Monday and Wednesday).** You run your own morning: your reading, your core academics, your personal project, and the session's writing. Nobody is steering but you. This year the guide is not in the building on your own days: they have left Vibrant Life Tots and are at home with their child on the mornings they are not with you. Who is in the building on those mornings, and how the midday check-in happens, is not settled yet; it will be written here, plainly, before any family is handed this book, because a learner should never find out on a Monday who is and is not down the hall.
- **The fallow day (Friday).** Protected. Never earned, never filled, never converted back into work. It is for rest, play, friendship, and making things for no reason. This is not a reward for finishing. It is practice for a whole life. And it is binding: it does not get eaten to cover a busy week. It is for you and for the guide both.

A guided morning, start to finish

Guide days run 9:00 to 1:00. The order is the same on both days, so you never walk in wondering what today is. What changes between Tuesday and Thursday is the middle block.

Time	What happens
9:00 - 9:25	**The walk-in.** Door open, nothing required. Put your things down, make tea, talk or don't. The guide is here and will come find one or two people for a quiet one-to-one.
9:25 - 9:35	**The settle, then the circle.** Three breaths, the same words every time. Then one round of "how are you, really?" You may pass.
9:35 - 10:50	**The Work of the Day.** Tuesday: the Impossible Question, then the lighter work - a game, a group challenge, hands-on building, planning an expedition. Thursday: the week's one deep block. This is the part that changes week to week. The rest of this table does not.
10:50 - 11:00	**The way down.** Stand, shake it out, step outside, water. Then we eat.
11:00 - 11:40	**The Table.** We eat together. You bring your own lunch.
11:40 - 12:40	**Hands and each other.** Making, building, service prep, an errand into the world, a project with somebody else. Different from the morning's work on purpose: the body works and the talking gets easy.

Time	What happens
12:40 - 1:00	**The close.** One light thing, then your closing minute, then you go.

The times are honest rather than strict. Most days drift ten minutes. The order never drifts.

Expedition Tuesdays leave the building (Session 4's second week, and the service weeks of Session 6), so the grid bends: the guide tells you the day before where we gather, when we go, and when we are back. The walk-in, the Table and the close still happen; they happen where we are.

The Table

Every guide day has a shared meal in the middle of it. Here is exactly how it goes.

You bring your own lunch. On ordinary days the studio does not provide the food.

It is still a shared table rather than a lunch break. We stop, sit down together, and the guide sits and eats with you. The forty minutes is for being a group of people who eat together, not for getting through food on the way to the next thing.

You sit wherever you want. Seats are not assigned, and nobody's seat is kept from last week.

You do not have to eat. Presence is the whole requirement here, never consumption. If you are fasting, or observing, or not hungry, or food is a hard thing for you right now, you sit with us and that is full participation. Nobody watches anybody's plate, and you never owe anyone an explanation for what is or is not on yours.

If you arrive late, come in and sit down. Nothing restarts, and nobody asks where you were in front of the room.

On the one day a year when there *is* shared food, the feast after the Call to Action in the last week, tell the guide what you cannot eat, once, whenever you know it. Planning around it is the guide's job rather than yours to work around. That day the studio provides the base of the meal, and bringing a dish is never required. If you want what the studio brings to stand as yours, say so to the guide once, privately, and it will. Nobody at the table will know the difference, and nobody will ask.

On an expedition your lunch travels with you, the same as any guide day, and the guide says the day before where we eat and when. If the place we visit serves food to people who need it, that food is theirs. We eat what we brought, where the host says, or after we leave. Being a guest is part of what the expedition teaches.

The circle: “how are you, really?”

Right after the settle, every guide day, we go around once. The question is “how are you, really?” and it means the real answer rather than the automatic one.

Here is how it goes. The guide asks, and answers first, honestly and briefly. Then it goes around in order, so nobody is picked on and nobody has to volunteer. One or two sentences each is plenty. “Tired.” “Good, actually.” “I don’t want to say today.” Those are complete answers.

You can always pass. Say “pass” and it moves on, with no follow-up and no note taken. Passing is not a smaller answer. A person who passes has been round the circle the same as everyone else.

Nobody fixes what you say here unless you ask. Advice that arrives unasked is not help, so the circle starts from being heard.

But you can ask, and you can ask the room. “Does anyone know what to do about this?” is a completely normal thing to say in a circle, and so is “I just wanted to say it, I don’t want to talk about it.” Both are answers to the same question, and the question is yours: **do you want this held, or do you want it worked?** Say which and the room will follow you. Six people who know you is not a smaller resource than one guide, and some things a sixteen-year-old knows better than any adult in the building.

If you would rather not ask in front of everyone, that is equally fine. Say so, or say nothing and catch the guide afterwards.

It takes a few minutes. It is not a check-up, and nothing said in it is written down. Then the Impossible Question, which comes after the circle on purpose: you cannot stand inside something enormous while nobody in the room knows you are tired.

Who else is in the room

There are a handful of you and one of me. My child is not in the studio this year. On the two guide mornings they are with their childcare, arranged before the year opens, and the rest of the week I am with them; that is the honest shape of this year, and it is why the year runs two guide mornings and not more. The first year, my child was in the room with us, worn. This year you get all of me on the mornings I am here. If the childcare falls through on a guide morning, you will be told that morning what the day is: the deep block waits for the next guide day and the morning turns into hands and each other, or the morning is called off before anyone arrives. That is the design working, not a lost day, and you will be told which it is rather than left to guess. On expedition days the childcare covers the travel time too, and that is planned per outing.

One thing you should hear plainly. If you ever need all of me, a hard day or a conversation that cannot be interrupted, say so. On a guide morning there is nothing to hand off; you have me.

Arriving late, stepping out, coming back

Arriving late. Walk in. There is no procedure and nothing restarts. If the circle is going, join where it has got to, or pass. If the settle is going, sit down and pick it up on the next breath. Nobody will ask you in front of the room where you were. If something made you late and you want the guide to know, catch them at the Table. On an expedition Tuesday the group leaves the building, so if you are late and we have gone, call the number the guide gives you in the first week and we work out the honest option together. Nobody asks why in front of anyone.

Coming back after stepping out. The soft parts of the day are named so you know where the easiest way back in is: the walk-in, the Table, and the hands block after it. You can come back at any moment, including the middle of a hard one. The soft seams are just the ones where nothing has to be said at all. Nobody says anything to you when you come back. Not even “glad you’re back.” You pick up a plate or pick up a tool and you are in.

The Log, captured however you hold it

You keep the Captain’s Log in whatever form is true to you. Written in a notebook. Spoken aloud and recorded. Drawn. Dictated. Typed. Told to a scribe who writes it down for you. No form is the lesser Log. The point is that you are keeping your own record, not that it looks a certain way.

Where it lives. Your Log can go home with you, or stay here somewhere only you open, or both, and you can change your mind any time. If you want it to stay here, say so and nobody asks why. It is not kept in the Compass or on any school computer, and no copy is made, because the moment there is a copy somebody else is holding your life.

When you write in it. There is no Log time and nobody will ever call one. Here is where the room has room for it, and all of these are open rather than expected:

- **The walk-in**, the first twenty-five minutes of a guide day. Nothing is required then, so if you came in with something on your mind, that is the place to put it down before the day starts asking things of you.
- **Right after your closing minute**, at the end of a guide day. This is the natural one.
- **Your own mornings**, Monday and Wednesday. Your block, your call, no check-in about it. When the week’s flow says “Log” on your own days, that is a place the day has room for it, never a thing anyone checks.

- **Friday**, if you want it. Friday is also a fine day to deliberately not write. A record you have to feed every day stops being a record and becomes a chore, and **there are supposed to be days you skip.** Weeks, even. A Log with gaps in it is not a failed Log; it is what an honest one looks like.

One rule about this, and it is for the guide as much as you: **nobody writes on a bell.** We will never all sit down and write at the same time, because the moment that happens, everyone can see who is writing and who is not, and the only thing that makes this yours is that nobody is watching. Your Log is private in what it says and private in whether you touched it today.

How “no” works here

You may decline anything. **Your no takes effect the moment you say it, and it is not conditional on explaining yourself.** This is called **decline-with-reasoning**, and here is the honest shape of it.

You can say no to any quest, any prompt, any expedition, any share, and the no lands straight away. Nothing is held up while you find words.

The reasoning is still owed. Two things about that, and they matter equally. **It is owed to your tribe, not to the guide.** You are in a room with other people whose work and plans move around yours, so they get to know where you stand. It is not a toll you pay an adult for permission. And **it is not owed in the moment.** “I don’t know yet, and I’ll come back to you” is a real answer. Take a day. Take the week. Work it out in your Log first and come back when you have it. A reason you had to produce on the spot is not thinking, it is pressure.

The guide may ask you an honest, curious question about it, the way a friend might. But the guide **has a voice, never a veto.** The guide cannot overrule your reason, and cannot require you to have one ready. The question is a mirror, not a test you can fail.

There is one place where even the curious question is set aside: anything to do with official papers and government forms, which this year’s life-admin work touches. There, an honest reason for declining might reveal something private about your legal situation that a guide has no business knowing. So on that one surface, your no needs no reason at all.

The settle

Every guide day opens with a short, body-first way in, and there is a matching way down when something gets heavy. This is fixed, and it is yours to keep for life.

- **The way in (the settle).** Three slow breaths with the out-breath longer than the in-breath (roughly four counts in, six counts out), feet flat, one hand where you feel your breath. The guide paces it out loud, the same way every time. The out-breath is what tells your body it is safe to settle. No app, no playlist, no special frequency. Just a human voice, used the same way on purpose. It is the same three moves every day, all three years, because the sameness is what lets it become yours.

- **The way down.** After hard work stirs the body up, you stand, shake it out, take a short walk, move the activation *through* the body before sitting back down. If standing or walking is not yours, any movement that is - shaking out your hands, rolling your shoulders, rocking - does the same work. You cannot metabolize a stress spike sitting still. This is thirty seconds to a few minutes, and it comes before the shared meal, because an activated body cannot receive a meal as belonging.

- **The way out (the exit ramp).** There is a named place you can step out to, set up in the first week. You do not have to ask. And there is a designed way back in during a soft part of the day, with no scene, no acknowledgment demanded. Stepping out and coming back costs you nothing. This is the room holding a door open for you, never the room watching you for a fall.

- **The way back (the close-return).** After a day that went somewhere heavy, the room says out loud that the heavy part is over, so your body hears it and not just your head. These words do not change either:

  > *"That was then. This is now. Look around and name one thing you can see. You're in this room, and the hard part is behind you."*

  It sounds almost too simple to do anything. It works because a body that has been inside a hard thing for an hour does not automatically notice that the hour ended, and being told, in words, is how it notices. Solo version, for the rest of your life: *that was then, this is now, and I'm here.*

The closing minute

At the close of an opening - a problem that got to you, a hard conversation, a look at the shadow of a problem - you take a quiet minute and cross back through three fixed questions. They are always the same, in the same order:

1. **What did I meet?**
2. **What do I carry back?**
3. **What's different in me now - even a little?**

That is the whole practice. It is spoken or held in your head, never written down for the studio, never read by anyone. It is yours. It runs at the close of every guide day, light days included, because a practice used only on heavy days never becomes the one you reach for at forty.

Reach for the real answer. Taking the first thing that comes to mind and moving on makes this worth almost nothing. Staying in the question for a whole minute and letting something come up makes it worth a great deal, and **something almost always comes up, if you stay open long enough to hear it.** That takes a kind of nerve. It is the same nerve the rest of this year asks for.

"I don't know yet" is a real answer, not because the question has no answer, but because sometimes the true one has not surfaced, and naming that beats manufacturing something to have said. "Nothing's different, and I'm steadier for having looked" is also true and complete, because steadier is a change.

But you will know the difference between *I don't know yet* and *I didn't look*. Nobody else ever will. Nobody reads this, nobody asks about it, and no one can tell from the outside whether you reached or shrugged. **This is the one practice here that runs entirely on your own honour**, and what you do with a quiet minute when nobody is checking is worth knowing about yourself.

The one adult outside the room

There is one adult, outside the studio, you can always talk to. You will know who they are and how to reach them in the first week, before you ever need them.

One honest line about breaks, said now. When the studio is on a break - the short ones between sessions, Thanksgiving, the two weeks at winter, and the summer - the guide is not reachable. A break is rest and reset for them too, and the book protects that the same way it protects your Friday. The one adult outside the room is reachable across every break, the same as always. And if you are ever in danger, or someone else is, **988** is free, open all day and all night, and you can call or text it from anywhere. Nobody here will ever be upset that you used it.

And this is the honest shape of privacy, said on the first day rather than saved for the moment it matters. Almost everything stays here. Your Captain's Log, nobody reads. Your closing minute is never written down by anyone.

Here is what doesn't. If the guide believes you are in danger, that someone is hurting or neglecting you, or that something is going on that is bigger than a studio morning can hold, they will bring in real help. That includes talk of suicide or self-harm, abuse or neglect, something going wrong with eating, a crisis with drugs or alcohol, a panic or a flashback they cannot reach you through, a threat to someone else, or something that keeps going and is getting in the way of your life.

Those are two different things and they have different consequences, so both get named. **Abuse or neglect is a report**, and in Idaho the guide is required by law to make it. **Everything else on that list is a hand-off**, which means they stop the session work and help you get to someone trained, you will be told who, and you get a say in which one and when.

In most of those cases they will also call your parent or guardian, and they will tell you they are making the call. The one exception is if your parent or guardian is the person hurting you. Then the call goes to the state rather than to them.

That is the whole list. It is not one secret trapdoor, and the guide will never go looking for a reason to use it. **What they know is only what you chose to tell them.** None of this is breaking trust. It is what care actually looks like.

What gets written down about you

Short answer: very little, and you can read all of it.

- **Your Captain's Log and your Vineyard.** Yours. Nobody reads them. No copy is kept.
- **Your closing minute.** Never written down at all, by anyone.
- **Your witnessed work** - your named dragon, your plan and prototype, what you did with real people, your Call to Action. The guide sees what you bring into the room, and so do the people you choose to show. That is what bringing it means.
- **The guide's own notes.** A short practical record: attendance, your pace and your credit plan, and a factual note if there is ever a safety event, meaning what happened, what they did, and who they called. A safety note never contains what you wrote or said about your own life.
- **Your Growth Record, in the Compass.** The one record here that is built to leave with you. It works differently from everything else on this list, so it has its own section below.
- **The agreements record, if you ever reach a Stop.** Our studio agreements run on a ladder: a Pause, then a Stop, then a Strike. The Stop and the Strike are the two rungs that make paper. A Stop note says what happened and goes home the same day, you fill it out

with your guide, and the line about coming back is yours in your own words. A Strike letter lists the dates of the three Stops. Your character contract is yours, in your handwriting, and a copy stays with Jenna, who runs the school, while you are working it. All of it records a choice and never a judgement about who you are, the count clears at the start of each year, and none of it goes on a transcript or travels with your Growth Record.
- **What is never kept.** Scores. Rankings. Assessments of your character written by anyone but you. Any note about you that you have not read. Any file that follows you past this year.

You can ask to read anything written about you, at any time, and the guide will show you. If you think a note is wrong, say so, and it gets corrected. That includes a Pause, a Stop or a Strike: if you think a call was wrong, say so, and it can come off - off the note and off the count. You do not have to be calm about it. A learner who is angry at an unfair call is giving us information, not failing a condition.

That is the whole of it. “No surveillance” is a promise about this list, and the list is short on purpose.

The Growth Record, and whether any of this counts on paper

You are sixteen to eighteen, so a fair question about any year of your life is whether it counts on paper. Here is the straight answer.

The Compass holds a record called your **Growth Record**, and the whole design of it is that you own it and the studio does not. The app is a lens, not a vault: you hold the keys from the first day, and a guide is a guest whose access ends when the relationship does. A school cannot lose, withhold or hold hostage a record it never held in the first place.

It has two faces, and you control which one anybody sees.

- **The Journey view** is the whole trail, in order, with the slow parts and the stalls in it. It stays private. It is yours.
- **The Portrait view** is the one you would hand a college, an employer or a programme. It is framed as what you can actually do, and **you choose what goes into it, piece by piece.** Nobody assembles your Portrait for you, and nobody sends it anywhere without you.

One rule holds across both, and it is built into the thing rather than promised about it: growth here is only ever shown as **movement compared to your own earlier self.** Never a grade. Never a score. Never set beside another learner.

And the honest limit, which you should hear from us rather than discover. The part that lets the record physically leave - a real export, readable by a human, held in your hands - **is not finished yet.** It is being built. Until it exists, nobody walks the Launch at the end of the three years, because a ceremony that hands you something that is not there is not a ceremony. That rule reaches anyone leaving at the end of this year too: the leaving rite in Part 4 is the same Launch, with the same condition. That is a rule the programme put on itself before any learner was in the room.

Two more things, said plainly. High-school credit is tracked separately, and it is the one record other people read as a routine matter, which is the honest exception to the first promise. And a transcript from a studio like this one is not yet a thing every college recognises; the bridge to dual enrollment is real work and we will do it alongside you rather than pretending it is already finished.

Joining at the Forge (a note for a learner starting here)

You do not have to have done the first year to start The Forge. Some learners begin their Launch Pad story right here, and that is a real beginning, not a late one.

Origin does one quiet job: it gives a person three things to stand on. The Forge leans on those three things, so if you are joining here, you will build a short version of them in your own work time over the first few weeks. We call it the short Origin. In plain terms, the three things are:

- **A self named.** Some sense of who you are and what you dream about. You will do a fast version of naming your own dreams, on the same card Origin uses: a hundred is the target, not a gate, and borrowed dreams count.
- **Agency claimed.** The felt knowledge that your choices matter and that you can move some things in your life. You will take a quick stock of what you actually have to work with.
- **A routine that holds.** A rhythm for your days that fits you, so the work has somewhere to live.

There is a card for each one, in print, in large print, and read aloud on a recording, so you can take it in the way you take things in. You build them in your own-day blocks across the first four weeks, and the midday check-in on those days is where you ask about them. They can be picked up again any time, they are never a test, and nobody grades them. Nobody can see who is doing them. By the time the group names the problem each person will carry, most people have enough of “what’s mine” to name a problem that is genuinely theirs; if you don’t yet, you carry a smaller problem or a placeholder, and that is a real start. In the shared work, you are a full Forge learner from the very first day. There is no catch-up table.

Part 2 - For the guide: teaching this year

The shape of the year, and naming the destination on day one

The Forge runs the full Vibrant Life year, mid-August to late May, on the school's calendar rather than a tidy one of its own, and it takes the same shape as Origin: seven sessions with a break between each, thirty-one weeks of session work, plus the three-week Open Waters tail, for thirty-four program weeks in all. The sessions are **not** equal lengths. They are set by where the breaks fall.

The Forge 2028-2029. A program week is Monday to Thursday: two guide mornings (Tuesday and Thursday), two the learners run themselves (Monday and Wednesday), and Friday fallow.

Session	Dates	Weeks
S1 Naming the Dragon	Aug 14 - Sep 7	4
session break	Sep 11 - 14	
S2 The Detective	Sep 18 - Oct 19	5
session break	Oct 23 - 26	
S3 My Arena	Oct 30 - Nov 16	3
Thanksgiving	Nov 20 - 24	
S4 The Wider Field	Nov 27 - Dec 14	3
Winter break	Dec 18 - 29	
S5 The Long Game	Jan 1 - Feb 8	6
session break	Feb 12 - 15	
S6 Hands to Work	Feb 19 - Mar 29	6
session break	Apr 2 - 5	
S7 The Call to Action	Apr 9 - May 3	4
Open Waters (flex tail)	May 7 - May 24	3

Five Mondays inside sessions are holidays: Labor Day (Sep 4) in S1, the second Monday of October (Oct 9) in S2, New Year's Day (Jan 1) as S5's first day, MLK Day (Jan 15) in S5, and Presidents Day (Feb 19) on S6's first day. A Monday here is a self-run morning rather than a

guided one. One guide day in S3 is a holiday: Election Day, Tue Nov 7, a presidential election that year. Whether the studio observes it is decided before S3 opens. Veterans Day falls on a Saturday that year and is observed on Fri Nov 10, a fallow day, so it takes no program day.

These dates take Origin's 2027-2028 shape and begin it on Monday, August 14, 2028, around that year's real Thanksgiving week. They are a projection. One thing the real calendar will move: as printed, New Year's Day is S5's first Monday, so expect the winter break a week later. Jenna, who runs the school, sets the real dates. Confirm them before anything is printed for a family.

The sessions below are cut to these weeks. Where the calendar gave a session more weeks than its plan, the extra went to one of two places: air, so the threshold rites and the learner's own dig each get a day of their own, and the year's one fallow week, named as such in Session 2. Nothing was added because a week existed.

Every session ends into a break, so every session carries the same two seams. On the last guided day, the carry-out: the pace question, the harvest, and the closing minute at session scale. On the first guided day back, the re-thread. The re-ask is rarer and is asked three times, where there is still time to act on the answer: at the winter break, which is The Wider Field's last guided day; after The Long Game; and on the year-close day. The agreements are open for reopening at every session's close too - say so on the last guided day, every time, so the handle is real and not only promised in week one.

On day one, name where the year is going. Say it plainly:

> *"In May, you'll stand up in front of a room and tell them what's worth solving and what you're asking of them. We call it the Call to Action. Everything between now and then is getting ready to mean it."*

A destination named on day one is a gift, not a deadline; it gives the whole year a shape the learner can feel. No week count in the line: the count is not settled, and a date that moves is a promise broken.

The year opens with a shared threshold that the whole room crosses together - returners and joiners in the same doorway, never a remedial side door for the new arrivals. Returners re-open their Origin Captain's Log and pull one dream forward: "which of your one hundred dreams is a problem you could act on? Which broke your heart enough to name?" Origin's harvest becomes The Forge's premise. This is offered, never required - a returner may carry a wholly new dream, and that is theirs to choose.

For any learner joining mid-cycle, three things make “joining in progress” real rather than a polite word for behind: the Captain’s Log from day one, peer-witness pairs in which each witnesses the other naming a dream (not tutoring, witnessing), and the short Origin built quietly in their own work blocks across the first four weeks. Pair everyone, mixed, and only where both have said yes; a pairing that marks the joiner is the catch-up table the learner’s page says does not exist. No visible catch-up.

The year’s daily ritual: the Impossible Question

Every guide day opens, after the settle and the circle, with an Impossible Question - a question with no clean answer, debated playfully. The circle comes first because you cannot stand inside something enormous while nobody in the room knows you are tired. “Could we end loneliness?” “Can one person change a system?” The point is never to answer it. The point is to grow comfortable standing inside something too big to close.

Name it plainly when it begins: this is the same muscle you have been building since the first year. In Origin it was small choice games - making real decisions and feeling their consequences. Here it grows into standing inside questions too big to close. In the final year it becomes the hard call inside a no-win. Small choices, then big questions, then the hard call - one continuous muscle, deepening. Say so at each handoff or the three-year payoff goes silent.

The safety floor

You are a life-coach and a mentor, not a licensed clinician. This year surfaces real problems, real heartbreak, and hard days by design. Clinical material will come up. Your job is not to treat it - it is to recognize it, hold the moment safely, and route it to real help fast.

The settle, the way down, the exit ramp, the close-return. These moves are fixed and run every guide day (see Part 1; the learner reads the same words you do). Open with the settle. Fix your own wording for it in the first week, write it down, and then do not improve it, because the sameness is the medicine: a settle improvised fresh each day never becomes the reflex a body can drop into without thinking, and if it goes stale to you, that is it working. Seat the way down in the seam between a deep block and the shared meal, and again at the end of any day that ends heavy - do not send a learner home on a still-activated body. Keep the exit ramp real: a named place, a no-scene re-entry. Say the close-return in its fixed words after any day that went somewhere heavy. And run the closing minute at the close of every guide day, light days included; “take your closing minute” is the whole prompt, and you never ask what came up.

The referral pathway, in plain terms. Some things are past coaching, and when you see them you route, you do not work them in a session. Route now, do not coach, if you see or hear any of these: any mention of suicide, self-harm, or not wanting to be here; abuse, neglect, or someone hurting them; a crisis happening right now: panic, a flashback, feeling cut off from their own body, or distress you cannot reach; signs of something going wrong with eating; a crisis with drugs or alcohol; a threat to someone else; something past an ordinary hard day: it keeps going, and it is getting in the learner's way. When in doubt, route. Being sure is a clinician's job, not yours.

In the moment: stay with the learner, never leave them alone; move to the quiet space you prepared before the year opened; be present and calm and listening; do not fix, do not ask for details, do not counsel; do not promise a secrecy you cannot keep. In Idaho everyone is a mandatory reporter, including you - suspected abuse or neglect gets reported, ideally within twenty-four hours, and you do not need proof, because the law gives the judging to the state; your job is to tell, theirs to find out. For immediate danger, 988 (call, text, or chat) or 911 if life-threatening. This duty does not give you a key to the Log. You do not read it, so it cannot be a source. What the duty reaches is what a learner tells you, shows you or hands you, and what you see and hear in the room. Say that distinction out loud on day one: the Log is never read, and what you are told, you may have to act on. The named local therapist you can warm-refer to must be a real person arranged before the year opens - "route to real help" is only real if the help is real. The pathway runs across breaks, not only on program days, and the learner is told so before each one.

Keep confidences safe. Say the privacy words on day one, woven into the promises you make each other, and say them as written rather than improvising a warmer version, because a learner who hears a different wording than the one they read goes looking for the seam:

> *"Almost everything you write and say here is yours. Your Captain's Log, nobody reads - including me, and I won't go looking. What I can't keep private is a short list, and I'd rather you hear it now than find out later: if you're in danger, if someone's hurting you, or if something's going on that's bigger than I can hold here. That's when I bring in real help, and usually that means a call home too. I'll tell you when I'm doing it. That's not breaking trust - it's what care actually looks like."*

Those are the same promises that are on the learner's privacy page in Part 1, in your own voice. A confidentiality limit named up front is a promise kept. Named in the moment, it feels like betrayal.

After any hard moment, debrief with your own named person - do not carry it alone. Document factually and minimally: what happened, what you did, who you contacted, never the learner's private content, because a safety note holding their own words becomes the copy of their life the Log promise forbids.

The real-service guardrails

This year the work goes out to real people, and that raises the stakes. Hold these:

- **Design with, never for.** The learner designs the work alongside the people who have the problem, not on their behalf, because the people who have the problem are the only ones who can say whether it moved; a fix designed for them is the fixer's idea of their life. Talk to real, affected humans, early and often, and let them shape the work.
- **Never do service *at* a community as a lesson.** The community names its own need. A project does not touch real people until a named community member is invited (not just interviewed for data) and agrees - to the project, its terms, and a way to say "stop." They are the one party this year that did not enrol here, so their yes is the only thing that makes this service rather than practice on them. Between the invitation and the yes there is a wait, and the wait is the work.
- **Name where the benefit flows, up front.** If the honest answer is "they are part of my learning project," that is the savior trap, and naming it early is how you catch it. The harvest sits with the community's verdict - "did this serve you?" - not the learner's guess.
- **Build in a repair clause.** If a project lands wrong on the people it touched, there is a calm, named way to make it right. Repair is part of the service, not its failure, because a project with no way to be set right has no way to be told it went wrong, and the people it touched will not tell you without one.
- **Relationships outlast the harvest.** No drive-by service. Affected voices lead early, not consulted at the last minute. And no one's story enters the final talk without their consent, because a story is the strongest thing in a talk, which is exactly why it must belong to the one who lived it. Consent reaches back: what they take back comes out of the talk.
- **Do not send a learner into a situation heavier than the support around them.** With people who are easily harmed, match the mode to the learner's readiness; stay close. Service should stretch, not wound, because stretch is the point and a wound teaches the wrong thing. Any work with people who are easily harmed gets a real adult's support, and so does the graceful ending of any community relationship.

Holding a “no”

Decline-with-reasoning lives or dies in the single moment a learner actually says no. If that moment collapses into invisible opt-out - silence, the activity just continues around them - the learner is protected by being erased from the room. So hold a no in three beats, and you can run them under load:

1. **Receive the no, whole.** “Okay. You’re not doing this one.” Honor it *before* any curiosity, so your curiosity never lands as a lever.
2. **Offer the door once, and don’t push it.** “That no stands, and it’s done. When you’ve worked out what’s behind it, the tribe will want to hear it. Not me - them. And not today.” Hold both halves or you have turned the practice into a toll: the reasoning is genuinely owed to the room, and it is genuinely not owed in the moment. If a learner never comes back to it, that is between them and the tribe, and it is not yours to collect.
3. **Keep them inside the encounter.** “Come sit with me - you don’t have to do the thing.” Removing the task is not the same as removing the person.

Your curious question, when you offer it, stays a mirror and never a way to scare someone into yes. Ask “when do you think you’ll first run into this for real?” - never “what happens the first time you need this and no one is beside you?” The first opens a door with curiosity; the second forecasts them alone and unequipped, which lands on an anxious learner as “you’ll be sorry.” And whether a fear is “the right kind of scared” is the learner’s to name about themselves, never yours to assign. The instant you re-code a reasoned no as “avoidance” so you can override it, you have smuggled the veto back in as a diagnosis. You have a voice. You never have a veto.

Watch-fors, and protect yourself

Eco-anxiety and despair. Meeting real, world-sized problems can swamp anyone, and at sixteen it can swamp hard, which is why the field is always paired with a slice the learner can move. The whole antidote runs in two moves. First, agency: always pair the wider field with a slice the learner can actually move - you do not have to solve all of it. Second, and deeper, love: begin the outward turn with what the learner loves about being alive on this planet, before you show them the world’s hunger. Agency cures powerlessness, but only love cures despair. You fight for what you love, not against what you hate. If a learner comes grieving the world, name the grief as legitimate and sit with it before anything else - “grief is love with nowhere to go. It can sit here a while. When you’re ready, and not before, we can ask where it wants to go.” Route anything heavy to real support.

Some lives have mostly been facts of life so far. Some learners arrive with a world that has mostly been things that happened, not things to fix. That is the honest shape of some lives, not a lack in the person, and naming one small problem in reach is the whole win. A small arena is not a small person. “The quiet arena is the invitation.”

The mapper is in the map. Wherever a learner meets a problem, add the standpoint question: “Where are you inside this system? What does it let you see, and what does it hide? What do the people who live it see that you can’t?” This turns design-with from a rule obeyed into a truth understood.

Crew, never watch. Every net in this room is phrased as a crew that holds each other, never as a watch set on a fragile person. A crew keeps the person at the centre the one steering. A watch set on someone turns them into the thing being watched, and the room into the hero of their story. Do not let the safety architecture quietly make the room the hero and the learner the thing it protects.

Your own settle. You spend your own steadiness settling a room all morning, solo, in a week that is otherwise parenting a toddler. Run your own settle, your own way down at day’s end, and your own closing minute - as safety instrumentation, not as self-care. A depleted guide cannot run the watch-and-pivot the whole floor depends on. Do a weekly presence-check: “was I whole for the deep hour this week, or was I bailing water?” The lighter shape of this year *is* the floor working - a smaller tribe or a further-lightened year is the design honoring you, not you failing. What you can hold sets how many learners are in the room, and both come before money, because a learner enrolled on coverage not yet secured is one the floor cannot hold, and the day it fails is the day you find out. And there is a pre-written, honorable permission to defer the whole thing if the year outgrows the sustainable shape, written while rested because rested is the only time it can be: a depleted person does not pause on instinct.

Your fallow day is fallow too, and so are the breaks. Protected, not on-call. The learner’s page says plainly that you are not reachable over a break, so you never have to improvise that limit on the last guided day; what you say aloud before each break is who is: the one adult outside the room, and 988. Every session here ends into a break: the September break after Naming the Dragon, the October break after The Detective, Thanksgiving after My Arena, the two-week winter break after The Wider Field and its expedition, the February break after The Long Game, the April break after Hands to Work, and after the Call to Action, Open Waters and then the summer, the longest absence in the cycle. Say it on the last guided day, every time, in one fixed form: “The break starts Friday and runs [length]. I won’t be reachable - that’s my rest too. [Name] is, the whole time, not only on studio days; here is how to reach them. 988 is free and open all day and all night, call or text, from anywhere. The path to real help stays open the whole break. I’m back in the room on [day].”

Part 3 - The sessions

Each session below gives you: what it's for, a short plain intro for the learner, the flow day by day, things you might say aloud, the settle and closing minute, watch-fors, and what you'll need.

A note on the flow tables: Monday and Wednesday are your own days (you run your own hours; check-in around midday). Tuesday is the lighter guide day. Thursday is the deep guide day. Friday is fallow and closes the week. Each session header carries its calendar weeks and projected dates; the week labels inside a session count from that session's first week. The weeks inside a session follow one small grammar, and the word in brackets after each week says which beat it is: a session opens, deepens, applies, and harvests. The week the work leaves the room and comes back is a gather. A three-week session doubles up. Session 2's fourth week is named what it is: fallow.

One word about words. Part 1 said the Log is kept however you hold it, and that holds all year. When the sessions below say write, draft, or read, and when a day line says Log, they mean put it in your Log and go back to it, in whatever form yours takes. The book says write because it is the shortest word, not because it is the only way. The same holds for stand, walk, and speak: they mean take part in the way your body takes part. And anything the room listens to has a transcript in the room; anything the room reads can be heard. Both are on the table for everyone before anyone needs them; nobody has to ask.

Session 1 - Naming the Dragon (four weeks, Aug 14 - Sep 7)

What it's for: Learn the difference between a problem, a fact of life, a preference, and a mystery - and name the one problem you will carry all year, precisely enough to actually fight it.

For the learner: The first week is the threshold. You help write this year's agreements whether you were here last year or not; last year's do not carry over. Then the work. "Everything sucks" is a dragon too big and too foggy to fight. A dragon you can name - the specific, actual thing, said clearly enough that you would know what moving it looks like - is a dragon you can face. This session hands you a distinction almost no one gets handed as a teenager: some hard things are problems you can act on, some are facts of life you accept, some are just preferences, and some are mysteries you sit with. You work on each of them differently. By the end you may name the one dragon you will trace and act on all year. If you are still searching for yours, that is honest and honored - a dragon can't be forced, and "I'm still looking" is a true harvest.

The flow:

Weeks 1-4 · Aug 14 - Sep 7 · off: Mon Sep 4, Labor Day

The fourth week goes to the front, as Origin's did, and the mixed room is the stronger reason, not a weaker one. In Origin the risk was exposure among strangers. Here the risk is inheritance: a joiner signing a floor they did not write, in a room where six people already know where the cups are. A floor the returners wrote last year cannot be consented to by a joiner this year; it can only be accepted. So the first week is where the room that will live under the floor writes it, both halves as authors, carried on a shared task where history is no advantage: setting up the room for the year. No Forge content in the week.

Week 1 - the threshold (open). - **Mon (your own):** returners' own morning: re-open the Origin Log, restart the core rhythm. A joiner's first day is Tuesday, by design; one who chooses to come today is met at the door and shown the building, and the guide says who will be down the hall. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** arrival, then the door. The walk-in, the settle, the first circle with a name round and "how are you, really?" (pass is always allowed), the Table, the map of the year, and the destination named. Then the exit ramp built and walked by everyone before any promise is asked for - returners walk it again, because last year's ramp was last year's room. Then the privacy words as written, the one adult outside the room named, and breaks said. All of it carried on the shared task of setting up the room for the year: the exit-ramp place, the quiet space, the Table, the dragons wall. No Impossible Question today, no pairs, no Forge content. - **Wed (your own):** the interval: promises offered, nothing owed back. Returners, core. Joiners, the short Origin's first card in their own block, where nobody can see who is doing it. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** the tribe's own half. Say the floor first: six things this tribe cannot agree to, the six it was promised. Then the agreements, written fresh by this room - a returner who offers reads last year's aloud as a starting point, not a text, because the count cleared and the room is new - contributions on cards or aloud, named as reopenable and told when. Say what happens if a learner will not sign: in the room anyway. Then, last and separate, the carried objects for joiners: name your Log with every form on the table, name your Vineyard-thing; a returner says their Vineyard's name aloud only if they choose. The close's one light thing is the first Impossible Question, named as the handoff: the same muscle as Origin's choice games, now standing inside something too big to close. At the very end of the week, send home the dragon-watch ("notice one thing that bugs you this week") and offer the returner reach-back: "which of your hundred dreams is a problem you could act on? Bring that one next week, or a new one, or neither yet." - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 2 - the distinction (deepen). - **Mon (your own):** returners pull a dream forward, or carry a new one; joiners continue the short Origin; everyone carries the dragon-watch; core. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question, in its place from now on. Peer-witness pairs set in the walk-in, mixed, only where both have said yes, now that a yes means something. Then "Problem or Not?" - cards with real situations sorted into four buckets; the arguments over the gray cards are the whole lesson. - **Wed (your own):** apply the four buckets to the thing that

bugged you; core; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** the distinction held on real material - problem, fact of life, preference, mystery - and the Iceberg begun (the surface problem versus the thing underneath). Bridge: watch for your own dragon. - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 3 - name it precisely (apply). - **Mon (your own):** reframe one of your own complaints; core; Log; joiners continue the short Origin. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; then "Reframe-It to How Might We" as a group game - crank a complaint ("history is pointless") into an open design question ("how might we make this matter?"). A complaint is a closed door; a How-Might-We is an open one. - **Wed (your own):** apply the Iceberg to a real complaint - what's underneath it? Core; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** where's the dragon really? Each learner brings a candidate problem and works to name it precisely - not "everything sucks" but the specific, actionable thing. Bridge: refine your named dragon. - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 4 - name the dragon you'll carry (harvest). - **Mon:** Labor Day; no studio. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; share candidate dragons, and the peer-witness pairs witness each other naming one (borrowed dreams count, and a joiner has had three weeks to find one); find "problem-neighbors" (whose problem rhymes with yours - the start of collaboration); light peer feedback. - **Wed (your own):** the interval, named out loud as one: the learners run it themselves, carrying one question, handing in nothing. Late in the session they can hold their own silence, which they could not in week 1. - **Thu (deep guide day, harvest):** each learner names the dragon they'll carry, or says they are still looking. A small voluntary share. Ask the pace question; run the closing minute at session scale; say aloud who is reachable over the break, and that you are not. Bridge into Session 2: "You've named the dragon. Next: trace it to its root - the obvious villain is almost never the cause." - **Fri:** fallow, closes Session 1.

Things to say: - "A vague dragon can't be fought. A named one can. Naming precisely is half the victory." - "Is that a problem you can act on, or a fact of life you accept? A fact of life doesn't answer to effort. Fighting one can wear you out, and that's not a fault in you." - "I'm still searching for mine" - honor it whole: "That's a true harvest. You can't force a problem to matter." - "Last year's agreements were last year's room. This room writes its own."

The settle and the closing minute: open every guide day with the settle; close every guide day with the closing minute, "take your closing minute" as the whole prompt. Run it at session scale on the harvest day, Thu Sep 7, and ask the pace question before the bridge.

Watch-fors: if a learner's hard things turn out to be facts of life, they have not failed to solve anything; hold the distinction gently. Complaints can surface real pain - hold, do not treat, route if it's past coaching.

What you'll need: the "Problem or Not?" cards (real situations for the four buckets), in large print and read aloud as each is drawn, with the Iceberg drawn and also said in words; the three short-Origin cards for any joiner (dreams, what-I-have, a week that holds), each in print, large print, and audio; peer-witness pairs set by consent in week 2; the exit-ramp place, set up before Tuesday; one shared setting-up task to carry the first week; cards for agreement contributions; the map of the year to hand out; last year's agreements, for a returner to read if one offers; the one adult outside the room, written; the childcare for every guide morning, confirmed before the year opens; the quiet space and referral roster live before day one.

Session 2 - The Detective (five weeks, Sep 18 - Oct 19)

What it's for: Learn root-cause thinking - keep asking "why" until you hit the system underneath - and trace your own dragon down to the rot beneath it.

For the learner: The obvious culprit is almost never the real cause. This session you work a mystery the tribe picks, and you learn one tool, the 5 Whys: keep asking why until you reach the pattern underneath. The villain everyone suspects usually turns out to be a symptom, and the cause is a system, which means a set of choices people keep making. Then, if you want, you turn the same tool on your own dragon. There is a second half: a system is made of choices, so you also ask who is still answerable inside it. Cause and who-is-answerable, together: that is the whole of justice. Some dragons, dug into, turn out to be facts of life and not problems. That is a true finding, not a failed one. You dig as far as you choose and stop where you choose, and the dig has no finish date inside the session: the fourth week is the week the answer is allowed to not be in yet, and it is the year's one fallow week, empty on purpose.

One straight thing first: the mystery is usually a murder, the board-game kind - cartoonish, bloodless, nobody real - and the trick of it is that every suspect looks guilty until you find the system underneath. If a made-up death is not what you want to spend two weeks on, for any reason or none, there is a version with the same puzzle and no body in it: who sabotaged the harvest festival, who killed the river. Same mechanics, same twist. Ask once and nobody asks why.

The flow:

Weeks 5-9 · Sep 18 - Oct 19 · off: Mon Oct 9, Indigenous Peoples' Day / Columbus Day, in week 4

The dig has no finish date inside the session. The mystery takes two weeks and ends in a twist. Your own dragon takes as long as it takes: the tool turns to it in week 3, and week 4 is the week the answer is allowed to not be in yet. Nobody is waited on but you. "I stopped here" and "it's a fact of life" are places to stand, not places to be moved from, and nobody asks what is under them in front of the room.

Week 1 - set the mystery (open, re-thread). - **Mon (your own):** core; begin gathering facts about your own dragon from Session 1, or, if you are starting here, begin the short Origin and carry a placeholder dragon or a smaller one; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** the re-thread first - where were you, where are you now, what came back changed over the break; peer-witness pairs set for anyone new, mixed, only where both have said yes; Impossible Question; then the tribe picks the format - a ready whodunit, build-your-own mystery for another group, or a roam-the-room speakeasy - and the mystery begins (for example, "A Death at Greywater Manor," six guests, each a motive; every suspect looks guilty in turn - that's the trap). A learner starting this week has a full vote; it is the first thing the tribe decides with them in it. - **Wed (your own):** investigate the mystery; core; joiners continue the short Origin; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** introduce the 5 Whys and run it once, on the mystery - ask why of the death, then why of the answer, until it bottoms out. Name what one chain is: a ladder, and a ladder is never the whole of a system. Bridge: "Next week we start again from the same body and see whether we land in the same place." - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 2 - the twist (deepen). - **Mon (your own):** core; investigate; one more fact about your own dragon; joiners continue the short Origin; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; continue the mystery; the Iceberg revisited on the mystery - what sits under the six motives? - **Wed (your own):** core; investigate; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** run the 5 Whys three times from the same symptom, finding a different root each pass, then look for the loop where the roots feed each other. The loop is the twist: "no one murdered her; a system did." A system is a web, not a ladder. Then the arrow both ways, inside the fiction, where it is safe to practise: a system is made of choices people keep making, so who in Greywater Manor is still answerable? Where does the system stop being an excuse - for the powerful first? The mystery closes here. Bridge: "Next week the tool turns to your own dragon, if you want it to." - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 3 - the tool on your own dragon (apply). - **Mon (your own):** core; a first 5 Whys pass on your own dragon, or on your placeholder; a joiner's short Origin finishes about now and can go on being picked up; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; the Iceberg on your own dragon, in company, lightly - what is it sitting on? Low stakes: nobody reads out a root. - **Wed (your own):** core; a second pass from the same symptom; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** the transfer - the system beneath your dragon and the choices inside it. The arrow both ways, asked of the powerful first; "you can ask it of yourself if you choose to," and the choosing is the learner's. Then name the two findings out loud before anyone has made them, so nobody is surprised by their own: some dragons, dug into, are facts of life; and some digs stop before the bottom. Both are places to stand. Bridge: "Dig as far as you choose. It comes back when it comes." - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 4 - the fallow week, and it stays empty (gather). No new detective work. **This is the year's one deliberately empty stretch inside the arc, and it is un-harvested: no Work of the Day, nothing reported, nothing to hand in.** The grid still runs - the settle, the circle,

the Impossible Question, the Table, the close - and the middle block is low-stakes craft, or nothing. The temptation to refill it the first time it looks idle is the exact thing it exists to resist. The guide's work this week is the walk-in, for whoever wants to say where the dig stands: at the bottom, still going, stopped on purpose, or a fact of life. "Stopped on purpose" closes the question, and nobody is asked it twice. Nobody is behind. A root you reach under the shovel is not the root; the dig needs a week where nobody is digging. - **Mon:** off, Indigenous Peoples' Day / Columbus Day. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; then craft or nothing - if the tribe chose build-your-own, the finished mystery is handed to the group it was built for; if not, a game, or the hands block early. The dig is talked about in the walk-in, one to one, if at all. - **Wed (your own):** core; the dig, if it is still going; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** left empty on purpose. No new tool. The room is open to work your dig in company, with the guide or a problem-neighbour, for anyone who wants it, and hands and each other for anyone who does not; nobody says which they are doing. - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 5 - what's under it (harvest). - **Mon (your own):** core; finish, or leave unfinished, your 5 Whys on your dragon; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; share early root-cause findings, voluntary; find problem-neighbours by shared system - whose dragon sits on the same web as yours; the start of collaboration, and also where a learner who stopped digging can look at a neighbour's root without owning it. - **Wed (your own):** core; name the system underneath your dragon, or name where you stopped; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day, harvest):** each learner names the root or system beneath their dragon, or "fact of life," or "I stopped here," or "a placeholder, dug into" - all four equal (voluntary share). Ask the pace question. Say aloud who is reachable over the Oct 23-26 break, and that you are not. Run the closing minute at session scale. Bridge into Session 3: "You've found the system. Next: where in it can *you* actually act?" - **Fri:** fallow, closes Session 2.

Things to say: - "The obvious villain is a symptom. Underneath it is a system: things people keep doing. That's what we're looking for." - "A system isn't a ladder you climb down. It's a web. Find where the causes feed each other." - "A system explains a lot. Where does it stop explaining, and someone's choice begin? Ask it of the powerful first. You can ask it of yourself if you choose to." - "Dig as far as you choose. It comes back when it comes, and 'I stopped here' is a place to stand."

The settle and the closing minute: settle to open; the closing minute at every close, and at session scale after the harvest; the way down and the close-return on any day a learner's own root-cause dig touches something tender. The re-thread is the first thing on week 1's Tuesday; the pace question and the break line are on week 5's Thursday, Thu Oct 19, before the bridge.

Watch-fors: keep the mystery Clue-style, cartoonish, and bloodless - no graphic violence, because the mystery is a tool for root-cause, and a learner who has met real violence cannot use a tool that reopens it; the cartoon keeps the twist and drops the wound. The lighter swap is on the learner's page and offered to everyone, not produced for whoever needs it; opt-out always. This is

a strong belonging session for a newcomer - the 5 Whys needs no Origin foundation. “My dragon turned out to be a fact of life, not a problem” is a real finding, not a failure, and it gets a week before anyone asks what is under it: a finding said in the hour it is found, in front of six peers, is a verdict; one the learner has sat with is theirs. The same holds for “I stopped here.” The mystery is shared work a learner starting this week is inside from the first morning; their short Origin runs on the own-days alongside, and their dragon may be a placeholder all session.

What you’ll need: the chosen mystery materials (a ready whodunit like Greywater Manor, or build-your-own supplies, or the space set up as a speakeasy), with every clue and character sheet in a form each learner can take in alone - read, heard, or large print - so the detective work is never routed through a sighted partner; the lighter non-murder swap ready; the 5 Whys as a simple, visible frame, also said in words.

Session 3 - My Arena (three weeks, Oct 30 - Nov 16, ends into Thanksgiving)

What it’s for: Right-size the problem to the slice you can actually move, take an honest inventory of what you have to work with, and win one small real thing you can feel.

For the learner: You cannot fix all of a huge problem, and spending all your energy on the parts you can’t reach wears a person out. This session finds your arena - the place where your own action actually moves something. You sort your worries into what you can control, what you can influence, and what you can only care about. You take stock of what you have right now: skills, time, people, things. That stock is for finding what you can act with. It is not a list of what you are missing, and a short list is not a small person; some lives hand a person less to work with, and saying so plainly is honest, not failing, because the whole session is built for the slice that is actually yours, whatever its size. Then you may pick one small real problem inside your reach and try to move it. Some starter quests work. Some don’t, and what happened tells you something about the arena, not about you. “I tried and it didn’t move” and “I haven’t found my slice yet” are both real harvests.

The flow:

Weeks 10-12 · Oct 30 - Nov 16 · on a guide day: Tue Nov 7, Election Day, observance decided before the session · ends into Thanksgiving

Week 1 - the Three Circles (open, re-thread). - **Mon (your own):** core; list everything about your dragon you worry about; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** the re-thread first, short; Impossible Question; the Three Circles map (Concern / Influence / Control) - sort your worries;

watch where energy can actually act. - **Wed (your own):** core; sit with your map; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** right-sizing, by question - where does your energy move something, and where does it just burn? Concern-only turns into cynicism. Add the standpoint question: "Where are you standing inside this system? What does that let you see, and what does it hide?" Bridge: what do you actually have to act with? - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 2 - agency inventory and a starter quest (deepen, apply). - **Mon (your own):** core; agency inventory - skills, time, relationships, resources you have *now*; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; finish the agency inventory; pick a starter quest - one small real problem inside your arena to act on. - **Wed (your own):** core; scope your starter quest small enough to actually finish; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** the move from "it happens to me" to "I can act on this slice"; test the starter quest against the Three Circles - is it really in your influence or control? Bridge: begin acting. - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 3 - a thing you moved (harvest). - **Mon (your own):** act on the starter quest; core; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; act, build, or share starter-quest progress in company. - **Wed (your own):** finish the starter quest; core; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day, harvest):** a thing you moved - "this one is mine, and I moved it." Some feel it as a win; some don't yet; both count, and "it didn't move" is a harvest too. Voluntary share. Ask the pace question. This is the last guided day before Thanksgiving, Thu Nov 16: say aloud who is reachable over the break, that 988 is always open, and that you are not; run the closing minute at session scale. Bridge into Session 4: "You've moved something in your arena. Now lift your eyes - what in the wider world gets to you?" - **Fri:** fallow, closes Session 3.

Things to say: - "Energy spent only on what you can't touch tends to run out. Find the slice you can move, and spend some there." - "You don't have to solve all of it. You pick your slice." - "Where are you standing inside this system - and what does that let you see, and hide?"

The settle and the closing minute: settle to open; the closing minute at every close, and at session scale after the harvest. Re-thread on the first guide day back.

Watch-fors: this whole session is the anti-despair move - a learner swamped by world-sized problems gets handed a slice they can move. A small arena is not a small person; acting on one real thing is the win at any scale. A starter quest that didn't work is data about the arena, never a verdict on the learner.

What you'll need: the Three Circles map (a simple three-ring diagram), and the same map as three plain lists, because a ring is a picture and a list is the same thing you can hear; the agency-inventory prompt; room for starter quests to actually run on project days.

Session 4 - The Wider Field (three weeks, Nov 27 - Dec 14, ends into the winter break)

What it's for: Lift your eyes from your own arena to the world, meet real problems where they live, and choose the one that breaks your heart - the one you'll carry through the rest of the year.

For the learner: Now you look outward. We start with what you love about being alive on this planet, before anything about what's wrong with it, because people fight for what they love. Then there is an expedition, off-site, to a real place where a real problem lives - a shelter, a food bank, a council meeting - and to one living place that is not a scene of failure, so you meet the world as something you belong to, not a broken machine you stand above. You can come and not go in, or stay back, and you can skip the trip and still carry a problem. By the end you may choose the problem you'll carry: not the one you think you should care about, the one that actually gets to you. The tribe also picks one shared problem together. If nothing has chosen you yet, say so. "Nothing has broken my heart yet, and I'm still looking" is a true answer, and the year goes on with you in it.

Three things said now, before the trip. Some of these problems may already be touching your life or your family's; if we visit a place you know from the inside, you are a member of that world, not its exhibit, and you choose how much of that travels back to the room: all, a little, or none. Meeting the world's hunger can bring real grief, which is honored here, not hurried; there is a named place to step out to on the trip. And you are a guest where we go. The people there did not enrol in your year. We arrive on time, we leave when they say, and nobody there becomes a story in your talk without saying yes.

The flow:

Weeks 13-15 · Nov 27 - Dec 14 · ends into the winter break

Week 1 - the wider field (open, re-thread). - **Mon (your own):** core; notice what in the world you can't stop thinking about; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** the re-thread first, short, after Thanksgiving; Impossible Question; love before heartbreak - begin with "what do you love about being alive on this planet?" (gladness before hunger). Then the Problem Gallery - a set of real-world problems laid out to move through (global goals, local issues, environmental, social); which one won't let you go? - **Wed (your own):** core; sit with the ones that pulled you; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** "what breaks your heart?" - not what you should care about, what actually moves you. Pair every heartbreak with agency (your slice, not all of it). Bridge: come to the expedition ready to see one firsthand. - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 2 - the expedition (deepen). - **Mon (your own):** core; research a problem that pulled you; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day), the expedition:** go where a real problem lives (a shelter, a food bank, a council meeting) - and to at least one living-system site that is *not* a scene of failure (an old-growth stand, a wetland, a farm at harvest, a dark night sky). You are a thread in a living whole, not a technician above a broken machine. Ask the membership question: "How is this problem already touching your life? Where are you inside this system, not above it?" - **Wed (your own):** core; write what the expedition stirred; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** debrief the expedition; the stakeholder intro (who actually *has* this problem?); re-anchor hope, not helplessness. Bridge: which problem will you carry? - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 3 - commit to the problem (apply, harvest), and the first half of the midpoint crossing. - **Mon (your own):** core; narrow toward the problem you'll carry; map its stakeholders; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; share candidate problems; problem-neighbors (who might collaborate). - **Wed (your own):** core; commit; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day, harvest):** each learner may commit to the world-problem they'll carry, or say they are still looking, *and* the tribe deliberates one shared "Commons Problem" into being - argued together, yielded to, chosen as a *we*, to carry to a shared chorus talk at the year's end. Name the relay: "you are one hand in a relay that began before you and continues after you - carry it your distance and pass it well, not 'I must solve it.'" Voluntary share. **This week holds the true midpoint of the year, and the midpoint is the winter break itself** - the fold between here and January, crossed with the learner's body out of the room. So the crossing comes in two halves, and this half is Thu Dec 14: the look-back across Sessions 1 to 4 (the dragon named, traced, a slice moved, the eyes lifted - who are you becoming?), the pace question, the re-ask (*is this still yours?*), asked to the room and answered one at a time in the walk-in or at the Table, never round the circle, and the re-entry note to your future self, so the problem committed this morning survives two weeks of ordinary life. Say aloud who is reachable across the break, that 988 is always open, that you are not until January, and that the pathway stays live the whole time. Run the closing minute at session scale. Bridge into Session 5: "You've chosen what's worth solving. Next: can a big problem actually be solved - and how do you begin?" - **Fri:** fallow, closes Session 4.

Things to say: - "Acting on something helps with feeling powerless. For despair, what seems to help more is remembering what you love. So: what do you love about being alive?" - "Not what you should care about. What actually gets to you?" - "You're one hand in a relay that began before you and continues after you. Carry it your distance." - If grief surfaces: "Grief is love with nowhere to go. It can sit here a while. When you're ready, and not before, we can ask where it wants to go."

The settle and the closing minute: this session opens the interior wide (heartbreak, eco-despair), so it earns its close - the closing minute after the expedition and the Problem Gallery, and the way down at the end of the expedition-debrief day. Do not end the expedition day on a stakeholder map; a body that has absorbed the world's hunger needs to come home before it drives home.

Watch-fors (binding): world problems can swamp anyone in despair, and at sixteen they can swamp hard. Always pair the wider field with agency - hope, not helplessness. The expedition must not leave them crushed; some come back lit up, some flat, some tired, and the design's job is the floor, not the lift. Grief for the world is honored, not bypassed - witnessed, never excavated; route anything heavy to real support. The expedition is off-site, so the morning's childcare must cover the travel time as well - plan it per outing, and plan each site so every learner in the room can get there and take it in with the senses they have: a night sky is also cold air, quiet, and the smell of sage.

What you'll need: the Problem Gallery, each problem in a form that can be read, heard, or handled; expedition sites arranged (one problem site and one thriving living-system site), with the host told the shape of the visit; the membership and standpoint questions ready; off-site logistics and coverage planned; the number a late learner calls if the group has already left.

Session 5 - The Long Game (six weeks, Jan 1 - Feb 8)

What it's for: Learn that big problems are systems, not single heroic acts - break the impossible into a next doable step, find the real leverage, gather people, fail forward, and come out with a real plan and a first prototype.

For the learner: Things are only impossible until they're not. Nobody solves a big problem alone or in one move. This is the long session. It teaches you to break a big problem into a next real step, to find the lever where a small push moves a lot (the obvious levers are usually the weakest), to work with other people, and to treat what went wrong as information. There are three doors into it, each yours to open or leave shut: play, where being wrong is allowed; the child's question, "why not?"; and the shadow, meaning the uncomfortable truth inside a problem that people avoid. The shadow we look at is the problem's, never yours. The shadow day is one day, late in the session, and the lightest-touch day of the year: nobody will ask about your past, your family, or anything you carry, and you can sit that day out and still finish the session. You'll also be asked what pushes back if your fix works, the honest question that keeps you from playing the savior. "This problem is bigger than one year" is a real plan, and you can say it without shame.

This session opens the Monday after the winter break, and its first guided day is the second half of the midpoint crossing: the big re-thread as the whole morning, not a warm-up. Where were you, where are you now, what came back changed; the carried problem picked back up and checked against what two weeks of ordinary life showed; the safety floor said aloud again before a session that holds a shadow door. The clowning starts on the Thursday.

The flow:

Weeks 16-21 · Jan 1 - Feb 8 · off: Mon Jan 1, New Year's Day (the session's first day as projected; the real break likely moves); Mon Jan 15, MLK Day · no break inside this session

Week 1 - systems, not single acts (open, re-thread). - **Mon (your own):** core; is my problem a system? map its parts; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** the big re-thread, the whole morning (above). Nothing else is asked today. - **Wed (your own):** core; where's the leverage in my system? Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** the Impossible Question at full strength, and the clowning and play intro (failing-forward, "yes-and"). Then: can big problems be solved? Systems, not single acts; no hero alone. The leverage-ladder: tweak-a-number, then change-a-rule or who-enforces-it, then change-the-goal, then change-the-story everyone believes - and the obvious levers (a rule, more funding, more awareness) are usually the weakest. Bridge: find a lever, name which rung it's on, and a higher rung you haven't tried yet.

Week 2 - next doable steps (deepen). - **Mon (your own):** core; break the impossible into the next doable step; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; more clowning and play - the clown fails constantly and turns failure into delight; permission to be gloriously wrong. - **Wed (your own):** core; name your next doable step; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** next doable steps, and how each small win makes the next one feel possible; how a big problem yields to small, real, next steps. Ask the pace question here, Thu Jan 11, two clear weeks before the shadow door, so there is still time to act on the answer. Bridge: take one step.

Week 3 - the inner child door (deepen). - **Mon (your own):** core; take a real step on your problem; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; the inner-child door - children ask "why not?" before anyone teaches them a thing is impossible; reconnect to fearless curiosity. - **Wed (your own):** core; "why not?" applied to your problem; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** collaboration - who else is working on this? No one solves a system alone; find your collaborators. Bridge: reach one.

Week 4 - the shadow door (deepen). - **Mon (your own):** core; what's the uncomfortable truth inside your issue? Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; light, held play after the shadow prep. - **Wed (your own):** core; sit with the shadow *of the problem*; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day), the shadow:** the uncomfortable truth most big problems stay unsolved because everyone avoids it. Of the problem, never the self. Opt-out, lightest touch, invitational. Accountability with compassion: the people inside the shadow are also inside the system - repair includes them, it doesn't just defeat them. Guard against the shadow hardening into contempt for a villain. Bridge: what does naming the shadow open?

Week 5 - prototype (apply). - **Mon (your own):** core; build the smallest real prototype of a solution-step; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; prototyping in company; iterate from what happened, not what you hoped. - **Wed (your own):** core; test your prototype; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** iteration and failing-forward; change one

thing based on what actually happened. And: “if your action works, what pushes back?” Name one likely unintended consequence of your own plan - the antidote to the savior posture, which requires believing your fix does only what you meant. Bridge: refine toward a real plan.

Week 6 - a plan and a prototype (harvest). - **Mon (your own):** core; consolidate your plan; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; share plans and prototypes; peer feedback. - **Wed (your own):** core; ready your plan; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day, harvest):** a real plan plus a first prototype for acting on the problem, or honestly not yet. Voluntary share. Ask the pace question, and the re-ask (*is this still yours?*), answered one at a time in the walk-in or at the Table, never round the circle: after the long middle session, before design-with service begins, is the yes that matters, and there are ten weeks left to act on a no. Run the closing minute at session scale, Thu Feb 8, and say aloud who is reachable over the break. Bridge into Session 6: “You have a plan. Now: real action, with real people.”

Fallow every Friday, all six weeks.

Things to say: - “Big problems are systems, not single acts. No hero solves them alone.” - “The obvious levers - a rule, more funding, more awareness - are usually the weakest. What’s a higher rung you haven’t tried yet?” - “Here, being wrong is allowed. The clown gets it wrong on purpose and keeps going. You can too, and you can sit this one out.” - “What’s the uncomfortable truth inside this issue?” - never “what’s your childhood wound?” - “If your fix works, what pushes back?”

The settle and the closing minute: the shadow work is an opening, so it earns its close - the closing minute at every close, the way down and the close-return after the shadow door, and the closing minute at session scale on the last guided day. The shadow stays aimed at the problem, never at the self. The pace question sits at the close of week 2, two clear weeks before the shadow door, and again at the harvest.

Watch-fors (binding): aim shadow and inner-child work at the shadow of the *problem*, never a forced excavation of the self, because the shadow of a problem can be said in a room; the shadow of a self already has a home, the Log, and a room is not where a teenager is asked to open it. Opt-out always; the shadow comes last, lightest touch, because the two doors before it build the play that makes the third survivable. This long session runs through late winter - lighter-scope the deep days, lean on the once-weekly pivot (a deep block that has to move because of a hard day in the guide’s own home is recoverable next week), protect your own fallow, and re-thread after any break. “The honest finding is that this problem is bigger than one year” is real - name it without shame. This session ends into a break two weeks after the shadow door: say aloud who is reachable across it.

What you'll need: the ladder of levers as a simple visual and as four plain sentences in order; improv and clowning prompts, chosen so every learner plays as built - clowning lives in the voice, the face, and the hands as much as the feet; the shadow question framed carefully (of the problem, opt-out); prototyping materials; the "what pushes back?" prompt.

Session 6 - Hands to Work (six weeks, Feb 19 - Mar 29)

What it's for: Act, for real, with real people - choosing how you serve, designing the work *with* the people who have the problem, and doing something that actually leaves them better off.

For the learner: This is where you act. You choose how you serve from five ways - direct help, advocacy, giving, building, or teaching - because chosen service teaches something assigned service can't. The core skill is designing with the people who have the problem, not for them. You talk to real, affected humans, and you let them shape the work.

Three honest things. Your project cannot start until a real person who has the problem says yes to it, and they can say stop at any point; that is their right and not a verdict on you, and the wait between the asking and the yes is the work, not a gap before it. The honest answer at the end may be "this did not serve us," and there is a calm, named way to make it right, because landing wrong is part of real work, not failing at it. A project that stopped because the people said stop is a whole harvest. And some of the people you work with may be having a very hard time. The guide stays close for that, and a situation heavier than the support around it is one we do not send you into. At the end, the people you worked with say whether it served them. That is their word about the work, not a grade on you. What it did in you is a separate question, and it's yours.

The flow:

Weeks 22-27 · Feb 19 - Mar 29 · off: Mon Feb 19, Presidents Day (the session's first day)

Week 1 - choose your mode (open, re-thread). - **Mon (your own):** core; which mode of serving fits you and your problem? Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** the re-thread first, short; Impossible Question; the service-choice menu presented - direct service, advocacy, philanthropy, building, teaching; each learner chooses. - **Wed (your own):** core; plan your action; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** empathy as the core skill; design *with*, never *for*; who are the real people with this problem? Bridge: invite one of them (not just interview) - ask whether this should happen, and let them shape it. - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 2 - design with (gather). Between the invitation and the yes there is a wait, and the wait is the work. A person deciding whether to let you in is doing the thing this session is about, and "they haven't answered" or "they said no" is a true place to be standing in the third week, not a week

behind. - **Mon (your own):** core; talk to a real, affected person, if they have said yes; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; service prep or building in company. - **Wed (your own):** core; shape your action from what real people told you; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** design-with in practice; adjust your plan to the people, not your assumptions. Bridge: begin the real action. - **Fri:** fallow.

Weeks 3-5 - carry out the project, with real people (apply). Each week the same shape, and at the close of week 4, Thu Mar 15, the pace question: - **Mon / Wed (your own):** carry out the service, philanthropy, building, or teaching project, with real people; core; Log; check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; hands-on project work or service expeditions in company. - **Thu (deep guide day):** reflect on what's happening in the real action; iterate; hold anything heavy (hold, don't treat). Bridge: the next real step. - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 6 - a real action taken (harvest). - **Mon (your own):** core; finish and consolidate your action; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; share what you did and what happened. - **Wed (your own):** core; reflect - did it leave people better off? Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day, harvest):** a real action taken, with real people, or honestly not yet, plus the reflection ("did this serve them, as they tell it? And, separately, what did it do in me?"). Voluntary share. Ask the pace question. Then the join with the Call to Action, so the April break is dwell time: the Problem / Stakes / Story / Ask card goes on the table and is read aloud once; the four ways of being seen are named as equal; and any community story a learner may want in their talk gets its yes asked for now, while the relationship is live, never retrofitted in the last week. Run the closing minute at session scale, Thu Mar 29, and say aloud who is reachable over the break. Bridge into Session 7: "You did the work. Now: tell a room what's worth solving. Here's the shape a Call takes, and the four ways you can give it; carry them over the break. Nothing is due." - **Fri:** fallow, closes Session 6.

Things to say: - "Design *with* the people who have the problem, never *for* them." - "Invite them, don't just interview them. Ask whether this should even happen, and let them shape it." - "Did this serve *you*?" - the community answers this, not the learner. - "If it landed wrong, we have a calm way to make it right. Repair is part of the service, not its failure."

The settle and the closing minute: real-people service can land heavy - carry the closing minute and the way down; route anything heavier than coaching to real support. Re-thread on the first guide day back after the break.

Watch-fors (the community-standing gate, binding): no project touches real people until a named community member is invited and agrees - to the project, its terms, and a way to say "stop." Name where the benefit flows up front (if the honest answer is "they're part of my learning project," that's the savior trap, caught early). The harvest sits with the community's verdict, not the learner's guess. A repair clause is the same promise as an honored empty harvest: landing

wrong is not failing. Affected voices lead early, not at the last minute. No one's story enters the final talk without their consent. Do not send a learner into a situation heavier than the support around them - match the mode to readiness; stay close; service should stretch, not wound. Service expeditions are off-site; plan coverage per outing. Any work with people who are easily harmed gets a real adult's support, and so does the graceful ending of any community relationship.

What you'll need: the service-choice menu; the Problem / Stakes / Story / Ask card, for the harvest day; named community members invited and agreed before real people are touched; the benefit-flow and repair-clause conversations ready; off-site logistics and coverage; a partner adult where the situation calls for one.

Session 7 - The Call to Action (four weeks, Apr 9 - May 3, the year's harvest)

What it's for: Make a room care - stand up and make the case for a problem worth solving, with vulnerability as the persuasive force, and close the year back inside yourself before it ends.

For the learner: This is the harvest. You may make a talk: here is a problem worth solving, here is why it got to me, here is what I did and learned, here is what I'm asking of you. It is advocacy, not a sales pitch; honesty is what makes a room listen, more than polish, and you choose how much of yourself goes in. You choose who hears it, and you know all the choices now rather than in the last week. Four ways, equal, not one main road and three exits: the full room, with families there; the tribe only; one person you choose; or a recorded or written form that you present, or that the guide or a person you choose presents for you while you sit with your people, or while you do not. Nobody will ever have to ask for one of these; all four are offered to everyone, the same way. The feast is in the last week, in the evening, and the last morning after it is the year's close, yours and the guide's together. A talk that says "here is why this was harder than I thought, and here is the smaller thing I'm asking" is a whole talk. "I have nothing to ask a room for yet" is a whole harvest.

The room that day is your people - families, the tribe, whoever you invite - and the tribe is your people if no one else comes, honored equally and never as consolation. It is a feast, not a judged presentation. The studio provides the base of the meal; bringing a dish is never required and nobody will know who did. You do not have to eat. There is a named place to step out to that night, and you do not owe anyone a reason. Two rules we hold for you. If your talk carries another person's story, you need their yes before it goes in; a community's pain is never your material without it. And afterwards people will want to ask about your talk. You do not have to answer any question, from anyone, including an adult who means well. "I'd rather not say" is complete, and the guide backs you in the room. The tribe also gives its chorus Call for the shared problem: the

whole group saying together what you chose together, in a shape the group decides in rehearsal. If you argued against the shared problem and the room went the other way, you can stand in the chorus, stand with it silently, or sit it out. Before the feast, one question back to yourself: what came back changed in you? Then we eat.

The flow:

Weeks 28-31 · Apr 9 - May 3 · the session break falls before this session (Apr 2-5), not inside it

Week 1 - what a Call to Action is (open, re-thread). - **Mon (your own):** core; the Problem / Stakes / Story / Ask card from the last harvest in hand; what's the one thing you'd ask a room to do? Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** re-thread first. Then the Impossible Question; what a Call to Action is - advocacy versus a sales pitch; the four shapes named again as equal, so the choice stays open the whole session. Anyone still choosing a shape is choosing, not behind. - **Wed (your own):** core; draft your Problem and your Ask; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** what makes a room *care*? Honesty over polish; the story under the argument; where an arc lands and where it loses the room. Bridge: find your story, and write your Stakes. - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 2 - Problem, Stakes, Story, Ask, and the chorus (deepen). - **Mon (your own):** core; write your Stakes (why it matters, to whom) and your Story (why it got to *you*, what you did); Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; story-craft games - how an ordinary experience becomes a story that moves people. Then the tribe builds the chorus Call for the Commons Problem together: what we chose, and what we ask, in a shape the group decides. A *we*, not five solos. A learner who argued the other way in the autumn chooses now whether to stand in it, stand with it silently, or sit it out, and can change their mind up to the night. - **Wed (your own):** core; a full first draft, in the form your talk takes; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** shape the whole arc - Problem, Stakes, Story, Ask; share a passage (voluntary, aloud or in the form the talk takes; an offer, never a round); revision as care. Ask the pace question here, with two weeks left to act on the answer. Bridge: build it. - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 3 - build, then the dry run (apply). - **Mon (your own):** core; build and revise the talk; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** Impossible Question; talk-building and low-stakes delivery practice in company; the chorus run once. Confirm each learner's chosen shape in the walk-in, one to one, so choosing one person is never announced to the room. The four were on the table from the last harvest; this is the week the choice is made real, not first offered. - **Wed (your own):** core; last revisions; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep guide day):** the dry run, in the shape each learner chose - the tribe for those who chose it, with the one chosen person or the guide for those who did not. Each is the same dry run: the rehearsal, not a thing that precedes one. Hold nerves warmly; honesty is the force. What they said is the point, not how the room reacts. Bridge: rest. Nothing is built between the dry run and the feast. - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 4 - the Call to Action, the feast, and the year-close (harvest). - **Mon (your own):** core; final touches; rest. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter guide day):** the last Impossible Question of the year, then set the room together; last nerves held; the exit ramp named for the feast room and shown before anyone arrives. At the close of the morning, the turn back inward: "Having gone out to the world's problem, what came back changed in you?" - **The feast, Tuesday or Wednesday evening** (the guide's call, by their own day-shape; never the last Thursday): the Call to Action and feast, a real audience, families and the tribe. Each learner makes their case, as much and in whatever shape they choose, and the tribe gives the chorus Call for the Commons Problem; standing in it is offered, not required, and a learner who sits it out is still inside the *we*. Advocacy, or a Call to Repair, never a judged presentation; the tribe cheers each other. Being seen is a gift, never a demand. - **Wed (your own):** the interval, named as one: nothing asked back, nothing handed in. Core if you want it, rest if you need it. The noon check-in as always. - **Thu (deep guide day), the year-close:** after the feast has had its night, the three acts (Part 4): the co-authoring close with the whole short record on the table unasked, the Log handoff, the last re-ask, and the closing minute at year scale in its fixed words. Say aloud who is reachable over Open Waters and the summer, and that you are not. Bridge into the final year. - **Fri:** fallow, closes Session 7. Then Open Waters.

Things to say: - "This is advocacy, not a sales pitch. Honesty is what makes a room listen, more than polish. You choose how much of yourself goes in." - "Is this your Ask, or theirs? Whose voice are you carrying to this room?" - "Here is what I learned about why this is hard, and here is the smaller, truer ask" - a whole talk. Say so plainly; don't rank it above or below the others. - A Call to Repair: "Here is what I owe, here is who leads this, here is how you join *them*." - "The room will clap. That's fine, and it's not the point. What you said is the point." - Before the harvest, the turn back inward: "Having gone out to the world's problem, what came back changed in you?"

The settle and the closing minute: the Call to Action is a public harvest - an opening in front of other people - so it gets its private re-crossing afterward, the closing minute at year scale, in its fixed words, on the year-close day (see Part 4). Add the turn back inward at the close of the feast morning, the last ordinary guided morning before the room opens outward.

Watch-fors: being seen is invitational - depth is never a performance requirement. Offer the other three shapes as real roads, not as "share less." Name and hold the learner with no family in the room: the tribe is your people, a chosen witness is honored equally, never a consolation. Advocacy, not a stage performance - what they said is the point, not the applause; never coach for the room's reaction over the learner's conviction. No one's story enters the talk without their consent - a community's pain must never become the learner's persuasive story without that person's yes. Do not let the Wednesday between the feast and the year-close fill, and do not seat the year-close on the feast's last hour.

What you'll need: the Problem / Stakes / Story / Ask card, on the table at Session 6's harvest and read aloud there and again in week 1; the chorus Call's shape, decided by the tribe in week 2; story-craft prompts; a warm real audience arranged and told they are witnesses, not judges; each learner's chosen shape confirmed one to one; any recorded shape playable to the room with its transcript; consent secured for any story that touches another person, asked in Session 6 while the relationship is live, never retrofitted in the last week; the feast planned like a real event with the inclusion floor (base provided, presence not consumption, allergen-safe, no cover charge); the exit ramp named for the feast room; the co-authoring review structure; the Log handoff.

Part 4 - Closing the year

The Call to Action harvest

The year's harvest is the Call to Action and the feast at the end of Session 7. Each learner makes their case in the shape they chose, and the tribe raises the chorus Call for the shared Commons Problem they argued into being back in Session 4. This is a celebration, not a judged event. The guide holds what is true over what gets applause. Being seen is a gift, never a demand, and the talk that found only part of the answer - "here is what I learned about why this is hard, and here is the smaller, truer ask" - is held up as a whole talk, the one that understands how systems work, never put up with as an empty harvest.

The turn back inward

Before the year closes, add the small return beat. The Forge's arc runs from the self outward to the world; left there, it hands the learner back only the world's change and leaves the coming-back-to-yourself to the final year. So close it back, before the feast: "Having gone out to the world's problem, what came back changed in you?" The middle year closes its own loop. This is a thing the guide says about the year, the way Origin says "it's allowed to be a little tender." It is not a second closing minute.

The year-close

On the last guided day, after the feast has had its own night, three acts. First, a co-authoring close: the learner reviews the year's design *with* the guide, the design named not hidden - "here's how The Forge was built, and why; tell me what to change for the final year." The learner's call on their own year, never a feedback form, and declinable like every other quest. Alongside it, put the whole short record of them on the table, unasked: attendance, pace, credit plan, any safety note. Second, the Captain's Log ownership handoff: the Log is theirs; it goes where they say - home, or back to the one place here only they open for next year - and no copy is kept. That is the same whatever form the Log took: if any of it lives on a studio device or in a scribe's hand, it goes to the learner and nothing stays behind. Third, the closing minute at the whole year's scale, in its fixed words. It is a naming, not a new ceremony; the practice they have run all year, put in their own hand at the year's scale:

> *“Before the next year opens, take your closing minute at the whole year’s scale. What did you meet this year? What do you carry back? What’s different in you now - even a little? ‘I don’t know yet’ is a real answer.”*

That is what brings a learner back from standing in front of a room to being themselves. Then a real fallow stretch before the next year opens, and the fallow day stays empty; nothing is seated on it. Never start a new opening on a body still buzzing from the feast.

The tail of the year: Open Waters

The flex tail runs May 7 to May 24, the three weeks after Session 7 closes on May 3. It is light structure, not a void, and it is not an eighth session. Four things live there. Credit close-out, for anyone finishing the year’s plan, on their own days as all year. Project finishing, because a prototype that was real in March is allowed to be finished in May, and allowed to stay unfinished. The relay handed on: this is where what you built with real people goes to whoever carries it next - back to the community member who said yes, to the tribe who comes after you, or to nobody, which is a true handoff too - and where that relationship ends well, with the thank-you said and the repair clause honoured if it was ever called on; a Call to Repair’s “who leads this” is made good here, not only announced from a stage. The tribe’s shared problem is passed the same way: what the chorus asked for is left where the next group can find it, in the room’s own words, and the next group is free to leave it there. And rest, which is a legitimate use of all three weeks. Nothing the year did not finish is finished here; what a shorter session let go, it let go. Which mornings are guided in the tail is said before it starts, so nobody arrives to an empty room, and no re-thread opens it: the year-scale closing minute already closed the year, and a re-thread would reopen what the learner closed. On the last guided day, Thu May 24, say the summer’s break words: the one adult is reachable all summer, 988 never closes, the guide is not reachable, the pathway stays live. Name it to families as intentional: flex plus fallow, not “we’ll figure it out.”

Some learners finish the Launch Pad at the end of this year. Each of them gets their own leaving rite, the Launch, in whichever year they leave from, because the end of their own line is the true end. It sits inside Open Waters, in the third week, on a day set with the learner and their circle and never the last day, because the last day is when the calendar ends and a crossing is not hurried by a calendar. It carries the same condition every Launch does: it waits until the Growth Record export is real, and that is checked in the second week, not on the day. The Helm’s book carries the rite in full.

Then the bridge into the final year: “You found what’s worth solving and acted on it. Next: what do you do when there is no easy answer?”

“We evoke - we never extract.” - and that includes the guide, who chose the sustainable shape, and everyone in the room.

The Helm Year - Lesson Plan Book

A guide's book for Year Three of the Launch Pad, written so a learner can read every page.

A short opening note

This is a book for the guide who runs the third and final year of the Launch Pad - the year called The Helm. It is also a book any learner is welcome to read cover to cover. There is nothing in here to hide from you.

That is a promise with a shape. Everything in this book is safe and honest for a learner to read; nothing in it manages or manipulates anyone. Lines in "quotes" are things a guide might say aloud. Everything else is written for the guide to understand and hold - the reasons behind the moves, the care under the plan. When a note is written for the guide, it is still written to be read by a learner. There is no second, secret version.

One author's note on language: this book was written by Erin Stanley, who opened the studio and guided its first year. "The guide" means whoever is leading the studio, and this book says "they" throughout, because that will not always be the same person. Where the book says the guide is raising a small child, that is the shape of the year it was written for, named so the shape is owned; a later guide names their own shape in the same place. "You" sometimes means the guide and sometimes means the learner - the context always makes it clear which.

One more thing to say plainly at the start: this is the heaviest year in the three-year story, so the care around it is built up thickest. The material is real. It touches hard calls, mortality, shame, leadership, and, at the end, leaving. Which version a tribe runs, the lighter or the full, is decided by the guide before the year, and you will be told which. Inside it, every heavy day is yours to step out of, and the lighter path is always honorable, never a lesser version of the year. Held well, this year can change a person. Some will feel that, some won't yet, and both are true.

Part 1 - For everyone: what this year is

The year's question

The Helm is the year of **the hard call, and loving the life around it.**

The whole question of the year is this: *What do I do when there is no easy answer?* Not "how do I win." Instead: how do I face something that cannot be cleanly won? How do I make the call from my own principles, name what it costs, and not lose myself doing it? And how do I still love my actual life while I do?

The three years each carry their own question:

- **Origin - Who am I?** (Know your story.)
- **The Forge - What is worth solving?** (Find your work.)
- **The Helm - What do I do when there is no easy answer?** (Make the hard call, and love the life around it.)

The three years turn as a cycle rather than a ladder. Whichever year is running when you arrive is the one you start in, and you are not behind. You do not have to have done Origin or the Forge to start here. Your Log starts today, your Vineyard is named this week, and your Evidence File is built from any real proof you have. In the shared work you are a full Helm learner from the first morning. If you are not launching this year, the Council is yours all the same; the Launch is a rite for whoever is leaving, and the year's close is yours.

The journey

The Launch Pad is three years, three expeditions. The first year, Origin, is about **dreaming it**: who am I? The second year, The Forge, is about **building it**: what is worth solving? The Helm is the resolution. It is where you learn to make a real decision from your own principles, in the open, in front of your people, and still go home and love your life.

The arc runs self, then world, then the hard call. By now you know your story and you have found work worth doing. This year you learn four things. To reason when you truly cannot know the answer. To live with a hard decision. To lead the people beside you. To be mentored by adults who are further down the road. And one more: to choose life *because* you have looked at hard things, not by looking away from them.

The daily practice of this year is the **no-win scenario.** It is the practice of standing inside a situation that has no clean answer, long enough to reason from principle instead of reaching for the exit. It is the same muscle you have been building the whole time. In Origin you made small real choices in games. In The Forge you stood inside questions too big to close. This year you make the hard call inside a situation that cannot be won. Same muscle, one more turn.

Named plainly, the seven sessions are:

1. **The Mantle** - meet the feeling of not-belonging-yet, and take up what you will carry.
2. **No Easy Answers** - reason through real dilemmas from principle, out loud.
3. **The Ripple** - look downstream of a choice, and stay humble about what you can't see.
4. **The Stage** - feel a hard call from inside the lives it touches, through theatre.
5. **The Arena of Voices** - learn from adults further down the road, and how to be mentored well.
6. **The Bridge** - lead the people beside you, and be led.
7. **The Council** - make a hard call in the open, before your people.

The words this book uses

This studio has its own small vocabulary. None of it is a secret, so here it all is, before you meet any of it.

- **A quest.** One piece of work with a beginning and an end: a prompt, a case, a scene, a share. It is the unit you can say no to.
- **A session.** One of the year's seven stretches, each with its own question. Three to six weeks long, with a break after it.
- **Core.** Short for your core academics: the high-school credit work you have claimed, at your own pace, on your own days.
- **The settle.** The three slow breaths that open every guide day.
- **The way down.** Standing up and shaking it out after hard work, so your body can put the stress down.
- **The exit ramp.** The named place you can step out to, without asking, and come back from with nothing said.
- **The close-return.** The words the room says out loud after a heavy day, so your body hears that the heavy part is over. Always the same words; they are on the settle page.
- **The closing minute.** The three private questions at the end of an opening. Never written for the studio, never read by anyone.
- **The Captain's Log.** Your own record of your own life. Yours.
- **The Vineyard.** The thing you love that nobody ever makes useful.

- **The Work of the Day.** The one piece of the session's work the whole tribe does together that morning, named out loud at the start so you know what the day is for.
- **Your tribe.** The people in this studio with you.
- **Your crew.** Two things share this word. On a heavy day it is the one other learner who notices you and whom you notice; never a watch set on you. In the leadership work it is the people you lead and are led by.
- **The walk-in.** Two things share this word. The walk-in is the soft first stretch of a guide day, when the door is open and nothing is required. It is also what we call the quiet one-to-one conversations that happen inside that window, where the guide comes to one or two people rather than calling anyone over. "I'll catch you in the walk-in" means a conversation, not a meeting, and nothing in it is written down.
- **Fallow.** Deliberately empty. Fallow is a farming word: a fallow field is one you leave unplanted on purpose, because that is what makes it rich again. Fridays are fallow, and so is one whole week in the winter. Never earned, never filled.
- **A harvest.** The last stretch of a session, where you gather what the weeks grew and name what you got. It is yours to gather, and an empty harvest is a real harvest.
- **Witnessed.** Someone was there and saw it. Not watched, not assessed. Being witnessed is a gift and never a demand.
- **A re-thread.** Picking the year back up after a break. The first guide day back starts with it: where were you, where are you now, what came back changed. You are never restarting cold.
- **The pace question.** The guide asking whether the plan still matches the speed your real life is running at.
- **The re-ask.** The guide asking, out loud, *is this still yours?* It is not a mood check and it is not rhetorical. "No" and "I don't know" are both real answers, and it gets asked at points in the year where there is still time to act on the answer.
- **Open Waters.** The loose three weeks after the Council: expeditions, your own projects, credit close-out, and real rest.
- **The no-win scenario.** The year's daily practice: standing inside a situation that cannot be cleanly won, long enough to choose from principle instead of grabbing the exit. The name is borrowed from an old Star Trek story about a training test built so nobody can pass it. In the story the hero cheats the test; that part is the bait, not the lesson.
- **The hard call.** A decision where every path costs something real. Making one well: from principle, cost named, without losing yourself.
- **The Mantle.** A real object you take up in the first session and carry all year. It stands for "I am someone who can hold a hard call." At the end you decide to keep it or leave it; both are true.
- **The Evidence File.** Real proof you have already done hard things, pulled from your own record. It lines the Mantle, so the proof is in the pocket when not-belonging shows up.
- **The Reasoning Standard.** Five questions a hard call must answer, none of which is "what is the right answer."

- **A real dilemma, and a rationalized wrong.** A real dilemma has two real goods pulling against each other. A rationalized wrong has one, dressed as two.
- **Steelman.** Saying the side you disagree with so well its holder would say "yes, that's it." You may not argue your own side until you have.
- **Forum Theatre.** A hard-call scene is acted out; anyone can stop it, step in, and try a different choice. Deliberation you can see.
- **De-roling.** Stepping out of a part: say your name, three true things about your real life, prop down, shake out, feel what is under you. It closes a role. It never closes real grief; the closing minute does that.
- **The second adult.** On the deep days of the three heaviest sessions, a second adult whose only job is to leave with the learner who needs to leave. No second adult that week, the heavy block waits.
- **The Council.** The year's harvest: a hard call made in the open, in front of your people, by reasoning together. Not a debate. A debate has a winner. It sits twice, once with the tribe alone and once with your people in the room, and both are the Council.
- **The Third Chair.** An empty chair between two hardened sides, holding four questions: what is each side protecting, is the "or" real or inherited, what would honor both, and if nothing can, which do we choose and what do we grieve.
- **The steward of the absent.** The one Council seat whose only job is "who is affected by this who is not in the room?"
- **The Launch.** The rite at the end of three years for a learner leaving: the ending named, a threshold crossed in front of your people, the door left unlocked from your side. Nobody is ever pulled back through it.
- **The Star Chart.** The map of where you have been, handed to you at the Launch, at the moment you must steer by it alone.

What you make and carry

Three things belong to you this year, and one of them you carry out the door for the rest of your life.

The Captain's Log. This has been yours since your first day here, whichever year that was. It is your private voice, your record of what you met and what you carried. A guide never reads it to grade you or check on you; it was never surveillance and it never will be. It is yours every day, not only at the end: it goes where you say, home or a place here only you open, and no copy is ever made, because the moment there is a copy somebody else is holding your life. At every year's close the handoff is said aloud, and if you leave, you carry it out the door.

The Mantle. This year you take up a Mantle: a role, a way of standing, an "I am someone who can hold a hard call." You take it up in the first session, you wear it into the leadership work and the Council, and at the very end you decide, on your own, whether to keep it or leave it. Both choices are true. The choosing is the point.

The Vineyard. This is the thing you love that has nothing to do with the curriculum: the instrument, the trail, the craft, the friendship, the game, the album on the floor. It was named on your first day here as the quiet twin of the Captain's Log, and by now it has roots. It is never made useful, because the moment it is useful it stops being a Vineyard. No one grades it, no one turns it into a lesson, no one asks you to reflect on it. At the Launch, the one small thing you leave for the room *can* be your Vineyard-thing, if you choose; it can also be anything else, and nobody will ask. Loving your life is not a footnote to making hard calls. It is what the hard calls are *for*.

When, and this is the one part that is required. Making time for something you love is a requirement of this programme. Not a particular thing, not a certain number of hours, and not anything you hand in. The requirement is that the time is in your week and that something you love is in the time. Friday is already yours and is the obvious home; the tail of a Tuesday is another. Nobody ever checks what you did with the time. The only question anyone will ever ask is *is the time there*. The requirement binds us to keep making room for it. It does not bind you to fill the room.

The promises (the six refusals)

Underneath everything, there is a floor of promises. Nothing in the Launch Pad is allowed to break these. In plain words:

1. **No grades or scores anyone but you can see.** Your progress is yours. High-school credit is the one honest exception, and it is explained at the end of this Part.
2. **No ranking and no leaderboards.** You are never stacked against the person next to you. A parent linked to your account can see which of your own goals you have finished, and that is the whole of what anyone else sees. If that ever stops being exactly true, you will be told before it changes, not after.
3. **No one deposits the answers into you.** You make meaning here; the guide holds questions and walks with you, and does not hand you a finished answer.
4. **No imposed deadlines.** You set your own pace. "I didn't get to it" is honored, not punished.
5. **Your worth is not your output.** A quest you abandoned and learned from counts as much as one you finished. Doing more does not make you worth more.

6. **No surveillance.** The data of your life belongs to you, not to the school. This promise is about a short list of what gets written down about you, and the list is at the end of this Part so you can check it.

And one more, which sits on top of the six:

You may refuse the structure itself. If you decline a whole quest, you are fully honored. You are not quietly marked down as a failure or an opt-out. Your no is real.

Where your no reaches, and where it stops

Here is the edge of that last promise, said now rather than discovered later.

Your no covers your own work. A quest, a case, a role, a scene, a share, a whole session, this entire structure. It lands the moment you say it, it costs you nothing, and nobody can overrule it.

It does not cover how you treat the people in the room with you. That is not a deadline and it is not output. It is the floor that makes everything else here safe for the other people in the room, and it is the one place in this programme where something can actually be taken from you. The studio's agreements run that floor, and they have their own ladder: a Pause, then a Stop, then a Strike. You will meet it in your first week, and you will help write the agreements it rests on. The count clears at the start of every year, so nothing from last year walks in with you.

So, in one line: **the agreements are about how we treat each other. The promises are about whether you do the work.**

Declining a quest is never a Pause. A Pause is never a judgement on your work, your pace, or whether you are keeping up. If anyone ever runs those two together, they have got it wrong, and you can say so out loud and point at this page.

And if you do not sign. You are in the room anyway, and that was never the price of being here. The agreements still run for you, and here is the honest reason rather than a convenient one: they are not holding you to your word, because you did not give it. They are holding the room safe for the people in it with you. You can tell us the agreements are not yours. You cannot be outside the floor, because **the floor is not about you.**

How we work: the week

The studio day runs through the morning, 9:00 to 1:00. Across the week, two mornings are guide days and two are your own.

- **Guide days (Tuesday and Thursday).** The guide runs the studio with you. The order of the morning is below, and it is the same every time. What differs this year is the middle: Tuesday's work is lighter, and Thursday holds the week's one deep block. That is on purpose. One deep block a week is the shape every year of the Launch Pad has run, and the guide is here all four mornings this year, so the lighter day is not a lighter guide; whether both guide days could carry a deep block in this year is the guide's call before the year, and this book will say which.
- **Your-own days (Monday and Wednesday).** You run your own morning: your reading, your core academics, your personal project, and the session's writing. Nobody is steering but you. This year the guide is in the room with you on your own days, working alongside you on their own things: planning, reading, their own Log. They are not watching; they are working, and a guide at the next table who does not look up is the point. The midday check-in still happens, around noon, as a real conversation and not a glance across the room. If you need them before noon, you say so. You are genuinely running your own hours and you are never alone in the building. Both of those are true at once.
- **The fallow day (Friday).** Protected. Never earned, never filled, never converted back into work. It is for rest, play, friendship, and making things for no reason. This is not a reward for finishing. It is practice for a whole life. And it is binding: it does not get eaten to cover a busy week. It is for you and for the guide both.

A guided morning, start to finish

Guide days run 9:00 to 1:00. The order is the same on both days, so you never walk in wondering what today is. What changes between Tuesday and Thursday is the middle block.

Time	What happens
9:00 - 9:25	**The walk-in.** Door open, nothing required. Put your things down, make tea, talk or don't. The guide is here and will come find one or two people for a quiet one-to-one.
9:25 - 9:35	**The settle, then the circle.** Three breaths, the same words every time. Then one round of "how are you, really?" You may pass.

Time	What happens
9:35 - 10:50	**The Work of the Day.** Tuesday: the day's no-win question, then the lighter work - group challenges, theatre as play, leadership practice, planning an outing. Thursday: the week's one deep block. On the heaviest day of the three heaviest sessions there is a second adult in the room - in No Easy Answers and the Stage that day is a Tuesday, so the deep block and the lighter day trade places; in the Council it is the Thursdays and the public sitting - and you will know which days those are before they come. This is the part that changes week to week. The rest of this table does not.
10:50 - 11:00	**The way down.** Stand, shake it out, step outside, water. Then we eat.
11:00 - 11:40	**The Table.** We eat together. You bring your own lunch. On a heavy day this is the come-down, and nothing is asked of you at it.
11:40 - 12:40	**Hands and each other.** Making, building, rehearsing, an errand, a project with somebody else. Different from the morning's work on purpose: the body works and the talking gets easy. On Tuesdays this is a fine home for your Vineyard if you want it there; nobody asks.
12:40 - 1:00	**The close.** One light thing, then your closing minute, then you go.

The times are honest rather than strict. Most days drift ten minutes. The order never drifts.

The Table

Every guide day has a shared meal in the middle of it. Here is exactly how it goes.

You bring your own lunch. On ordinary days the studio does not provide the food.

It is still a shared table rather than a lunch break. We stop, sit down together, and the guide sits and eats with you. The forty minutes is for being a group of people who eat together, not for getting through food on the way to the next thing.

You sit wherever you want. Seats are not assigned, and nobody's seat is kept from last week.

You do not have to eat. Presence is the whole requirement here, never consumption. If you are fasting, or observing, or not hungry, or food is a hard thing for you right now, you sit with us and that is full participation. Nobody watches anybody's plate, and you never owe anyone an explanation for what is or is not on yours.

If you arrive late, come in and sit down. Nothing restarts, and nobody asks where you were in front of the room.

On the one day a year when there *is* shared food, the feast after the Council, tell the guide what you cannot eat, once, whenever you know it. Planning around it is the guide's job rather than yours to work around. That day the studio provides the base of the meal, and bringing a dish is never required. If you want what the studio brings to stand as yours, say so to the guide once, privately, and it will. Nobody at the table will know the difference, and nobody will ask.

Sometimes a guest speaker is with us across the Table. They eat with us by the same rule, and the guide tells them the shape before they come. You never owe a guest a performance of gratitude for sitting with us. Being at the table is the thanks.

The circle: "how are you, really?"

Right after the settle, every guide day, we go around once. The question is "how are you, really?" and it means the real answer rather than the automatic one.

Here is how it goes. The guide asks, and answers first, honestly and briefly. Then it goes around in order, so nobody is picked on and nobody has to volunteer. One or two sentences each is plenty. "Tired." "Good, actually." "I don't want to say today." Those are complete answers.

You can always pass. Say "pass" and it moves on, with no follow-up and no note taken. Passing is not a smaller answer. A person who passes has been round the circle the same as everyone else.

Nobody fixes what you say here unless you ask. Advice that arrives unasked is not help, so the circle starts from being heard.

But you can ask, and you can ask the room. "Does anyone know what to do about this?" is a completely normal thing to say in a circle, and so is "I just wanted to say it, I don't want to talk about it." Both are answers to the same question, and the question is yours: **do you want this held, or do you want it worked?** Say which and the room will follow you. Six people who know you is not a smaller resource than one guide, and some things a seventeen-year-old knows better than any adult in the building.

If you would rather not ask in front of everyone, that is equally fine. Say so, or say nothing and catch the guide afterwards.

It takes a few minutes. It is not a check-up, and nothing said in it is written down.

Who else is in the room

There are a handful of you and one of me, and this year I am here all four mornings. My child is in Vibrant Life Tots, down the hall, with their own teacher, on the mornings we meet; they are not in the studio. The first year they were in the room with us, worn; the second year they were with childcare on the two mornings I was here. This is the first year you get the whole of my week.

On the heaviest days of the three heaviest sessions there is also a second adult in the room. In No Easy Answers and the Stage that day is a Tuesday, so the deep block and the lighter day trade places; in the Council it is the Thursdays and the public sitting. They are not here for me. They are here for the room, so that if one of you needs to step out, somebody can go with you and I never have to choose between the room and you. If they cannot be there one week, the lighter version of the day runs and the deep version waits. You will know who they are before the first heavy week. They are another trained adult, never one of you.

And the same plain thing as every year: if you ever need all of me, a hard day or a conversation that cannot be interrupted, say so. There is nothing to hand off; you have me.

Arriving late, stepping out, coming back

Arriving late. Walk in. There is no procedure and nothing restarts. If the circle is going, join where it has got to, or pass. If the settle is going, sit down and pick it up on the next breath. Nobody will ask you in front of the room where you were. If something made you late and you want the guide to know, catch them at the Table.

Coming back after stepping out. The soft parts of the day are named so you know where the easiest way back in is: the walk-in, the Table, and the hands block after it. You can come back at any moment, including the middle of a hard one. The soft seams are just the ones where nothing has to be said at all. Nobody says anything to you when you come back. Not even “glad you’re back.” You pick up a plate or pick up a tool and you are in.

On a heavy day, stepping out works the same way, and the exit is named again that morning for that room. If the second adult comes out with you, you do not have to talk to them. They are there so that nobody is alone with a hard thing. During the Council there is also the pass signal, which hands the floor back at no cost and with no explanation.

The Log, captured however you hold it

You keep the Captain's Log in whatever form is true to you. Written in a notebook. Spoken aloud and recorded. Drawn. Dictated. Typed. Told to a scribe who writes it down for you. No form is the lesser Log. The point is that you are keeping your own record, not that it looks a certain way.

Where it lives. Your Log can go home with you, or stay here somewhere only you open, or both, and you can change your mind any time. If you want it to stay here, say so and nobody asks why. It is not kept in the Compass or on any school computer, and no copy is made.

When you write in it. There is no Log time and nobody will ever call one. The walk-in, right after your closing minute, your own mornings, and Friday if you want it are all open rather than expected. A record you have to feed every day stops being a record and becomes a chore, and **there are supposed to be days you skip.** A Log with gaps in it is not a failed Log; it is what an honest one looks like.

One rule about this, and it is for the guide as much as you: **nobody writes on a bell.** We will never all sit down and write at the same time, because the moment that happens, everyone can see who is writing and who is not, and the only thing that makes this yours is that nobody is watching.

How "no" works here

You may decline anything. **Your no takes effect the moment you say it, and it is not conditional on explaining yourself.** This is called **decline-with-reasoning**, and here is the honest shape of it.

You can say no to any quest, any case, any role, any share, and the no lands straight away. Nothing is held up while you find words.

The reasoning is still owed. Two things about that, and they matter equally. **It is owed to your tribe, not to the guide.** You are in a room with other people whose work and plans move around yours, so they get to know where you stand. It is not a toll you pay an adult for permission. And **it is not owed in the moment.** "I don't know yet, and I'll come back to you" is a real answer. Take a day. Take the week. Work it out in your Log first and come back when you have it. A reason you had to produce on the spot is not thinking, it is pressure.

The guide may ask you an honest, curious question about it, the way a friend might. But the guide **has a voice, never a veto.** The guide cannot overrule your reason, and cannot require you to have one ready. The question is a mirror, not a test you can fail.

There is one place where even the curious question is set aside: anything to do with official papers and government forms. There, an honest reason for declining might reveal something private about your legal situation that a guide has no business knowing. So on that one surface, your no needs no reason at all.

Meeting a hard thing with the ordinary supports. Twice this year, in two of the lighter sessions, the Ripple and the Arena of Voices, you may choose to meet a hard thing with the ordinary supports instead of the full net: the guide present, the exit there, the visible crew turned down. It is offered, you choose it by name, and it is never sprung on you. The floor's availability never goes down; only how loudly it is announced. It is never pressed on a learner already carrying more than enough, because the point is an ordinary-sized hard thing met with ordinary support, not a wound made on purpose.

The settle

Every guide day opens with a short, body-first way in, and there is a matching way down when something gets heavy. This is fixed, and it is yours to keep for life.

- **The way in (the settle).** Three slow breaths with the out-breath longer than the in-breath (roughly four counts in, six counts out), feet flat, one hand where you feel your breath. The guide paces it out loud, the same way every time. The out-breath is what tells your body it is safe to settle. No app, no playlist, no special frequency. Just a human voice, used the same way on purpose. It is the same three moves every day, all three years, because the sameness is what lets it become yours. When you are forty and something cracks you open, this is a way to come home to yourself.

- **The way down.** After hard work stirs the body up, you stand, shake it out, take a short walk, move the activation *through* the body before sitting back down. If standing or walking is not yours, any movement that is - shaking out your hands, rolling your shoulders, rocking - does the same work. You cannot metabolize a stress spike sitting still. On heavy days there is a short one in the middle of the work too: thirty seconds, feet on the floor or hands on the chair, look around the room, one breath.

- **The way out (the exit ramp).** There is a named place you can step out to, set up in the first week. You do not have to ask. And there is a designed way back in during a soft part of the day, with no scene, no acknowledgment demanded. Stepping out and coming back costs you nothing. This is the room holding a door open for you, never the room watching you for a fall.

- **The way back (the close-return).** After a day that went somewhere heavy, the room says out loud that the heavy part is over, so your body hears it and not just your head. These words do not change either:

  > *"That was then. This is now. Look around and name one thing you can see. You're in this room, and the hard part is behind you."*

  It sounds almost too simple to do anything. It works because a body that has been inside a hard thing for an hour does not automatically notice that the hour ended, and being told, in words, is how it notices. Solo version, for the rest of your life: *that was then, this is now, and I'm here.*

One more close belongs to this year, because this year you wear other lives on a stage. **De-roling** closes a role: say or sign your own name, three true things about your real life, prop down, shake out whatever part of you moves, feel what is under you. It says "that wasn't me." The close-return and the closing minute close a real feeling the role opened: "that was me, and I carry it, and I'm still here." They are kept strictly separate, because real grief is never something a learner is asked to put down like a costume.

The closing minute

At the close of an opening - a dilemma reasoned, a life tried on, a hard conversation - you take a quiet minute and cross back through three fixed questions. They are always the same, in the same order:

1. **What did I meet?**
2. **What do I carry back?**
3. **What's different in me now - even a little?**

That is the whole practice. It is spoken or held in your head, never written down for the studio, never read by anyone. It is yours. It runs at the close of every guide day, light days included, because a practice used only on heavy days never becomes the one you reach for at forty.

Reach for the real answer. Taking the first thing that comes to mind and moving on makes this worth almost nothing. Staying in the question for a whole minute and letting something come up makes it worth a great deal, and **something almost always comes up, if you stay open long enough to hear it.** That takes a kind of nerve. It is the same nerve the rest of this year asks for.

“I don’t know yet” is a real answer, not because the question has no answer, but because sometimes the true one has not surfaced, and naming that beats manufacturing something to have said. “Nothing’s different, and I’m steadier for having looked” is also true and complete, because steadier is a change.

But you will know the difference between *I don’t know yet* and *I didn’t look*. Nobody else ever will. Nobody reads this, nobody asks about it, and no one can tell from the outside whether you reached or shrugged. **This is the one practice here that runs entirely on your own honour**, and what you do with a quiet minute when nobody is checking is worth knowing about yourself. The whole point is that you can run it on yourself for the rest of your life, at a kitchen table at 2 a.m., with no guide in the room.

The one adult outside the room

There is one adult, outside the studio, you can always talk to. You will know who they are and how to reach them in the first week, before you ever need them.

One honest line about breaks, said now. When the studio is on a break - the short ones between sessions, Thanksgiving, the two weeks at winter, and the summer - the guide is not reachable. A break is rest and reset for them too, and the book protects that the same way it protects your Friday. The one adult outside the room is reachable across every break, the same as always. And if you are ever in danger, or someone else is, **988** is free, open all day and all night, and you can call or text it from anywhere. Nobody here will ever be upset that you used it.

And this is the honest shape of privacy, said on the first day rather than saved for the moment it matters. Almost everything stays here. Your Captain’s Log, nobody reads. Your closing minute is never written down by anyone.

Here is what doesn’t. If the guide believes you are in danger, that someone is hurting or neglecting you, or that something is going on that is bigger than a studio morning can hold, they will bring in real help. That includes talk of suicide or self-harm, abuse or neglect, something going wrong with eating, a crisis with drugs or alcohol, a panic or a flashback they cannot reach you through, a threat to someone else, or something that keeps going and is getting in the way of your life.

Those are two different things and they have different consequences, so both get named. **Abuse or neglect is a report**, and in Idaho the guide is required by law to make it. **Everything else on that list is a hand-off**, which means they stop the session work and help you get to someone trained, you will be told who, and you get a say in which one and when.

In most of those cases they will also call your parent or guardian, and they will tell you they are making the call. The one exception is if your parent or guardian is the person hurting you. Then the call goes to the state rather than to them.

That is the whole list. It is not one secret trapdoor, and the guide will never go looking for a reason to use it. **What they know is only what you chose to tell them.** None of this is breaking trust. It is what care actually looks like.

What gets written down about you

Short answer: very little, and you can read all of it.

- **Your Captain's Log and your Vineyard.** Yours. Nobody reads them. No copy is kept.
- **Your closing minute.** Never written down at all, by anyone.
- **Your witnessed work** - your reasoned position on a hard case, a monologue if you perform it, the Council board, your Evidence File, your next-step plan. The guide sees what you bring into the room, and so do the people you choose to show. That is what bringing it means.
- **The guide's own notes.** A short practical record: attendance, your pace and your credit plan, and a factual note if there is ever a safety event, meaning what happened, what they did, and who they called. A safety note never contains what you wrote or said about your own life.
- **The cards from the first session.** If you write one, it is read once in the guide's voice with no name, and then it is gone. Nobody keeps them or matches a hand to a name.
- **A recent loss, if you choose to say.** Before the one scene in the year that touches death directly, the guide will ask you, one to one and never in the circle, whether there is a recent loss you would want that day planned around. You can decline to say, and nothing is written either way.
- **If you are matched with a mentor.** The guide can see that contact exists and how often, never what it says. You, your parent and the mentor sign the boundaries together. Your parent is told who any guest speaker is and when they come.
- **Your Growth Record, in the Compass.** The one record here that is built to leave with you. It works differently from everything else on this list, so it has its own section below.
- **The agreements record, if you ever reach a Stop.** Our studio agreements run on a ladder: a Pause, then a Stop, then a Strike. The Stop and the Strike are the two rungs that make paper. A Stop note says what happened and goes home the same day, you fill it out with your guide, and the line about coming back is yours in your own words. A Strike letter lists the dates of the three Stops. Your character contract is yours, in your handwriting, and

a copy stays with Jenna, who runs the school, while you are working it. All of it records a choice and never a judgement about who you are, the count clears at the start of each year, and none of it goes on a transcript or travels with your Growth Record.
- **What is never kept.** Scores. Rankings. Assessments of your character written by anyone but you. Any note about you that you have not read. Any file that follows you past this year.

You can ask to read anything written about you, at any time, and the guide will show you. If you think a note is wrong, say so, and it gets corrected. That includes a Pause, a Stop or a Strike: if you think a call was wrong, say so, and it can come off - off the note and off the count. You do not have to be calm about it. A learner who is angry at an unfair call is giving us information, not failing a condition.

That is the whole of it. “No surveillance” is a promise about this list, and the list is short on purpose.

The Growth Record, the Launch, and whether any of this counts on paper

You are sixteen to eighteen, so a fair question about any year of your life is whether it counts on paper. Here is the straight answer.

The Compass holds a record called your **Growth Record**, and the whole design of it is that you own it and the studio does not. The app is a lens, not a vault: you hold the keys from the first day, and a guide is a guest whose access ends when the relationship does, which for a launching learner is the Launch. A school cannot lose, withhold or hold hostage a record it never held in the first place.

It has two faces, and you control which one anybody sees.

- **The Journey view** is the whole trail, in order, with the slow parts and the stalls in it. It stays private. It is yours. Reading it at the start of the Launch is your invitation: alone, or with the guide if you want company.
- **The Portrait view** is the one you would hand a college, an employer or a programme. It is framed as what you can actually do, and **you choose what goes into it, piece by piece.** Nobody assembles your Portrait for you, and nobody sends it anywhere without you.

One rule holds across both, and it is built into the thing rather than promised about it: growth here is only ever shown as **movement compared to your own earlier self.** Never a grade. Never a score. Never set beside another learner.

And the honest limit, which you should hear from us rather than discover. The part that lets the record physically leave - a real export, readable by a human, held in your hands - **is not finished yet.** It is being built. Until it exists, nobody walks the Launch, because a ceremony that hands you something that is not there is not a ceremony. That is a rule the programme put on itself before any learner was in the room.

The Launch, and what is promised. If you are leaving at the end of this year, the Helm's last session closes, and then, in the third week of Open Waters, on a day set with you and never the last day, the Launch: a rite in three movements, where the ending is named out loud, you decide what to do with the Mantle, you leave one small thing for the room, and you step over a real threshold into a circle of adults who receive you as one. That is promised, and so is this: the Launch is built to be sad as well as glad, on purpose. It names that this was your home and that you are leaving it, and holds that without hurrying. If no family is in the room, the tribe is your people, said now and not on the day. Two things are conditional, and you should hear them now. The Launch cannot be walked until the Growth Record export exists. And the deep version of each heavy session runs only when a second adult is in the room; otherwise the lighter version runs, and that is the floor working, not you missing something. What is never conditional: the door stays unlocked from your side, nobody will call you back, and a launched learner who never returns is a success.

Two more things, said plainly. High-school credit is tracked separately, and it is the one record other people read as a routine matter, which is the honest exception to the first promise; if this is your last year, the guide will walk the credit close-out with you rather than leave it to the last week. And a transcript from a studio like this one is not yet a thing every college recognises; the bridge to dual enrollment is real work and we will do it alongside you rather than pretending it is already finished.

Part 2 - For the guide: teaching this year

The shape of the year, and naming the destination on day one

The Helm runs the full Vibrant Life year, mid-August to late May, on the school's calendar rather than a tidy one of its own, and it takes the same shape as Origin: seven sessions with a break between each, thirty-one weeks of session work, plus the three-week Open Waters tail, for thirty-four program weeks in all. The sessions are **not** equal lengths. They are set by where the breaks fall. The last session is the harvest, and for a leaving learner it flows into the Launch.

The Helm 2029-2030. A program week is Monday to Thursday: two guide mornings (Tuesday and Thursday), two the learners run themselves (Monday and Wednesday), and Friday fallow.

Session	Dates	Weeks
S1 The Mantle	Aug 13 - Sep 6	4
session break	Sep 10 - 13	
S2 No Easy Answers	Sep 17 - Oct 18	5
session break	Oct 22 - 25	
S3 The Ripple	Oct 29 - Nov 15	3
Thanksgiving	Nov 19 - 23	
S4 The Stage	Nov 26 - Dec 13	3
Winter break	Dec 17 - 28	
S5 The Arena of Voices	Dec 31 - Feb 7	6
session break	Feb 11 - 14	
S6 The Bridge	Feb 18 - Mar 28	6
session break	Apr 1 - 4	
S7 The Council	Apr 8 - May 2	4
Open Waters (flex tail)	May 6 - May 23	3

Five Mondays inside sessions are holidays: Labor Day (Sep 3) in S1, the second Monday of October (Oct 8) in S2, Veterans Day observed (Nov 12) in S3, MLK Day (Jan 21) in S5, and Presidents Day (Feb 18) on S6's first day. A Monday here is a self-run morning rather than a

guided one. Two guide days are holidays: Election Day, Tue Nov 6, in S3, and New Year's Day, Tue Jan 1, in S5's first week as projected. Whether the studio observes Election Day is decided before S3 opens.

These dates take Origin's 2027-2028 shape and begin it on Monday, August 13, 2029, around that year's real Thanksgiving week. They are a projection. One thing the real calendar will move: as printed, S5 opens on Monday, December 31 with New Year's Day on its first Tuesday, so expect the winter break a week later. Jenna, who runs the school, sets the real dates. Confirm them before anything is printed for a family.

The sessions below are cut to these weeks. Where the calendar gave a session more weeks than its plan, the extra went to air (a threshold week at the front of the Mantle; the Bridge learning the Council's form at low stakes), to the year's one fallow week, named as such in the Arena of Voices, and in one case to nothing: the Bridge's fourth week is left unplanned on purpose. Where the calendar gave fewer, the Stage runs in three weeks with the death scene on its second Tuesday and a held week after it, and the Council runs in four because its form was learned in March. Nothing was added because a week existed.

Every session ends into a break, so every session carries the same two seams. On the last guided day, the carry-out: the pace question, the harvest, and the closing minute at session scale. On the first guided day back, the re-thread. The re-ask is rarer and is asked three times, where there is still time to act on the answer: at the winter break, which is the Stage's last guided day; after the Arena of Voices; and on the year-close day. The agreements are open for reopening at every session's close too - say so on the last guided day, every time, so the handle is real and not only promised in week one.

On the very first day, name the destination out loud. This is the single most important framing move of the year:

> *"In May you will sit with your people and make a hard call in the open. We call it the Council. Some of you will then go out the door into your own lives - that's the Launch. Everything between now and then is getting ready to sit in that chair and mean it."*

No week count in the line: the count is not settled, and a date that moves is a promise broken. Once the mountain is named on day one, every session becomes a rung toward it. The reasoning work is how the captain thinks. The empathy work is how the captain feels the cost. The mentorship work is learning the terrain from those who walked it. The leadership work is how the captain holds the room. Give them the mountain first, and the whole year points somewhere.

Three threads run through the whole year and give it a spine:

1. **The destination**, named day one (the Council, and the Launch).
2. **The Mantle**, one physical object taken up in Session 1 and carried to the end.
3. **The Vineyard**, the un-useful joy, tended for years, ripening now.

The year's daily frame: the no-win call

The daily ritual of The Helm is the no-win scenario. It opens every guide day after the settle and the circle, because you cannot stand inside something that cannot be won while nobody in the room knows you are tired. Name it plainly as the same muscle the learners have built all along: small choices in Origin, standing inside big questions in The Forge, and now the hard call inside a situation that cannot be cleanly won.

The famous move in the old story - reprogram the test, beat the unbeatable - is the bait, not the lesson. For near-adults months from the real world, the deeper truth is this: the test is not whether you can always find the clever third option. It is who you are when there is no third option. Sometimes the freighter dies: sometimes there is no option where nobody loses something. So teach both halves. Half the wisdom is finding the third door when it is really there. The other half is knowing when there isn't one, choosing anyway from principle, naming the cost, and not losing yourself carrying it. The highest thing this whole three-year arc can produce is not "the learner found the clever way out." It is: the learner faced something that could not be won, made the hard call from principle, named what it cost, and did not lose themselves doing it.

The safety floor, fullest here

This year has the heaviest material in the whole program, so the floor is built up thickest. Do not treat the floor as the brake on honesty. The floor is what lets the room go to hard places and come back. Honest-and-held changes a person; honest-and-abandoned wounds them. The whole difference is that one word: held.

The floor has these parts, and they are non-negotiable:

- **The settle, the way down, the close-return, the closing minute.** Described in full in Part 1; the learner reads the same words you do. Every heavy day opens with the settle (settle the room before you stir it), has a short way down in the middle of the work, and ends with the close-return said in its fixed words, so people land back in the present. Fix your own wording for the settle in the first week, write it down, and do not improve it, because the sameness is the medicine: a settle improvised fresh never becomes the reflex a body drops into, and if it goes stale to you, that is it working. Run the closing minute at the close

of every guide day, light days included; “take your closing minute” is the whole prompt, and you never ask what came up. A tired guide cuts these first because they feel like overhead. They are not overhead. They are the floor.

- **Stepping out and back.** There is a named place a learner can go to, set up in week one, and they never have to ask. Coming back in costs nothing - they slip back during a soft moment, no scene, no acknowledgment demanded.

- **A crew that holds each other.** On heavy days every learner is paired with one other learner who simply notices them. Frame it as a crew, always - never “assigned to watch you flood.” A crew keeps the person at the centre the one steering. A watch set on someone turns them into the thing being watched, and the room into the hero of their story. Keep them the hero.

- **A second adult present for the heaviest sessions.** Three sessions carry material heavy enough that one adult cannot both hold the room’s deliberation and catch the one learner quietly going under. On the deep day of those three, a second adult is required in the room - not for childcare, but as a second pair of eyes whose only job is to leave with the learner who needs to leave, at that learner’s pace, so you never have to choose between the room and the wound. The three are Session 2 (the heaviest dilemmas), Session 4 (the death scene in *Our Town*), and Session 7 (the public Council). The second adult is another trained adult: a co-op parent who has done the safety briefing, or another adult freed for that hour, never one of the learners. Name it as a precondition, not a hope. If a second adult genuinely cannot be secured for a given heavy week, the deep block for that week lightens or defers - the lighter version runs, and the deep version waits until the room can be held. That is the floor working, not the guide failing.

- **The referral pathway, in plain terms.** You are a life-coach and mentor, not a licensed clinician. This year surfaces real clinical material - grief around mortality, shame, hard days - more and earlier than any prior year. Your job is not to treat it. It is to recognize when something is past coaching, hold the moment safely, and route it to real help fast. Route now, do not “work it in a session,” if you see or hear any of these: any mention of suicide, self-harm, or not wanting to be here; abuse, neglect, or someone hurting them; a crisis happening right now: panic, a flashback, feeling cut off from their own body, or distress you cannot reach; signs of something going wrong with eating; a crisis with drugs or alcohol; a threat to someone else; something past an ordinary hard day: it keeps going, and it is getting in the learner’s way. When in doubt, route. Being sure is a clinician’s job, not yours. Stay with the learner, never leave them alone in crisis, move to the designated quiet space, be calm and present, do not ask for details or counsel. The referral roster must be built real - real names and current numbers - before Session 1 runs, and the one line that must never stay blank is a named, warm-referral therapist arranged in advance. In Idaho everyone is a

mandatory reporter, including you; suspected abuse or neglect gets reported, ideally within twenty-four hours, and you do not need proof, because the law gives the judging to the state. This duty does not give you a key to the Log: you do not read it, so it cannot be a source; what the duty reaches is what a learner tells you, shows you or hands you, and what you see and hear in the room. Say that distinction out loud on day one. 988 is the crisis line; keep those numbers current and on paper, because in a crisis the phone in your hand is already doing something else, and a number you have to search for is a number you do not call. The pathway runs across breaks, not only on program days, and the learner is told so before each one.

- **Keep confidences safe.** Say the privacy words on day one, woven into the promises you make each other, and say them as written rather than improvising a warmer version, because a learner who hears a different wording than the one they read goes looking for the seam:

> *"Almost everything you write and say here is yours. Your Captain's Log, nobody reads - including me, and I won't go looking. What I can't keep private is a short list, and I'd rather you hear it now than find out later: if you're in danger, if someone's hurting you, or if something's going on that's bigger than I can hold here. That's when I bring in real help, and usually that means a call home too. I'll tell you when I'm doing it. That's not breaking trust - it's what care actually looks like."*

Those are the same promises that are on the learner's privacy page in Part 1, in your own voice. Said up front, that is a promise kept. Said only in the moment, it feels like betrayal.

- **The gate before each heavy session, in writing.** The second adult is a precondition, and a precondition is not a check. Three times this year - before the first heavy Tuesday of No Easy Answers, before the death scene, and before the Council's first deep deliberation day - stop and certify, in writing, dated, on the plan, that the floor built in August is still real today: the quiet space is still a room and not a cupboard; the named clinician still has a current number, will still take the call, and in December is reachable across the holiday or has a named backup who is; the one adult outside the room is reachable across the break that follows; the second adult is named, by name, for the day; and the consented walk of this session's floor has happened, with the date and who walked it. Name the second adult because a rule met by "I'll find someone" is a feeling, and a gate nobody signs is a gate nobody holds. It is three times and not once because the Helm's heavy sessions sit in October, December and April, and a pathway built before Session 1 is eight months old by the Council; numbers go stale, rooms get repurposed, and a second adult in a room with a

dead referral number is a held room with no trapdoor. A solo studio has no second signature, so the guide self-certifies and says so plainly. Coach, not therapist: the gate certifies the container, never a treatment. If a line cannot be signed, the lighter version runs that week, and that is the floor working.

- **Material is chosen, not sprung; opt-in by readiness.** The heaviest content is previewed, alternates are chosen before the day and never improvised, because an alternate chosen on the day is chosen in front of the learner who needs it and announces them. No learner is required to disclose anything about their own life to take part. The lighter version of the whole year is the honorable first pass, because a floor never run has never been tested and the first tribe is the test. The full version is a choice a rested tribe makes on purpose, before the year, never something a tired room slides into, because exhaustion decides late, after the heavy day is on the calendar, while readiness decides early.

Leadership styles taught by example

In the leadership work you will use well-known ship captains and public leaders as examples - different styles of leading, all real. Present them plainly, as public teaching examples. “Here are four real captains with four different styles; which do you lead like?” is a teaching device, nothing more. They are not insider lore and they are not personas giving advice. They are examples a learner can look up on their own, the way you would study any public leader.

Holding a “no” - three beats

Decline-with-reasoning lives or dies in the single moment a learner actually says no. If that moment collapses into invisible opt-out - silence, the activity just continues around them - the learner is protected by being erased from the room. So hold a no in three beats, and you can run them under load:

1. **Receive the no, whole.** “Okay. You’re not doing this one.” Honor it *before* any curiosity, so your curiosity never lands as a lever.
2. **Offer the door once, and don’t push it.** “That no stands, and it’s done. When you’ve worked out what’s behind it, the tribe will want to hear it. Not me - them. And not today.” Hold both halves or you have turned the practice into a toll: the reasoning is genuinely owed to the room, and it is genuinely not owed in the moment. If a learner never comes back to it, that is between them and the tribe, and it is not yours to collect.
3. **Keep them inside the encounter.** “Come sit with me - you don’t have to do the thing.” Removing the task is not the same as removing the person.

Your curious question stays a mirror, never a way to scare someone into yes. Ask “when do you think you’ll first run into this for real?” - not “what happens the first time you need this and no one is beside you?” The first opens a door with curiosity; the second forecasts them alone and unequipped, which lands on an anxious learner as “you’ll be sorry.” And “the right kind of scared” is the learner’s to name about themselves. It is never yours to assign to them. You have a voice. You never have a veto.

Watch-fors, and protect yourself

This year asks the most of the guide, too. Holding hard material costs the holder, and the whole floor depends on you having enough reserve left to notice the one learner going under.

- **Run your own floor.** Do your own settle, your own way down at day’s end, your own closing minute. This is safety instrumentation, not self-care - a guide whose own body is flooded cannot run the watch-and-pivot. The room reads your nervous system faster than any lesson plan can counter.
- **Debrief after every heavy day.** After each heavy deep day, debrief with a peer or supervisor before the next heavy session. Do not carry it alone.
- **A second adult on the heaviest days** protects you as much as the room.
- **Lightening or deferring is honorable.** If the load is too much in a given week, the lighter version is the floor working. What you can hold sets how many learners are in the room, and both come before money, because a learner enrolled on coverage not yet secured is one the floor cannot hold, and the day it fails is the day you find out.
- **Your fallow day is fallow too, and so are the breaks.** Protected, not on-call. The learner’s page says plainly that you are not reachable over a break, so you never have to improvise that limit on the last guided day; what you say aloud before each break is who is: the one adult outside the room, and 988. Every session here ends into a break: the September break after the Mantle, the October break after No Easy Answers, Thanksgiving after the Ripple, the two-week winter break after the Stage and its death scene, the February break after the Arena of Voices while a mentor’s silence may still be landing, the April break after the Bridge, and after the Council, Open Waters, which holds the Launch for a leaving learner, and then the summer, the longest absence in the cycle. Say it on the last guided day, every time, in one fixed form: “The break starts Friday and runs [length]. I won’t be reachable - that’s my rest too. [Name] is, the whole time, not only on studio days; here is how to reach them. 988 is free and open all day and all night, call or text, from anywhere. The path to real help stays open the whole break. I’m back in the room on [day].” For the winter break, say the real date back, not “January.” For the summer, say it on Open Waters’ last guided day, Thu May 23.

Part 3 - The sessions

Each session below gives you: what it's for, a plain word for the learner, the flow, things you might say, the settle and closing minute, watch-fors, and what you'll need. Each session header carries its calendar weeks and projected dates; the week labels inside a session count from that session's first week. The weeks inside a session follow one small grammar, and the word in brackets after each week says which beat it is: a session opens, deepens, applies, and harvests. The week the work leaves the room and comes back is a gather. A three-week session doubles up. The Arena of Voices' fourth week is named what it is: fallow. A week left unplanned carries no beat, because a beat is a job and nobody has given it one.

One word about words. Part 1 said the Log is kept however you hold it, and that holds all year. When the sessions below say write, draft, or read, they mean put it in your Log and go back to it, in whatever form yours takes. The book says write because it is the shortest word, not because it is the only way. The same holds for stand, walk, speak, perform, wear, and cross: they mean take part in the way your body takes part. And anything the room listens to has a transcript in the room; anything the room reads can be heard. Both are on the table for everyone before anyone needs them; nobody has to ask.

Session 1 - The Mantle (four weeks, Aug 13 - Sep 6)

What it's for. To open the year by meeting imposter feeling honestly - naming it as the felt sensation of growth, not a defect - and to take up the Mantle you will carry all year. The imposter's lie is "everyone else belongs here and I snuck in." The truth is that accomplished people feel it too, and for many people it fades with acting, not with proving. For some it stays, and they act with it there.

For the learner. "Who am I to make hard calls?" Most people feel that knot when they reach past what they can already do, including people who have done a great deal. This session names that feeling and puts something beside it: real evidence of hard things you have already done, pulled from your own record. Then there is a rite, the Mantle, where you may say aloud what you are taking up for the year. For some people worthiness arrives after the acting. For some it doesn't, and they act anyway. Both are the year.

Here is the whole of it, said now. You will not be asked to share a time you felt like a fraud. The adults do that part - the guide and a mentor say theirs, specifically - and you receive it. If you want one of yours in the room, you put it on a card with no name and the guide reads it as "someone here once felt." Nobody can see who wrote and who did not. Right after, same morning, you build

your Evidence File from any real proof you have: the Origin portfolio if you were here for it, your Forge project, work from outside the studio. In the fourth week there is a short rite, and you will hear the whole of it on the Tuesday before. You'll be asked to say one sentence, in your own words, about what you're taking up this year. You can say it to the room, say it quietly to your chosen witness only, put it on a card the witness reads out, or say nothing and still take the mantle. The mantle is a real object; you take it up yourself, worn, held, or set in your hands. One person you chose says back what they saw. If you don't take it up this session, nothing in the year closes to you; you can take it up any week in a walk-in, and the Council is open to you either way. Stepping out mid-rite costs nothing.

The flow.

Weeks 1-4 · Aug 13 - Sep 6 · off: Mon Sep 3, Labor Day

The fourth week goes to the front, as Origin's did. After the rite there is already air: a break with the mantle at home, then the craft weeks of No Easy Answers before its heavy block. Before the first heavy thing there was none: the first week carried the exit ramp, the privacy words, the one adult, the destination, the agreements, the Log and Vineyard for a joiner, and then on Thursday an adult stranger saying a time they felt like a fraud, in the week the room met. So the first week is the crossing into the year, and nothing heavy is in it. The room is mixed - returners who know each other and learners for whom this is day one - so everything is carried on a shared task, side by side, so the joiner is never the only person being introduced.

Week 1 (open) is the threshold week. **Tuesday: arrival, then the door.** The walk-in, the settle (fix your words this week and keep them), the circle with pass, the map of the year, the Table. Then the exit ramp is built and walked before any promise is asked for; then the privacy words as written, and the one adult outside the room named with how to reach them, and breaks said. Say the day-one line. Introduce the no-win frame on something game-sized, as the same muscle. Say the word for the knot, imposter feeling, once, as a name only: "Most people hearing that line feel a knot. It has a name, and next week two adults will tell you about theirs." The modelling waits a week. **Wednesday: nothing is asked back. Thursday: the tribe's own half.** The floor said first, the six things the agreements cannot make enforceable; the agreements co-written, on cards or aloud, named reopenable with the when said in words; the no-sign line said. Then, separate, the carried objects: the Log named for anyone new, every form on the table and said to the whole room so no one is the only person being told; the Vineyard re-opened for returners and named in the walk-in for anyone new, never in a round. Name the crew, and say which days the second adult is first in the room, so the heavy days of the next session are already visible from here. Week 2 (deepen): Tuesday is lighter - the no-win question, group work, and the real act seeded, "this week or next, one real thing that scares you a little." Thursday, the deep day: the guide and the invited mentor model imposter feeling, genuinely and specifically, and the learners receive it; the cards, optional, in any form a learner can make alone, read once in the guide's voice with no name, then

gone. The same morning, before the way down, the Evidence File is begun, from each learner's own record in the form it was made - the learner's page promises "right after, same morning," and the flow keeps that promise, because nobody leaves with the knot surfaced and the counterweight unbuilt. Week 3 (apply): "Why not you?" The Evidence File grows across the week; the real act, once done, goes into it in the learner's own words, whether it found worthiness or only a thing done. Walk-ins carry the credit and path conversation for anyone whose last year this is. Thursday: the mantle object is brought into the room and handled, with no ask attached; each learner chooses their witness privately in the walk-in. Week 4 (harvest): **Tuesday, the approach.** The rite told in full, all four movements, the three ways to say the sentence and the fourth way of saying nothing; the object in the room again; a learner who wants to draft their sentence does it in their Log, or does not. Ask the pace question at this day's close, so the crossing day carries nothing else. **Wednesday is the interval, named out loud as one:** learner-run, one carried question, "what are you taking up?", nothing handed in; the sentence is chosen after a night and a day of the learner's own air, not in the hour the object was handed to them. **Thursday, the rite**, on the deep day, so the crossing gets its silence: the threshold, the object, the witness, the wearing. The way down, the Table and the hands block are the landing - the mantle worn into an ordinary hour of the same morning, and nobody asks about it. Close with the close-return and the closing minute at session scale; say who is reachable over the break and that you are not, and that the agreements are open; then the mantle goes home. A learner who did not take it up has a walk-in any week of the year.

This is the rebuilt session - read this carefully. The old version had "everyone shares a time they felt like a fraud, going around the circle." That is gone, on purpose. Shame and imposter feeling are not the same emotion. Imposter feeling ("I don't belong here yet") is generative. Public shame disclosure in a peer group, at the age of peak peer-sensitivity, can wound lastingly - and opting out of a shame ritual in front of peers becomes its own quiet shame event. So the structure is fixed:

- The dissolving power comes from **adults modeling, learners receiving** - not from any learner being required to share.
- No circle-round, no going-around.
- If a learner *wants* to share, it is **non-attributed** - put on a card in any form a learner can make alone (written, typed, or recorded alone in the quiet space) and always read aloud in the guide's voice, with no name ("someone here once felt…"). The guide's voice is what keeps abstention invisible for a learner who cannot write.
- **Abstention is invisible.** In a "receive, then optionally make a card" structure, no one can see who chose not to. That is the only way opt-out is real in a peer room. The cards are read once and then gone; nobody keeps them or matches a hand to a name.
- The Evidence File comes immediately after, the same morning. Never leave a room having surfaced shame without building the counterweight of real evidence of competence.

Things to say. - “In May you make a hard call in the open, before your people. Everything from here is getting ready to sit in that chair and mean it.” - “That feeling of not-belonging-yet? Accomplished people feel it too. It doesn’t mean you snuck in. It means you’re reaching.” - “Why not you? If not you, who?” - “You don’t have to feel ready to act. Many find the feeling comes after. If it doesn’t, you still did the thing, and the thing was real.” - (At the rite) “I saw you take that up.”

The settle and the closing minute. Open with the settle - shame lives in the body (heat, dropped gaze, a curled spine), so settle the room before you touch the material. Go in small steps: the adults speak first and nothing is asked of anyone at the start, so the counterweight of evidence is built before anything heavy is held. Close with the close-return. This is an opening session, so the closing minute matters; “take your closing minute” is the whole prompt, and “I don’t know yet” is a real close.

Watch-fors. A learner who dips into shame needs the room to treat it as normal and needs the exit ramp they can use without asking. What someone puts on a card can be bigger than a card; the referral pathway is live before this session runs. Guard the order so that any modeling is never the price of admission to the Mantle; the evidence of worth must be reachable by the learner who says nothing aloud.

What you’ll need. One shared task to carry the first week; cards for agreement contributions; an invited mentor for the modeling in week 2; cards for optional non-attributed sharing, in any form a learner can make alone; each learner’s own record for the Evidence File, in the form it was made, with a transcript for any recorded part; the physical mantle object, one that can be worn, held, or placed beside a learner, and a witness each learner chooses for the rite; the exit ramp and quiet space set up; the one adult outside the room, written; the referral pathway live.

Session 2 - No Easy Answers (five weeks, Sep 17 - Oct 18) - one of the three heaviest

What it’s for. To learn to reason through real moral dilemmas from principle, out loud, without an answer key. The world does not hand you the right answer. The win is not the verdict - it is the quality of the reasoning and the honesty about the cost. This is how the captain who will hold the Council learns to think.

For the learner. Some questions have no clean right answer, and pretending they do is a lie. This session you practice standing inside one long enough to reason from your own principles instead of grabbing the exit. The cases come through story and real history, so you can think about heavy things at full weight without anyone saying anything about their own life.

Here is what the stories touch, said now so none of it is a surprise: a person who wants to end their own suffering; being forced; being pressed to be like everyone else; and the Dred Scott case, which is not the other side of a hard call but a real court reasoning its way into evil - we study it to learn the difference. The two heaviest weeks are previewed, each has a lighter alternate ready, and a second adult is in the room: not to watch you, but so that if one person needs to leave, someone goes with them and the room still stands. You can step out any time, no reason owed. The harvest is a reasoned position on a hard case. “I can name the two goods that collide here and I haven’t decided” is a reasoned position.

The flow.

Weeks 5-9 · Sep 17 - Oct 18 · off: Mon Oct 8, Indigenous Peoples’ Day / Columbus Day · the two heavy days are Tuesdays, Oct 2 and Oct 9, with the second adult in the room

This session opens after the first break of the year: re-thread first. The method is moral dilemmas told through allegory, meaning a story that stands in for a real thing (well-known dramatic episodes), tied to real historical cases - personhood (paired with the Dred Scott case), due process under fear (paired with McCarthyism), loyalty versus truth (paired with whistleblowing). Weeks 1 and 2 (open, deepen) build the reasoning craft on progressively harder cases, and they build the floor’s habits on light ground at the same time: the Reasoning Standard is in every learner’s hands, the difference between a real dilemma and a rationalized wrong is taught, and the pre-brief (name the terrain, name the exit, name that no reason is owed) is run before the week 1 and week 2 deep blocks, so that by week 3 it is a familiar shape rather than a warning. On the Thursday of week 2, Sep 27, preview both heavy weeks to the room - what each touches and which day - and take the readiness read in the walk-in, one learner at a time, never round the circle, so the alternate for anyone who needs one is chosen then, in advance, and nobody is announced on the day. Weeks 3 and 4 (apply) are the heaviest cases, one each week, previewed and alternated. In these two weeks the heavy thing runs on the Tuesday, so the held day is the Thursday and no one carries it alone into a weekend: the second adult is in the room on Tue Oct 2 and Tue Oct 9, and Thu Oct 4 and Thu Oct 11 open no new heavy ground. Week 4’s Tuesday follows the holiday weekend, so its pre-brief carries the whole arrival and assumes nothing from week 3 is still warm. Ask the pace question at the close of week 3, Thu Oct 4, while there is still time to act on the answer before the second heavy case. If the second adult cannot be there on a heavy Tuesday, the lighter alternate runs that morning and the deep version waits outside this session; it does not move into week 5. Week 5 (harvest) has nothing heavy in it: each learner makes a reasoned position on a hard case, held from principle - not “won” - and an undecided position honestly reasoned is a whole harvest. On the last guided day, Thu Oct 18, ask the pace question, run the closing minute at session scale, and say aloud who is reachable over the break.

The spine of the session is the **Reasoning Standard** - five structural questions the reasoning must answer, none of which is "what is the right answer." Use it to coach, to self-assess, and to hold yourself to as well:

1. **Principles named** - which two or more genuine goods conflict here? (If there is only one real principle, it is not a dilemma - it may be a rationalized wrong. Say which.)
2. **Cost owned** - what does your path cost, and to whom? (A path that claims to be free is hiding its cost.)
3. **Steelman survived** - can you state the position you rejected well enough that its holder would say "yes, that's it"?
4. **Reversibility** - would you accept this reasoning if you were the person it costs?
5. **Framework visible** - are you reasoning through consequences, duty, character, or care? What does a different lens see that yours misses?

Two guardrails to teach. There is a well-known map of how moral reasoning grows up, made by a psychologist named Kohlberg; it describes *arguments*, never ranks *people*, and the map itself is argued over - say so. And teach the distinction between a genuine dilemma and a rationalized wrong. Some paired cases are real dilemmas. Some are not - Dred Scott is the study of how a system reasoned itself into evil, not "the other side of a hard call." A curriculum that cannot tell those apart teaches false equivalence. Teaching learners to tell them apart teaches the sharpest blade of the year. Real cases get real study - primary voices, the human cost named - or the pairing drops to allegory only. Honor the reality, or do not borrow its weight.

Things to say. - "The world doesn't come with an answer key. The win here isn't the answer - it's how well you reasoned and how honestly you named the cost." - "A story that stands in for the real thing isn't the watered-down version. It's the tool that lets us think about the hardest things at full weight, and nothing about your own life has to come into the room." - "Say the strongest version of the side you disagree with - well enough that someone who holds it would say, yes, that's exactly it." - "Dred Scott isn't the other side of a dilemma. It's how a whole system reasoned itself into evil. Learning to tell those apart is the whole game." - (In the heaviest weeks) "Today's story touches death and the choice to end suffering. You can step out any time, you don't owe anyone a reason, and there's water and a chair by the window."

The settle and the closing minute. Every heavy day: the settle to open, a short way down between hard passages (thirty seconds: feet on the floor or hands on the chair, look around the room, one breath), the close-return in its fixed words. Pre-brief before every flagged-heavy episode - name the terrain, name the exit, name that no reason is owed. This is arrival, not ambush, and it does the most for the least of anything you do. The dilemma work is an opening; close it with the closing minute (the feeling-side twin of the Reasoning Standard - reason the hard call, *and* re-cross what it stirred).

Watch-fors. Second adult required on the two heavy Tuesdays. Preview-and-alternate the heaviest episodes - assisted death, coercion, identity and conformity - with alternates chosen before the day, never improvised. The dilemma can be unflinching about the world; the learner's own interior is never required as material. If the care starts to sound like a prediction, as if the room expects you to fall apart, say less about the net and keep every bit of it in place.

What you'll need. The allegory episodes and their alternates pre-selected, each captioned, with a transcript, and audio-described where a described version exists - where none does, the guide says aloud what is on the screen as it plays; the paired real cases with primary sources, in print and audio; the Reasoning Standard on one page and read aloud once; a second adult secured for the two heavy Tuesdays, named before the session opens; the settle, the way down, the close-return and the exit ramp in place; the referral pathway live.

Session 3 - The Ripple (three weeks, Oct 29 - Nov 15, ends into Thanksgiving)

What it's for. To learn consequence-thinking - looking one, two, three moves downstream of a choice, and being honest that you cannot see all the way. Good captains think in ripples, not single points. This is a deliberately lighter, playful beat between the two heaviest sessions.

For the learner. A hard call doesn't end when you make it. It sets things in motion - some you meant, some you didn't. This session is about looking downstream before you act, and staying humble about the part of the river you can't see yet.

The flow.

Weeks 10-12 · Oct 29 - Nov 15 · on a guide day: Tue Nov 6, Election Day, observance decided before the session · off: Mon Nov 12, Veterans Day observed · ends into Thanksgiving

Re-thread first, short. The tools are games and maps: the Ripple Board (map the first-, second-, and third-order effects of a choice), the Monkey's Paw (every wish granted with an unforeseen cost - the shadow side of "solutions"), counterfactual history (change one thing, follow the ripples), and the Pre-Mortem (imagine the choice already failed - why?). Week 1 (open, re-thread) opens with the games, week 2 (deepen) goes downstream two and three moves, week 3 (apply, harvest) harvests a real decision traced forward, with blind spots owned and agency kept.

This session opens after the break: re-thread first. Because it is medium-weight and safe, it is one of the two homes for meeting a hard thing with only the ordinary supports rather than the full net - the guide present, the exit available, but the visible net turned down. This is chosen and named by the learner, never sprung, for a learner who chooses it, launching this year or not, and never

pressed on a learner already carrying more than enough. Reduce the visible net, never the floor's availability. The last guided day of this session is the last before Thanksgiving: ask the pace question, run the closing minute at session scale, and say aloud who is reachable over the break, and that you are not.

Things to say. - "Every choice sends ripples. Chase the cascade - then what? And then what?" - "The wish always comes with a twist. What's the shadow of this solution?" - "You can't see all the way downstream, and pretending you can is its own mistake. The move is: act wisely, watch for the ripples, adjust."

The settle and the closing minute. Carry the settle and the close even though the day is light - a light session still bookends. Closing minute as usual.

Watch-fors. Consequence-thinking can tip into anxiety ("what if everything goes wrong"). Always pair it with agency - "and here is the move you can still make." The point is wiser action, not fear of acting. Keep this session light on purpose; do not import heavy material into the room's breath between the two hardest sessions. No second adult needed.

What you'll need. The Ripple Board setup, said aloud as each ripple goes up; a Monkey's Paw story or two, read aloud or with a transcript; counterfactual prompts; each learner's own Forge project for the Pre-Mortem, or any real decision of their own for a learner who joined this year.

Session 4 - The Stage (three weeks, Nov 26 - Dec 13, ends into the winter break) - one of the three heaviest

What it's for. To feel a hard call from inside the lives it touches, through theatre - and to practice the discipline of stepping fully into another life and cleanly back out again. The distance of the stage is a safety feature, like allegory: you can *be* the person who makes the other choice.

For the learner. To make a hard call well, you have to feel it from inside the lives it touches. Theatre is a way to practice that from a safe distance: you try a person on, then you step out of them, and stepping out whole matters as much as stepping in. Performing is always a choice; watching is equal, and the harvest is yours in either shape: a moment you performed, or a moment you witnessed and can say what the other person carried.

One play, *Our Town*, has a scene where a young woman who has died comes back to relive one ordinary day. That is the one place this year where the story does not stand between you and the thing, because death on a stage is death. So, said now: that day is the second Tuesday of this session, the one Tuesday this year that carries the deep block, so the Thursday after it can be a held day with nothing new in it; a second adult is in the room that morning; there is a named exit

for that scene; and if you have lost someone recently and would want the day planned around you, tell the guide once, one to one, any time before that week. The guide will ask you too, in the first week, never in the circle, and you can say you would rather not answer. You decide what to say and whether to; nobody goes looking. Every role is chosen. You can perform, hand a role to the tribe, watch, or decline.

The flow.

Weeks 13-15 · Nov 26 - Dec 13 · ends into the winter break · the death scene is Tue Dec 4, with the second adult in the room, and Thu Dec 6 is held

Week 1 (open, re-thread) opens after Thanksgiving: re-thread first, then warm-ups and improv as play, and the first de-roling on a role that is nothing, a shopkeeper or a weather report, so the move (say or sign your name, three true things about your real life, prop down, shake out, feel what is under you) is in the body on something that costs nothing before it is needed on something that does; every learner de-roles at least twice from a light role before Dec 4. Tell the room on this Tuesday what the three weeks hold: that the death scene is next Tuesday, the one Tuesday this year that carries the deep block, and that the Thursday after it is held; describe the scene in words and offer the four ways to be in the room for it (perform, hand the role to the tribe, witness, decline), now, because offering them on the day they land is too late for the learner who needs them. On the own day between, each learner finds or writes a monologue from someone facing a hard call; on the Thursday the monologues are given from the inside, in voice, sign, or a recording, performing voluntary, witnessing equal, de-roled every single time. Across this week's one-to-ones, the noon check-ins and the walk-ins and never the circle, the guide asks each learner whether there is a recent loss they would want next Tuesday planned around; it is the week after Thanksgiving, so for some the loss is five days old again. A learner may tell the guide before being asked and may decline to answer, nothing is written either way, and the plan for that day, alternate included, is set by Thursday, Nov 29. Week 2 (deepen) is *Our Town* and its question: "Do any human beings ever realize life while they live it?" Emily returns from death to relive one ordinary day. It runs on the Tuesday, Dec 4, with the second adult in the room, the exit named for the scene, the pre-brief said, every role chosen, the Table as the come-down, the close-return in its fixed words. The Thursday, Dec 6, is the held day: no new hard ground, the room together, improv and play if the room wants them, the play's ordinary morning read seated if the room wants the play back in daylight, hands and each other, the closing minute, and the pace question, with a week left to act on it; nobody carries Emily alone into a weekend. Week 3 (apply, harvest) is the lighter week, designed and not accidental, and nothing in it touches death or recent loss: the Tuesday is theatre as play again, and each learner chooses the moment they will bring to the harvest, one performed or one witnessed. This is the first half of the midpoint crossing, because the midpoint of the year is the winter break itself, crossed with the learner's body out of the room: on the Tuesday ask the re-ask (*is this still yours?*) to the room and take the answers one at a time across the week's one-to-ones, never round the circle. The Thursday, Dec 13, harvests a moment of

empathy, stepping fully into another life and back out whole, performed or witnessed, and “I watched, and here is what she was carrying” is a whole harvest. Then the look-back across the four sessions so far (the Mantle taken up, the reasoning, the ripple, the lives tried on - who are you becoming?), the pace question, and the re-entry note to your future self so the throughline survives two weeks away. It is the last guided day before the two-week winter break: say aloud who is reachable across it, that 988 is always open, that you are not until the real date back, and that the pathway stays live the whole time, the clinician’s holiday availability having been confirmed in writing before Dec 4; say the agreements are open; run the closing minute at session scale. In the lighter Stage, week 2’s Tuesday runs the play’s ordinary morning and asks Emily’s question of the living, with no death scene and no second adult needed, and everything else is the same. Forum Theatre, which this session once held, now lives in the Bridge, where stopping a scene and stepping in is practiced as holding the room, and it pays off in the Council from there.

Archetypes are taught as **doorways, not identities**: you try a way of being on; you are not it. “I encountered the Hero,” never “I am the Hero.”

Two closes are kept strictly separate here. **De-roling** closes a *role* - “that wasn’t me.” The **closing minute** closes a real *feeling* the role opened - “that was me, and I carry it, and I’m still here.” Never de-role real grief. De-roling teaches “that wasn’t me”; grief needs “that was me, and I am still here.” Keep the line bright.

Things to say. - “You’re not becoming this person. You’re trying them on. It’s a doorway, not who you are.” - “Do any of us ever really realize life while we’re living it? Every, every minute?” - (After an embodiment, the de-roling) “Say or sign your own name. Name three things true about your real life right now - I am [name], I am 17, it’s Tuesday, I have soccer after this. Now shake out your hands, or whatever part of you moves, and feel what’s under you - the floor, the chair, your own hands.” - (For real grief that surfaces) “That was real. That was you. Let’s not push it out - it can stay, and you’re still here.” - (The Tuesday before, and again that morning) “Next Tuesday is the one Tuesday this year that’s the deep day. The story touches death, and it doesn’t stand between you and it the way the others have. You can step out any time, no reason owed; [name] is in the room so nobody goes out alone; and Thursday is held, nothing new.” - (At the harvest) “If you watched, tell us what she was carrying. That’s a whole harvest.”

The settle and the closing minute. The settle to open, a short way down in the middle of the work, the close-return at the end, every heavy day. De-role after *every* embodiment, with the real mechanic (say or sign your name, three true things about your real life, remove the prop, shake out, feel what is under you) - not once per session, every single time a body wears another life, because the nervous system does not know a role is pretend; it runs the state for real. The first de-roling in week 1 is on a role that costs nothing, so the move is a reflex before it is needed. Then the closing minute for anything real the role opened.

Watch-fors. Second adult required on the *Our Town* death-scene deep day - it is the one place this year's story-distance does not apply, because death on the stage *is* the real thing, and it lands straight on anyone carrying a recent loss, with no story in between. Ask in the first week, across the noon check-ins and the walk-ins so every learner is reached one to one and never in the circle, whether anyone has lost someone recently and would want the scene planned around them; it is the week after Thanksgiving, so for some the loss is five days old again. The learner decides what to tell you; you do not go looking, and nothing is written either way. The ask is finished and the alternate chosen by the first Thursday; this is a judgment made before the day, never improvised, with a previewed exit named for that scene specifically. The death-scene Tuesday carries the Thursday shape, the deep block and the second adult; if the second adult falls through, the scene does not run Dec 4 and does not move to Dec 11, the lighter Stage runs, and there is no later home in the year for the scene, so that is the year's answer. The held Thursday and the lighter week exist so that nobody's last sight of the room before two weeks away is Emily. Roles are always chosen; a role can be given to the tribe only, witnessed rather than performed, or declined. Protect the theatre-as-play as genuine joy, not only a safety warm-up, and keep the Vineyard distinct from the de-roling toolkit, because the moment the thing you love is used to bring you down from a role it has been made useful, and that is the day it dies.

What you'll need. Monologue sources in print, large print, and audio; the *Our Town* text in a form each learner can read or hear, any film of it captioned with a transcript, and the death scene described in words before it runs; the second adult confirmed for the second Tuesday before the session opens, and the lighter Stage ready if that falls through; the referral roster's holiday availability confirmed in writing before Dec 4, with a named backup who is reachable Dec 20 to Jan 2; whatever learners chose to tell you about a recent loss; a previewed exit; the de-roling space and mechanic; the settle, the way down, the close-return and the exit ramp; the referral pathway live.

Session 5 - The Arena of Voices (six weeks, Dec 31 - Feb 7)

What it's for. To learn from real adults walking the road ahead - professional mentors and guest speakers - and to learn the real skill of being mentored well. No one navigates alone. Being mentored can be a threshold. Some feel seen by it; some get a useful answer and nothing more; both count.

For the learner. Some adults are further down your road, and a conversation with one can be worth a lot. This session you learn how to be mentored: come with one real question you actually want answered, ask it, and say thank you afterward. Two honest things before you write to anyone. A lot of people won't answer. That says nothing about you; busy people are busy, and silence says nothing about your worth. And one-to-one mentors may not happen this year, because the

structure that keeps that door safe is still being built. If it is not ready, nobody is passed over: the guest speakers and your own interview are the whole session, not a lesser one. You will hear which it is in the second week, before anyone writes to anyone. Any mentoring match can be ended with one word to the guide, no reason owed. “I reached out and nothing came back” is a real harvest.

The flow.

Weeks 16-21 · Dec 31 - Feb 7 · on a guide day: Tue Jan 1, New Year’s Day (as projected; the real break likely moves) · off: Mon Jan 21, MLK Day · no break inside this session

Being mentored is a threshold: the ask is the crossing, the wait is the held threshold, the reply is the landing, the thank-you is the carrying forward. Three of those four movements cannot be put on a schedule without lying about them. Only the thank-you can, and it is the learner’s own act, which needs no reply. That is what keeps six weeks from becoming a march. Week 1 (open, re-thread) is the second half of the midpoint crossing: the big re-thread as the whole first morning and nothing else, where were you, where are you now, what came back changed, after the longest gap of the year, which followed the death scene; the safety floor said aloud again, the exit ramp, the one adult, the pathway; no prompt. As printed this week has one guide day; one is enough for this. If the real calendar gives the week its Tuesday back, Tuesday is the re-thread and Thursday a light Work of the Day with nothing asked; nothing else in the flow moves. Week 2 (deepen) is the art of being mentored: prepare, ask, follow up; questions drafted; the no-answer line said before anyone writes to anyone; the two-track told plainly - whether the one-to-one door is open this year was decided before the session, and this is the week the learner hears which, never later; “I’m not asking anyone” named now as a true answer to the session’s question. Week 3 (apply) is the ask: the first guest speaker, the window - the drafted questions asked of a live adult, answered in the room, the thank-you said before they leave - so the whole rite is walked once, small and held, before anyone walks it at a distance where the reply may never come. At the end of the week the asks go out, from whoever chooses to send one. Week 4 (gather) is the fallow week, and it stays empty. No new voices. **This is the year’s one deliberately empty stretch inside the arc, and it is un-harvested: no Work of the Day, nothing reported, nothing to hand in.** The grid still runs, and the middle block is low-stakes craft, or nothing. The question went out last week and is answered when it is answered. The guide’s work this week is the walk-in, for whoever wants to say where the ask stands: sent, answered, still waiting, or not sent. “Not sent” closes the question, and nobody is asked it twice. Nobody is behind. The silence is the session’s work, not a gap before it; the pace question sits in this week’s walk-ins, one to one. MLK Day removes the Monday. Week 5 is held, not filled: nothing is planned for it, on purpose. Replies that have come are received on their own clock - an interview happens when it happens, on an own-day, in the hands block, or after the session has ended - and a second guest speaker has a home here at the Table if one is sourced warmly, but the week stands whole without one and the book does not plan for one. Week 6 (harvest) thanks: a real conversation and what it opened, or “I asked, and nothing has come yet”; the thank-you to everyone asked, replied or not; the pace question; the re-ask (*is*

this still yours?), answered one at a time in the walk-in, never round the circle - after the long middle stretch is the yes that matters, with ten weeks left to act on a no; the closing minute at session scale; who is reachable over the break, and that a reply arriving in February is still received. The mentor door, if the container exists, runs alongside weeks 2 and 3 and the relationship runs past the session on its own clock, into the Bridge; if it does not, nobody is passed over and no week is empty for its absence.

The two-track design (binding). A guest speaker is a window; a one-to-one mentor is a door. Secure them differently.

- **Guest speakers (the window): buildable now, with a modest policy.** Guide present for the entire visit (this alone satisfies the never-alone rule); a public, observable setting; a short expectations sheet the speaker acknowledges (topic scope, no private contact with learners, no photos without consent); parent notification of who and when. No background check is required for a one-time supervised group speaker - the supervision *is* the control, and requiring checks would kill the ability to bring interesting people in. Watch the conversion point: a speaker who starts contacting a learner afterward has walked through the door without being vetted for it - route any follow-up through the guide, which moves them to the mentor track.
- **One-to-one professional mentors (the door): not cleared until the container exists.** Observable channel only - no private messages, personal social media, or off-platform contact; the guide sees that contact exists and how often, never reads the content for assessment. Never-alone satisfied by structure - default remote and monitored; in person only with the guide present or in a public setting, never a private residence or vehicle. A background check before first contact. Three-party informed consent (parent, learner, mentor) plus signed boundaries. A no-fault off-ramp - a learner ends or reports a match with one word to the guide, no reason owed, no confrontation. A written safeguarding and mandatory-reporting policy authored once, on paper, before the first match. And a counsel review of Idaho duty-of-care, mandatory reporting, and liability. Build the container before the first match.
- **Reciprocity - honor the givers, never mine them.** Pay real honoraria and cover costs (a waived fee is accepted only if freely offered, never solicited). Offer a menu of depths - one informational interview, a short arc, or a sustained mentorship - with the one-off honored identically to the year-long. Bounded terms and a dignified exit. The teen arrives prepared. Close the loop: thank them, tell them what their gift did, ask whether it served them too. A professional's hard-call story is a gift, never the price of admission - especially one that sits close to a wound, which is invited freely and never required as content. The mentor is not the load-bearing safeguarding adult; route weight it wasn't built for to the guide.

Source mentors warmly, through communities that already hold relationship - the parent network, local professional and civic bodies - never by cold approach, because a mentor reached through someone who already knows them has a relationship to answer to; a cold one has only the teenager, and a teenager is not a safeguard.

Things to say. - “A good question is a gift to the person answering it. Come with one you actually want answered.” - (The no-answer line, said before any outreach) “If you reach out and hear nothing back - that is not a verdict on you. Busy people are busy. The non-response says nothing about your worth.” - “Tell them what their answer did for you. Close the loop.”

The settle and the closing minute. Carry the settle and the close. Closing minute for what a real conversation opened - or did not.

Watch-fors. The no-answer line matters: reaching out to an admired professional and being ignored is a real wound at this age. Teach “the non-response is not a verdict” *before* the outreach, not as consolation after. This is also the second of the two homes where a learner may choose to meet an ordinary-stakes hard thing with ordinary support - never a manufactured wound, chosen and named by the learner, and never pressed on a learner already carrying more than enough, because the point is an ordinary-sized hard thing met with ordinary support, not a wound made on purpose. Keep the mentor boundary bright.

What you’ll need. The guest-speaker expectations sheet and parent notifications; a second guest speaker only if one is found, since the session stands without one; the mentor-track container fully built before any one-to-one match; a reciprocity plan and honoraria budget; thank-you materials; notes or a transcript of the guest visit for any learner who needs one; the settle in place.

Session 6 - The Bridge (six weeks, Feb 18 - Mar 28)

What it’s for. To practice leading peers and being led well. Leadership is stewardship, not command - the measure of a leader is what continues after they step back. This is where the Mantle is worn in the chair.

For the learner. The best captains lead toward not being needed: they build a crew that can go on without them. This session you may practice both seats, leading and being led, and both are the lesson. You’ll also practice holding a real disagreement from the chair without deciding it, and you will learn the Council’s form here, on a small real question the tribe owns, so that in April the form is already yours and only the dilemma is new. You will be disagreed with, and you will disappoint

someone, in a small real thing, on purpose; that is the practice, not something going wrong. Every turn in the chair is a choice, and a turn that went badly is one of the most useful things that can happen here.

The flow.

Weeks 22-27 · Feb 18 - Mar 28 · off: Mon Feb 18, Presidents Day (the session's first day) · no second adult needed

Re-thread first. Week 1 (open, re-thread) opens what leadership is, command against stewardship, "lead toward your own unnecessity," and both chairs are introduced on the first two mornings: the command chair on the Tuesday, with a real group task and the first turn in it, and the convener's chair on the Thursday, with the first low-stakes real disagreement the tribe owns, which from this week is the outing: where, how, who does what. The convener holds the question and refuses to decide it; the tribe decides. Week 2 (deepen) deepens: find-your-style with the public captains on the Tuesday, turns in both chairs continuing, and the hard parts arriving in the debriefs rather than as a lesson - the loneliness of the final call, disappointing someone, being disagreed with, the quiet leader honored. Forum Theatre arrives here from the Stage on the Thursday, as the way the hard parts are met: a hard-call scene acted out, stopped by anyone with the agreed word, gesture or raised card, stepped into, and tried a different way; played seated, voiced or signed as each learner chooses; de-roled after every scene, every time, because the nervous system does not know a role is pretend. Week 3 (deepen) is the Council's form at low stakes. Tuesday: the four seats, the six phases, the Steelman (with Forum Theatre's stop-and-step-in as its tool), the Third Chair, the board read back, the opening and the release, ground-before-you-speak as craft, and the pass signal agreed as a word and a gesture and kept unchanged to May, each with its because. Thursday: run it whole, once, on a real question the tribe owns and nobody's life (what the tribe does with its own Open Waters weeks is one), every seat filled, the voices absorbing the extra learners, a stand-in named for every seat, the dissent read in with the dissenter's yes while dissent still costs nothing. Debrief warmly: "here's the moment you reached for the answer when your job was to hold the question." **Week 4 is part of the session and is not planned; nothing is set for it and nothing is owed in it.** The one thing that may enter it is a turn in either chair the session already owes a learner whose turn has not come; new content may not. The pace question sits at this week's close, Thu Mar 14. Week 5 (apply) is the real outing, late March, planned by the tribe through the convener's chair and led from the command chair, with the guide led, and planned so every learner can go. The debrief after is where a turn that went badly becomes the most useful thing that happened. Week 6 (harvest) harvests a real act of leading and of being led, or an honest account of a turn that went badly, and one question held from the chair without deciding it. On the last guided day, Thu Mar 28, name the Council's real dilemma to the tribe, with the person who will use its Sense of the Room, so it has the break to sit in, and read the Council's form aloud once, the whole of it, saying plainly that the chair you have been practising from the side is the convener's chair. Ask the pace question, say who is reachable over the break and that

you are not, and run the closing minute at session scale. One guard: the question the tribe holds in week 3's form practice is about a thing the tribe does, never about a person in it; an interpersonal matter goes to the agreements' ladder, not to a board.

Two kinds of leading are built here, and the second is the one the Council needs. **Rotating command** teaches you to sit in the chair and decide. **Rotating facilitation** teaches you to hold the room from beside it - to hold a question without answering it, so the group can. Each learner takes the convener's chair for a low-stakes *real* cohort disagreement and practices refusing to decide. Debrief warmly ("here's the moment you reached for the answer when your job was to hold the question").

Use well-known captains as public teaching examples of different styles - "which do you lead like?" Present them as public figures anyone can study, never as insider lore.

Things to say. - "Leadership is stewardship, not command. The measure of a leader is what keeps going when they step back." - "Lead toward your own unnecessity. A crew that no longer needs you is the goal, not a loss." - "Leading quietly from the back is a different kind of leadership, not a weaker one." - (The loneliness of command) "When the hard call comes, you make it alone. The crew can advise; the crew can't decide. And here's the thing no one warns you about, and its answer: the captain with a life to go home to - the vineyard, the crew you love - makes better hard calls than the one who only has the chair."

The settle and the closing minute. Carry the settle and the close. The closing minute at every close.

Watch-fors. Guard against the room rewarding the loudest; name and honor the quiet leaders. Being led is a skill too - a learner who only ever leads has not finished the lesson, so rotate genuinely. Hold the hard parts internally, not for optics. In a mixed-age room, do not let the graduating learners' turns become the standard the younger ones measure themselves against - every turn in the chair is honored equally. Collaborative and safe by design; no second adult needed.

What you'll need. Real group tasks and a real outing to lead, planned so every learner can go; real low-stakes disagreements for the convener's chair, the outing's own decisions first; Forum Theatre's scenes, chosen to touch no death or recent loss, with the agreed stop and the de-roling space; the Council's four seats and six phases on one page; the pass signal agreed as a word and a gesture; one real question the tribe owns and nobody's life, for the whole run; the Council's real dilemma and the person who will use its Sense of the Room, ready to name on the last guided day; the second adult's four Council dates secured before this session closes, because a four-week session has no week to wait in; the settle in place.

Session 7 - The Council (four weeks, Apr 8 - May 2) - the harvest, one of the three heaviest

What it's for. To make a hard call in the open, before your people - reasoning from principle, naming the cost, honoring dissent, and either finding the third option or, when there isn't one, choosing anyway with your eyes open. This is the mountain the whole year climbed toward, named on day one. The learner wears the Mantle to hold the room.

For the learner. A council is not a debate to win. It is people of good faith reasoning together toward the best hard call they can make. They name the cost. They keep the dissent in the record. When the choice is a false either-or, they refuse it and look for the third way. When the either-or is real, they choose from principle and carry the cost. What you show is your reasoning, not a verdict on you.

Here is the whole of it, said now. The Council is public, your people in the room, and a second adult is there for the same reason as before. Four roles, chosen and rotating, all equally the Council: the one who holds the question, the voices, the scribe, and the one who speaks for whoever is affected and not present. The dilemma is never anyone's own life. A pass word or gesture hands the floor back at zero cost, mid-sentence, no explanation, and every role has a stand-in named in March and confirmed at the tribe's sitting, so stepping out of a public council costs nothing. The Council sits twice: once with the tribe alone, where every seat is yours, and once with your people in the room. Before the second, you choose in the walk-in whether to hold your seat, hold the scribe's seat instead, or hand your seat to your stand-in and sit with the tribe. All three are the Council, and nobody asks why. The Council opens with a sentence that says this isn't ordinary talk and closes with one that says we didn't solve it and it's closed; you'll hear both in rehearsal. When the room's strongest disagreement is read aloud and left standing, it is in the dissenter's own words and only with their yes. The audience has been told they are witnesses, not judges.

After the Council there is a feast, and the feast is the come-down, not one more thing to get right. The base is provided, nobody watches a plate, and you do not have to eat. There is a named place to step out to that night. If your own family is not in the room, the tribe is your people, and you will not fall through this. The Council is in the last week, in the evening. The morning after it has had its night is the year's close. If you are leaving, the Launch comes after that, in the third week of Open Waters, on a day set with you.

The flow.

Weeks 28-31 · Apr 8 - May 2 · the session break falls before this session (Apr 1-4), not inside it · a second adult on all three Thursdays and at the public sitting

Re-thread first, and then the form, met on something light. The Council's form was learned in the Bridge, on a small real question, and it comes back whole on the first morning, said again rather than taught again: the four seats, the six phases, the Steelman, the Third Chair, the board, the pass signal in the same word and gesture the tribe agreed in March, the opening and the release. Week 1 (open, re-thread) opens the real dilemma, named to the tribe on the Bridge's last guided day. On the Tuesday, with the form back in the room, walk the Third Chair's four questions once on each of two short practice cases from the year's own work, one with a third door and one without, so both shapes are fresh; the daily no-win question has been doing this all year. On the Thursday, the first two phases of the real dilemma: the Frame, then Divergence, every position and the fear under it on the board before anyone argues, read back aloud, with the steward of the absent's first list. Nobody argues this week. Week 2 (deepen) deepens into the middle phases, every seat rotated from week 1. Tuesday is the Steelman, voiced and physical: each voice states the case it rejects until its holder says "yes, that's it," and Forum Theatre's stop-and-step-in is the tool. Thursday is the Cost Ledger, every path's cost and who pays, the absent included, on the board and read back. Ask the pace question at the close of week 2, with two weeks still to act on it. Week 3 (apply) applies. Tuesday is the Turn and the Sense of the Room: the Third Chair's four questions on the real dilemma, whether the "or" is real or inherited, where the reasoning arrived and where it honestly did not. The strongest standing dissent is named, and its holder is asked in the walk-in, never in the circle, whether it may be read into the record in their own words. In that same walk-in each learner says which seat they hold for the public sitting: their own, the scribe's, or their stand-in's, sitting with the tribe. Thursday is the tribe's sitting: the whole Council, opening to release, the tribe alone, every seat held by its holder, each stand-in standing in for one phase so that no stand-in is only a name on a list, the pass signal used at least once on purpose so the room has seen it cost nothing, the dissent read in. This is a Council, not a rehearsal for one; it is also the only dry run the public sitting gets, and if the public sitting cannot be held, the Council has still been held. Week 4 (harvest) harvests. Tuesday morning sets the room: the chairs, the Third Chair, the board carried in as the record, the exit named for that room, the audience's briefing (witnesses, not judges), the feast's base. The public sitting is that Tuesday evening or the Wednesday, families and the tribe, never the Thursday; the Wednesday keeps the day-one line true, since Tuesday is April 30. Then the feast, which is the come-down; the Council, the feast and the year-close never share a day, because the release needs a night before anyone is asked what is different in them. The own-day between is the interval, named as one, nothing asked back. The year-close gets the last guided day, Thursday May 2, to itself, after the feast has had its night (Part 4), with the last re-ask asked there. Then Open Waters, and for a leaving learner, the Launch inside it.

The Council is built as a real form, or teenagers in front of an audience default to what school rehearsed - debate to win:

- **Named, rotating roles:** a *convener* (holds the question, not a position), *voices* (argue the live positions in good faith), a *scribe* (writes the reasoning where the room can see it), and a *steward of the absent* (whose only job is "who is affected by this who is not in the room?").
- **A six-phase sequence:** Frame, then Divergence (surface every position and the fear under it, before anyone argues), then the mandatory Steelman, then the Cost Ledger (every path's cost and who pays, on the board), then the Turn (is the either-or real or inherited? - the Third Chair), then the Sense of the Room (where the reasoning arrived, and where it honestly did not).
- **The Steelman, mandatory and physical:** you may not argue your own position until you have voiced the best version of the one you reject, well enough that its holder says "yes, that's it." This builds honoring dissent into the bones. Forum Theatre from Session 6 pays off here.
- **The Third Chair:** an empty chair placed between hardened sides, with four questions - what is each side protecting? Is the "or" real or inherited? What would honor both values at once? And, when there is no third option, choose from principle and carry the grief honestly.
- **A scribe and a board:** reasoning written where all can see, and read back aloud at the end of each phase so the board is heard as well as seen, becomes the object in the room, not the performers. The strongest unresolved dissent is read into the record in the dissenter's own words, with their yes, and left standing, unrefuted, as part of the harvest. A good decision carries its dissent forward visibly.
- **Mark the opening, and release:** a marked opening ("this is not ordinary talk") and a closing that completes the council without resolving the dilemma ("we did not solve it; we reasoned honestly, together, in front of our people; the council is closed"). That release lets a young person carry an unresolved hard thing without it becoming an open wound.

Let the Council deliberate something with real consequence to the community - a real policy, a real trade-off - so the reasoning matters because it is used, not graded.

Things to say. - "A council isn't a debate. A debate has a winner. A council has discernment." - "You can't argue your side until you've said the other side's best case so well its holder would say, yes, that's it." - "Sometimes there's a third door. Sometimes there isn't. Half the wisdom is finding it; the other half is knowing when there isn't one and choosing anyway, with your eyes open." - (The pass signal) "If you need the floor back, just [the agreed word or gesture]. No cost, no explanation." - (The release) "We did not solve it. We reasoned honestly, together, in front of our people. The council is closed." - (At the tribe's sitting) "This is a Council. Nobody is watching but us, and that makes it no smaller."

The settle and the closing minute. The settle to open, a short way down in the middle of the work, the close-return at the end; pre-brief before each sitting. Build a Council so a body cannot fail it: a pass signal, a word and a gesture both, that returns the floor at zero cost, because freezing is something a body does on its own, not a decision, so make it safe; ground-before-you-speak taught as the captain's own craft (feet on the floor or hands on the chair, one breath; steadying yourself is a skill, not a fix for something wrong with you); the audience briefed as witness, not judge, because a room of warm faces steadies every body in it; and the feast protected as the come-down, not one more thing to get right, because eating together in company is the body's signal that the danger is over.

What the Council leaves unresolved stays unresolved on purpose. Carrying a hard thing that has no answer yet is not waiting for the answer; it is the skill this year was for, and the feast is not where the answer arrives. The public Council is an opening in front of other people and needs its private re-crossing afterward, on the year-close day: the closing minute at the whole year's scale, in its fixed words (Part 4). The capacity to close your own openings, for life, is the deepest thing this year hands a graduate.

Watch-fors. Second adult required on all three Thursdays (Divergence, the Cost Ledger, the tribe's sitting) and at the public sitting, all four secured before the Bridge closes - public moral deliberation is being seen twice over: thinking in public, and being wrong in public. The dilemma is always external, never a learner's own life, because a public Council on your own life is a trial, and the promises say no one's life goes on a board for a room to reason about. No forced self-disclosure. A learner may pass, pause, or come back at zero cost. Name and hold the learner with no family in the room: the tribe is your people, and a chosen witness is honored equally, never as consolation.

What you'll need. One real community dilemma with actual stakes, a real dilemma and not a rationalized wrong, with the person or body who will use its Sense of the Room named to the tribe on the Bridge's last guided day; whether it has a third door is for the Turn to find, not the guide to pre-sort; two short practice cases from the year's own work for week 1's Tuesday; the roles and the six-phase form, with a stand-in for every role named in March and confirmed at the tribe's sitting; a scribe's board, read back at each phase; the Third Chair; a second adult for the three Thursdays and the public sitting, secured before the Bridge closes, and childcare for the public sitting's evening, since Tots is a morning; the pass signal, a word and a gesture both, and the exit ramp confirmed and named for the Council room; the audience told they are witnesses, not judges; the feast planned as the come-down with the full inclusion floor (base provided, presence not consumption, allergen-safe, no cover charge); the referral pathway live.

Part 4 - Closing the year and the Launch

The Council harvest

The public Council is the year's harvest and the arc's. It is the showing of reasoning, never a verdict. Close it with the release that completes it without resolving the dilemma, and protect the feast as the come-down.

The year-close

On the last guided day, after the feast has had its own night, three acts, for every learner, staying or leaving. First, a co-authoring close: the learner reviews the year's design *with* the guide, the design named not hidden - "here is how The Helm was built, and why; tell me what to change." The learner's call on their own year, never a feedback form, and declinable like every other quest. Alongside it, put the whole short record of them on the table, unasked: attendance, pace, credit plan, any safety note. Second, the Captain's Log ownership handoff, said aloud once: the Log is theirs; it goes where they say - home, or back to the one place here only they open for next year - and no copy is kept. That is the same whatever form the Log took: if any of it lives on a studio device or in a scribe's hand, it goes to the learner and nothing stays behind. For a leaving learner, this is also the day the Log goes out the door for good. Alongside the first two, the last re-ask, answered one at a time. Third, the closing minute at the whole year's scale, in its fixed words. It is a naming, not a new ceremony; the practice they have run all year, put in their own hand at the year's scale, and the private re-crossing the public Council needs:

> *"Before what comes next, take your closing minute at the whole year's scale. What did you meet this year? What do you carry back? What's different in you now - even a little? 'I don't know yet' is a real answer."*

For a learner staying on, this is their close between years, and then a real fallow stretch before the next year opens; the fallow day stays empty, and nothing is seated on it. For a leaving learner, it comes three weeks before the Launch, which sits in the third week of Open Waters, so that they cross the threshold already home in themselves.

The tail of the year: Open Waters

The flex tail runs May 6 to May 23, the three weeks after the Council closes on May 2. It is light structure, not a void, and it is not the Council's afterglow or its appeal; what the Council left unresolved stays unresolved here too. Four things live in it, and a fifth for some. Credit close-out, for anyone finishing the year's plan or the whole three years. Project finishing, for what the Bridge built. The relay handed on: the mentor is thanked, and that relationship either goes on, on its own terms and outside this building, or ends well, with the ending named rather than let lapse; and what you built with real people goes to whoever carries it next, or to nobody. And rest, which is a legitimate use of all three weeks; a year that ends in a public Council has earned it. Which mornings are guided in the tail is said before it starts, and no re-thread opens it: the year-scale closing minute already closed the year. Name it to families as intentional: flex plus fallow, not "we'll figure it out." On the last guided day, Thu May 23, say the summer's break words: the one adult is reachable all summer, 988 never closes, the guide is not reachable, the pathway stays live.

For a learner leaving, the Launch is in this stretch, in the third week, on a day set with each learner and their circle, never on a bell and never the last day, because the last day is when the calendar ends and a crossing is not hurried by a calendar; the first week is the Council's fallow. It is a crossing, not a close: the close already happened on the year-close day, and the Log already went out the door that day. The three weeks before it, for a leaving learner, are placement, not new work. Week 1: the Journey view read, alone or with the guide for company, in a walk-in; the credit close-out walked. Week 2: the next-step plan drafted in their own hand or voice, the guide witnessing; the Portrait begun, piece by piece; the circle named with the learner and its shape chosen - the full room, a small room, or one person; and by Thursday the learner's own Growth Record export verified in their hands. This is the gate, and it is checked here, not on the day; if it fails, the learner and the family hear it this week, and the date goes to a family only once it is true. Week 3: the rite told once more in words, the Mantle question named so it has been sat with and is not sprung, and no answer asked for; the gift chosen, or not; the room set; then the Launch, opened by a person, on its day. For a learner staying on, the cycle turns, and the bridge is one sentence: *"You know how to make the hard call. Next year is Origin again: who am I, now?"*

The Launch rite

For a leaving learner, and first of all for the founding tribe, the first ever to complete the full cycle, the Launch is a true rite of passage, built with the three movements every real threshold-crossing has. It is not a graduation that happens *to* you; it is a threshold you *cross through*. A person opens the rite, never the app, because a rite opened by a schedule happens to you; one opened by a person who knows you can be crossed through. The learner has read the whole of it in Part 1 and here before the day; nothing in it is sprung. It sits in the third week of Open Waters, on a day set

with the learner and their circle; the first week is the Council's fallow, and the gate is checked in the second. The Launch is a crossing, not a close: the closing minute was already run on the year-close day, and the grief in the first movement is neither de-roled nor closed with it.

Leaving - the un-belonging. The part everyone skips because it hurts, and skipping it is why so many graduations feel hollow. First, go back through the Growth Record together, in whatever form the learner takes it in, and arrive at where you have been; the Journey view is private, so reading it is the learner's invitation, alone or with the guide for company. Then the grief and the thanks. This is the real work of this part. The ending is named straight out - "this was your home; you are being released from it" - and it is allowed to be sad, held, and not rushed, with a real exit available. Do not use the de-roling move for this grief. De-roling steps you out of a role that was never you. Leaving home is stepping out of a self that truly was you. Never teach a young person to de-role their own real sorrow. For some, leaving here means leaving the steadiest place they have had, for somewhere not yet steady. That is allowed to be more than excitement; the guide holds it as a coach and routes what is bigger.

In between - the threshold, held. No longer a learner, not yet launched. Here the learner is given the Star Chart, the map of where they have been. It is given as a thing to carry over the threshold, not as a slide at a graduation, because this is the exact moment they must steer by it alone. There is a silence around it, and no one fills it; that silence is on purpose. Then the learner makes their next-step plan: their own plan for themselves, in their own hand or voice, with the guide as witness. It is not the studio's plan for them.

Coming in on the far side - the crossing, seen by your people, and a change in how they see you. This is the actual step into adulthood, witnessed by their people. The handoff comes first. The learner makes their Portrait export, piece by piece, and decides who sees it, and takes it. This part cannot be a ceremony over a placeholder, so the real export, in the learner's own hands, must exist before any real learner walks this rite. Then the learner decides what to do with the Mantle: keep it (this is who I am now) or leave it (it belonged to this place). Either choice is true; the choosing is the rite. Then they leave a gift for the room. Then the crossing itself: a doorway, or a line on the floor, that the learner crosses in whatever way they move, while their people watch, into a circle of adults who receive them as an adult and speak to them differently on the far side. The circle is made before the day, with the learner. It can hold their family, a mentor, the one adult outside the room, the adults of the tribe's families, the second adult who sat with us on the heavy days. If their own family is not in it, it is still a full circle, and if they would rather cross with one person than a crowd, it is the same crossing. A rite that does not change how your community sees you is a going-away party. This one changes it. A crossing not made costs nothing; the learner is still launched.

The empty exit. Then the Launch itself: the door closes and stays unlocked from the learner's side. No come-back nudge, ever, because the only proof the door was real is that it stays open from their side only; one nudge turns a launch into a subscription. No campaign to bring them back, no pull on former learners, nothing sold at the door. A launched learner who never returns is a success, not a loss. This is not negotiable under any future pressure.

Leaving a gift for the room

The rite is built around what the learner *takes*, but a threshold is also a community losing a member. So the launched learner leaves one small thing behind that is wholly theirs to give - a word to the next captain, a mark, their Vineyard-thing if they choose. The tribe marks the departure *as a tribe*, not the guide performing it at them - the threshold felt from both sides of the door. For the founding tribe, what they leave becomes the room's first inheritance, so each leaving adds to a line the next group inherits.

The learner with no family in the room is the one this day can let fall. "Crossing witnessed by your people" is the day it falls hardest. Name the tribe as *your people*, in advance and explicitly - the same inclusion floor the whole program holds, applied to the most tender day of all their years here.

What the learner leaves holding: the Growth Record (the backward face - their trail), the next-step plan (the forward face - their plan), and the Captain's Log (their private voice, always theirs, never read for assessment). And the practice they carry inside them - the settle, and the three fixed lines they can run on themselves at a kitchen table at 2 a.m. for the rest of their life.

The arc completes.

"We evoke - we never extract." The honesty is the gift; the container is the care. Held, this year can change a person. That is a hope, not a promise.